DHABA RUSH · GENRE RESEARCH

The core and the feel

What a hands-off idle tycoon is at its core, what its players look for, what they get today, five case studies, and a plan for Dhaba Rush. With all fourteen research notes.

Report and research notes
1 November 2026 · on game version 0.3.7
Little Tag Art Studios

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PART 1 · REPORT

Dhaba Rush: the core and the feel

Research report, 1 Nov 2026, on version 0.3.7. It answers four questions: what the core of this kind of game is, what its players look for, what they get today, and what the leading games teach. Section 6 turns the answers into a plan for Dhaba Rush.

How it was made. Seven research sweeps on the web, each fact-checked by a second agent, then three more sweeps on gaps a critic found: timed openings of today's leaders, games with seated service and waiters, and Indian players' own reviews. The notes are in research/, and section 8 lists them. Section 7 lists the claims that failed fact-checking. Nothing in the game was changed.

Market figures from Sensor Tower or AppMagic are third-party estimates. Player reviews are paraphrased here; the notes keep the originals with dates.

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1. The answer on one page

The core. A hands-off idle tycoon is a small machine the player watches and tunes. Customers flow through stations, money flows in, and the player's one real decision is which part of the machine to fix next. Four things surround that decision, and the genre cannot do without them: something affordable every minute or two early on, a place that visibly grows, money waiting when you come back, and a bigger next place once the current one is done. Everything else is decoration. (r1, r4, r5)

What players look for. Calm. Ads they choose, which always pay. One obvious next thing. A place to watch grow, with charm. Fair progress with no paywall. A reason to come back tomorrow. And, for the minority who optimise, a bottleneck to reason about. (r2, g3)

What they get today. Polished games whose first hour is good and whose shell fights the player: forced ads, pop-ups on launch, paid manager cards, walls that look like bugs, and the same restaurant again after the first hour. The leaders keep adding managers, weekly events and new locations. Nobody builds for India on purpose, and no dhaba idle game exists. (r3, r7, g3)

What the case studies teach.

- **Idle Supermarket Tycoon** (the reference): the opening Dhaba Rush copied is the part its players still call fun. What kept it alive for seven years came after the opening: new cities with income multipliers, permanent upgrades, events. Its 2026 rebuild put paid manager cards in front of upgrades, and its reviews collapsed. (r4, g2)
- **Eatventure**: the best-rated food idle game wins on trust (no forced ads), on play that needs no text, and on small arcs you finish and leave. (r5)
- **Idle Restaurant Tycoon**: the closest game to Dhaba Rush's seats-and-waiters twist. It made the bottleneck readable with a door counter. It lost players when guests walked out and the player had no way to prevent it, and when new content stopped. (r5, g1)
- **Pizza Ready and My Perfect Hotel**: the feel school. Everything is physical, something new arrives every one to three minutes, and the player does a chore briefly before hiring someone for it. Pizza Ready switched to staff carrying food to tables in Nov 2025. (r6, g1)
- **India's local hits** (Truck Masters, Indian Bikes Driving 3D, Bus Simulator India): players reward recognition, horns, real vehicles, their own state, offline play and small downloads. They punish ads that block play. Truck and bus sim players ask, unprompted, for a dhaba stop. (r7)

What Dhaba Rush must nail. The first three minutes already work, the twist is the right core, and the market is moving toward it. Three things stand between the game and the genre's core:

1. **There is no day loop.** New things stop at 35 to 50 minutes and goals at about 1 to 1.5 hours. Every leader hands the player a new place or a renovation by then. Without one, the soft-launch day-3 and day-7 numbers will measure the content wall, not the game.

2. **The twist doesn't yet read in the world.** Travellers walk out after 8 seconds even when the player could not have helped, which every seated-service game's reviews punish. Half of new players never get the seats lesson. Hires from the STAFF panel happen behind it, so the purchase that matters most is the one players see least.
3. **The ad plan breaks the calm.** Interstitials after purchases from session 4 match the exact pattern players describe when they uninstall, and India's ad rates make them worth little.

One precondition comes before all three: the game has never run on a phone. For Indian players, a game that won't start, loads slowly or eats data is the top reason for a 1-star review (g3). Every feel judgement in this report is unverified until it has.

The smallest day loop is a renovation, not a new map. All three syntheses and the case studies point the same way: a priced, locked "Family Dhaba" card shown from about minute 3, taken when the current content runs out, that keeps the player's place, adds an AC family hall and multiplies income (section 6.4).

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2. The core of the genre

2.1 The loop at four time scales

Scale	What happens	Dhaba Rush today
Seconds	Agents walk, wait on a timer, pay. Money pops. The player taps a station and buys.	Present and polished
Minutes	Costs race income. Something is always affordable. A red link in the chain says what to fix.	Present: the NEXT and PROBLEM chip
Session, 3 to 15 min	Collect what built up, spend it down, claim a task, bank one milestone, leave when the next thing is minutes away.	Present for about the first hour
Day and week	Capped offline money brings you back. A new place or a renovation multiplies income. A weekly event gives a reason to return.	Missing

Sources: r1 (Anthony Pecorella's idle-game maths; guides to Idle Supermarket Tycoon, Idle Miner Tycoon and Eatventure), g2.

2.2 The six parts that are the core

1. **The seesaw.** Costs rise faster than income, and multipliers at milestones pull income back ahead. Tuned well, something is always affordable in the first ten minutes, and a visible next goal arrives every three to five minutes. (r1)
2. **A bottleneck the player can see and fix.** Miner, elevator and warehouse in Idle Miner Tycoon. Department, checkout and parking in Idle Supermarket Tycoon. The chain is the game's only real decision. In Kolibri's playtests, players who never noticed the bottleneck quit, and on-screen prompts fixed it. (r1, r5)
3. **The place visibly grows.** Players praise upgrades that change the scene, and they call an upgrade that changes nothing visible a waste. (r2, r6)
4. **Doing becomes delegating.** Managers in Idle Miner Tycoon, staff in Pizza Ready. The fantasy is watching the business run itself. (r1)
5. **The day loop.** Capped offline earnings, a reason to return, and a reset or new location that multiplies income. When the content ends, players leave: Kolibri's first Idle Miner build lost players as soon as they finished it. (r1, r5)
6. **Calm.** No fail state, no timers, ads by choice, at most one pop-up on launch. This year's loudest complaints across every leader are pop-ups and ad density. (r1, r2)

2.3 What is decoration

The theme, the vehicles, day and night, music, the guide character, the dish names, the chest animation and the VIP pop-up styling. Decoration sells the game and makes it loved, but it cannot rescue a broken seesaw or an unreadable chain. For Dhaba Rush the theme matters more than usual, but mostly for installs. Recognition

dominates the 5-star reviews of Indian driving sims (section 5.5), yet in Indian reviews of idle games, India or Hindi themes come up in only 0.3% of reviews in either star band (g3). **The theme gets the install; the core earns the rating.**

A test from r1, worth using on every tester: **at minute 8, can they say what is slowing the dhaba down, what they will buy next, and what the dhaba will look like after?** If yes, the core is there.

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3. What players look for

Ranked from more than 30,000 store reviews across about fifteen games, Reddit threads and studio data (r2, g1, g3).

Rank	What they want	What they say, in short
1	Ads they choose, which always pay	Eatventure has been praised every year since 2022 for having no forced ads. A rewarded ad that pays nothing, crashes or reloads the game earns a 1-star review.
2	Any session length, with money waiting on return	Play five minutes or an hour without losing ground. Offline money feels like a gift.
3	A calm screen with one obvious next thing	Players count the pop-ups on launch and uninstall over icon clutter.
4	A place to watch grow, with charm	Watching the place grow is the most common 5-star theme, along with humour in upgrade names.
5	Fair progress, no paywall	Manager cards and research tokens that gate upgrades are this year's top 1-star cause in Codigames' games.
6	Upgrades that change what they see	An upgrade with no visible change reads as wasted money.
7	Always a next place or event	"Nothing else to do" and "I finished it, please update" end the game for many.
8	Something to think about	Optimisers want honest per-minute numbers and a bottleneck to solve, and call games without decisions shallow.
9	Their progress is never lost	One lost save or one reset update spends years of trust.
10	Honesty	The game should match its store ad, and updates should never take back what was earned.

Two kinds of player want opposite screens. Cosy players write most of the 5-star text. They want one next action, a quiet screen and life in the scene. Optimisers are loud in 2- and 3-star text. They want honest numbers, the bottleneck named, and cost against payoff for each upgrade. A screen can serve both by showing one next thing up front and the numbers one tap away. (r2)

Why players quit (r2, g2, g3):

When	Why
First session	Ads before trust. A wait in the first minutes. One confusing step. The game won't load on a cheap phone.
Day 1	The loop shrinks to open, spend, close. The second place looks like the first.
Week 1	Interstitials switch on "after a few days". The content runs out. A hard gate. A lost save.

The evidence splits on the top spot. Across the whole India-store sample, ads separate bad reviews from good ones most sharply. In the Hindi-locale reviews, "won't start or loads slowly" comes first. Both lead to the same fixes. (g3)

Indian players, in their own words (r7, g3). Hindi-locale reviews are the reliable Indian voice, because English reviews pulled from the Indian store are mostly foreign. Their top complaints in 1- to 3-star reviews: the game won't start or loads slowly, it eats data and MB, it doesn't match its ad, and the ads are too many or too long. Their praise: time-pass, fun, and playing without internet. The most-helpful review in the whole Indian sample

praises Pizza Ready for working offline. Requests for Hindi are rare, and most Hindi-locale reviewers write in Roman script. One Hindi reviewer of an idle game said they understood nothing because everything ran by itself. That is the testers' "hard to understand" in another form: without a stated job, "it plays itself" reads as confusion.

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4. What players get today

4.1 The market, Oct 2026

Game	Type	Google Play	How it extends play	Ads
Idle Supermarket Tycoon (Codigames)	Hands-off tycoon; Dhaba Rush's reference	4.1★, 10M+	First location ends in a guided move at 9 to 25 min. Since v4 (Feb 2026), paid manager cards gate upgrades.	Reviews report creeping ad density and some forced ads (Apr 2024, Mar 2026); none seen in 2026 gameplay videos
Eatventure (Lessmore, now Miniclip)	Hands-off, stage-based	4.7★, 50M+	60 cities of about 7 restaurants; renovate, then move; weekly events	Rewarded only
Idle Restaurant Tycoon (Kolibri)	Hands-off, seated service with waiters	4.5★, 5M+	Stars unlock new restaurants; weekly event restaurants; only bug fixes since 2023	Heavy rewarded placements
Pizza Ready! (Supercent)	Idle arcade with a joystick	4.4★, 100M+	Shop to shop; events; staff serve tables since Nov 2025	Interstitials, rewarded, banners; about 70% of revenue from ads
Idle Miner Tycoon (Kolibri)	Hands-off, three-link chain	4.5★, 100M+	Many mines, prestige, weekly event mines, season pass	About 8 optional ads per session
Roadside Empire, Travel Center Tycoon, Truck Stop Tycoon, Rest Stop Tycoon	Highway idle tycoons in US settings	100K+ to 10M+	Locations and events	Mixed; forced ads in several

Sources: r3, r4, r5, g2. Ratings read 31 Oct to 1 Nov 2026. Rest Stop Tycoon is by Highbrow of Chennai, the maker of Truck Masters: India.

4.2 Table stakes in late 2026

What the leaders shipped in 2025 and 2026 (r3, g1, g2):

- A manager or card layer on top of upgrades. Players accept it when it is earned in play and revolt when it is a paid gate.
- Weekly events, usually with a pass.
- Side systems: research, orders, pets, achievements.
- Staff who carry food to tables (Pizza Ready, Nov 2025).
- No ad before about three minutes of play (Supercent's stated rule).
- The same price ladder everywhere: Remove Ads, permanent ×2 income, a pass, a starter pack.

4.3 The gaps

- **Ad fatigue is the top complaint in every comparable game.** Ads come up in nearly half of the 1- to 3-star reviews in the India-store sample (g3).
- **Pop-ups on launch.** The same "UI confusing" signal Dhaba Rush's testers gave.
- **Walls that look like bugs**, such as Travel Center Tycoon's vault stuck at level 10 for two years.
- **Repetition after the first hour**: the same food in every city.
- **Western price ladders in rupees**, above ₹10,000 per item, in a market where ads are 70% of game revenue.
- **Nobody builds for India.** No Indian studio is in the top simulation charts. The India-themed idle games are tiny: Idle Indian Restaurant has 10K+ installs, Chaiwala Tycoon 5K+. The closest rival in mechanic, Rest Stop Tycoon, is a US-skinned highway stop with 100K+ installs. No dhaba idle game exists. (r3, r7)

The honest read on India: this is white space, not proven demand. Indians download the idle-tycoon loop at scale in foreign skins (Pizza Ready was a top-5 download in India in 2025), and Hindi reviewers read it as a small-business fantasy. No local-theme idle game has yet shown that the theme lifts it. (r7, g3)

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5. Case studies

5.1 Idle Supermarket Tycoon: the game Dhaba Rush copied

(r4, g2)

What it is. Codigames' 2019 hit, the most-downloaded strategy game in the US in May 2019 by the company's account. On it and three sister games, revenue went from €1.6M in 2018 to €71.8M in 2020. It then fell to about €20M by 2024, and the studio cut a fifth of its staff.

Seven things that make it work.

1. The machine is always visible, and you cannot lose money.
2. One sheet with three levers per department, and the next affordable thing is always obvious.
3. A stats screen flags the bottleneck in red.
4. Upgrades change how departments look.
5. Optional ad boosts double income rather than gate progress.
6. A long horizon from day one: the next city's price and multiplier.
7. City moves multiply income and keep unlocked building types, so a reset feels like a promotion. That is the rule for versions 1 to 3; version 4's carry-over is undocumented.

What its players wish it did better. Progress slows sharply after the tutorial. Prices jump between cities. Ads creep up and sometimes fail to pay. Timers were bolted onto instant actions. Paid manager cards arrived in 2026. Variety is thin.

The 2026 rebuild matters for Dhaba Rush. The 162-second video Dhaba Rush copied matches the current version 4: the task bar and the VIP ×2 pop-up at about 2:30 are version-4 beats. In that version, the copied opening is the first ten minutes of a small two-department town that ends in a guided move to a second supermarket, somewhere between 9 and 25 minutes in. About 26 minutes into play, paid manager cards start gating upgrades. In the Indian-store sample, English reviews since version 4 average below 2 stars. **Dhaba Rush copied the opening but not the promotion that follows it, and should never copy the card gate.**

Verdict on the copied three minutes: keep them. The hands-off loop with visible money, the three-lever sheet, the bottleneck readout, a first new counter inside the session, and the rewarded ad framed as a gift are the core. The guide character, the specific departments and the VIP styling are incidental. The warning from its reviews: the part that stays fun is the part Dhaba Rush copied. What bought Codigames seven more years came after it.

5.2 Eatventure: why it out-rates the reference

(r5, g2)

Lessmore, a German studio of three founders who made the art themselves, launched it in 2022. Miniclip bought the studio at the end of 2024, and it is now a team of about 33. By early 2025 it had about 69M downloads and $28M in purchases (AppMagic estimates). It rates 4.7★ on Play against Idle Supermarket Tycoon's 4.1★.

Why players rate it higher:

1. **The ad contract.** No forced ads, praised every year since 2022. The rewarded ad is a character: suited "investors" walk in among the customers.
2. **Small arcs you finish.** Each restaurant is renovated in place, from lemonade stand to food stand to food truck to café, and then the city is sold and you move on. A preview of the renovation appears at 3:00 and the first one lands at about 5:30. The typical complaint shifts from "nothing to do" (1 and 2 stars) to "repetitive" (3 and 4 stars).

3. **No text needed.** The studio's stated aim is visuals that tell the story without text. There is no guide character.
4. **A permanent layer that isn't sold as a gate**: gear, a vault of permanent perks, pets, clubs.
5. **A fixed weekly calendar**: a weekend event in a bigger restaurant and a mid-week race. A two-person team can copy the shape of that cycle, not its weekly pace.

Its weak spots are long dead stretches mid-city and the same dishes in every country. A dhaba game has a natural answer to the second: each highway stop gets its own regional menu.

5.3 Idle Restaurant Tycoon: the closest game to the twist

(r5, g1)

Kolibri built it in six months in 2020 as a deliberate move from Idle Miner Tycoon's three-link chain to linked bottlenecks. Hosts seat guests, cooks set speed, each waiter serves two tables, cleaners clear tables and parking brings guests. A door counter shows vacant tables, and an overview tab splits profit by area.

What its soft launch taught: many players got stuck at one early tutorial step, and most missed an ad placement that wasn't highlighted. Both were reworked and the numbers rose.

What its players punished:

- Guests walking out when a table frees a second later, or when the extra guests an ad brings find no seat. In hands-off games, walkouts are hated whenever the player had no way to prevent them. Walkouts are only praised in games where the player is the server (g1).
- Waiters who cannot be made faster.
- Bad pathing: waiters walking back to their station between tables, and a big table that never gets cleaned.
- Content that stopped: the same weekly events for months, then only bug fixes.

Players liked watching the staff scurry and the absence of pressure.

5.4 Pizza Ready and My Perfect Hotel: the feel school

(r6, g1)

Pizza Ready was the most-downloaded hybrid-casual game of 2025, with about 150M installs that year (Sensor Tower, via Supercent). India is its biggest market by downloads. About 70% of its revenue comes from ads.

A measured first session of My Perfect Hotel, SayGames' idle-arcade benchmark (ARPU Brothers, 2024):

Time	Beat
0:00	No tutorial. $50 at reception; the first room costs $30.
1:46	A cleaner unlocks
2:19	First rewarded ad, framed as a bag of cash
4:20	Cleaner hired
9:26	Automatic receptionist
11:29	Hotel level 1 complete

What makes the feel:

1. **Everything is physical.** Money is paper on the floor, food is a stack, and prices are a pad that drains.
2. **The player is the bottleneck, briefly.** A chore gets annoying around minute two or three, and the hire appears just then.
3. **Something new every one to three minutes** for the first twelve minutes.
4. **Automate the pain, keep the pleasure.** Staff take the chores; the player keeps collecting the cash.
5. **Rewards that change how you play**, such as a skin or a guest who drops a trail of money, not only a bigger number.
6. **An instant start**, with arrows instead of text.

7. **Many small confirmations every second**: a sound, a pop and a particle for every pickup, drop, payment and hire.

What its players hate: ads (Hindi reviewers describe ads every few seconds) and the content ceiling, where players max out the last shop and find nothing after it.

The waiter change. In Nov 2025 Pizza Ready replaced self-service pickup with a service table where staff deliver the food. A scan of 5,401 reviews found no praise and no backlash: players noticed ads, not who carried the food. That validates Dhaba Rush's twist as natural. It also means the twist alone is not a selling point. How well it reads and feels is.

5.5 India's local-theme hits

(r7, g3)

Game	Installs	Note
Indian Bikes Driving 3D	100M+	169 MB; praised as offline and light on storage
Bus Simulator Indonesia / Bus Simulator India (Maleo)	100M+ / 10M+	"Iconic Indian horn sounds"; players ask for their own state
Truck Masters: India (Highbrow)	10M+	598 MB; sells desi pressure horns; ads gate jobs
Masala Express, Indian Cooking Star	10M+ each	Indian cooking, time-management

What Indian players reward:

- **Recognition.** Words like real, Indian and desi appear in 75% of Bus Simulator India's 4- and 5-star reviews, against 43% of its 1- to 3-star ones.
- **Horns** as a signature sound, real vehicles, and "add my state".
- **Pride.** Players address the Indian developer by name.
- **The business fantasy.** Hindi reviewers recommend Pizza Ready to anyone who runs a business.
- **A dhaba stop.** Truck and bus sim players ask for one without being prompted. Drivers call a dhaba a "hotel".

What they punish: ads that block the core loop; a Remove Ads purchase that still shows ads; "offline" games that need data; heat and lag on cheap phones; shallow or wrong authenticity, such as the wrong region's dish, identical towns or empty streets; and store ads that don't match the game.

The recognition figures come from driving sims, not idle games, so treat them as a guide to what earns installs.

Dhaba Rush is well placed on the practical side, but that is expected, not a selling point. Its release download is about 34 MB, and only ads and analytics need a connection. Size is hygiene: hits of 169 to 929 MB still reach 10M+ when players want them. Offline play, though, is praised by name. The authenticity checklist in r7 section 6 lists the details Indian players will notice.

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6. Dhaba Rush: the core and the feel to nail

6.1 The core promise

> You own a busy Indian highway dhaba. Lorries pull in, travellers sit on charpais, waiters run trays and the galla keeps ringing. Your job is to spot what is holding the line up, fix it with a tap, and grow a chai stall into the most famous stop on the highway.

The feel in one line: busy but never stressful, and every rupee you spend shows up in the dhaba.

6.2 Where it stands

What already works (p0):

- **The first three minutes are tight and measured.** A sale at 0:37, a hire at about 1:10, and both twist lessons opened by a visible problem and closed in two taps.
- **The NEXT and PROBLEM chip** turns a confusing simulation into one sentence and one tap.
- **The numbers are honest.** "/min" is real takings, and every hire shows before and after.
- **The world reads as a dhaba**: whole orders on trays, lorries reversing into bays, fairy lights, harmonium and tabla, four Indian horns.
- **Purchase juice is in** and costs almost nothing on low-end settings.
- **The in-world hire card** for a waiter or a table already buys in two taps and pops the purchase in where the player is looking.
- **The build is small and works offline.**

What breaks the core or the feel (p0, checked against the research and the code):

Problem	Why it matters	Evidence
No day loop: new things stop at 35 to 50 min, goals at about 1 to 1.5 h	This is exactly where every leader hands the player a new place, and where Kolibri's first build lost its players	r1, r5, g2
Travellers walk out after 8 s at the door	Walkouts the player could not prevent are the top complaint about seated service in idle games	g1
The seats lesson fires in only 3 of 6 test runs	Half of new players never learn the second bottleneck	v3-architecture.md, g1
Hires made in the full-screen STAFF panel happen behind it	The most valuable purchase gets the least visible feedback. The tutorial and the NEXT chip both send players to STAFF.	p0, code, g1
The twist stops being the decision after about minute 15	Waiters, tables and cashiers all hit hard caps (3, 5 and 2), arrivals cap at 19.5 a minute, and throughput levels off near 17 a minute once the kadai is built. After that, growth comes only from raising prices, a few percent per tap.	p0, s_design-first
Interstitials after purchases from session 4, 60 s apart	Matches the "after a few days the ads started" uninstall pattern, and earns little at India's ad rates	r2, r3, r5, g3
Never run on a phone	Feel, heat, touch and sound are all unverified	p0
Chai's LEVEL UP gain drops from ₹0.70 to about ₹0.26 a cup at Lv 25, for about the same cost	The button the tutorial teaches pays a third as much per tap afterwards. The ×1.3 milestone and the new dish soften it.	economy_v3.json

6.3 Feel targets

Moments a tester or a test bot can check. The "Today" column comes from p0 and the code.

Moment	Target	Today	Source
A traveller walks in	Within 5 s of launch	Yes	r6
First sale, with the cash burst	By 0:40	0:37	r4
First purchase	By 1:00	About 0:45	r1
Something new to buy or see	Every 1 to 3 min for the first 12 min	Yes with ads. Without ads the kadai slips from about 13 to about 17 min	r6, p0
Every purchase changes something in the world	Within 1 s, where the player is looking	Yes, except hires in the STAFF panel	r2, r6, g1
The right purchase feels biggest	A waiter or table purchase gets more feedback than a LEVEL UP	No	p0, g1
The bottleneck shows without a panel	Plates stacking on the pass, a line at the gate, a queue at the galla	Partly	r1, g1
The minute-8 test	A tester can say what slows the dhaba, what they will buy next, and what it will look like after	Untested	r1

Moment	Target	Today	Source
The first place is finished and promoted	10 to 25 min (Idle Supermarket Tycoon) to days (Eatventure)	Never	g2
The next place is visible early	A priced, locked card from about minute 3	No	g2
Session 1	No interstitials, at most one offer	Yes	r3
Sessions 4 and later	No interstitials during the soft launch	One after a purchase, 60 s apart	r5, g3
Coming back	Money waiting, one pop-up, one tap to collect	Nothing under 10 min away, then ¼ rate	r5
It sounds Indian	A horn, a tandoor slap and a chai pour within 30 s	Yes	r7
It feels desi	Unprompted, a tester calls it "real" or "desi", or names a detail: the horn, the tandoor, the charpai	Untested	r7, s_market-first
It runs on a 3 GB phone	30 fps and no heat complaints over 20 min	Not measured	r7

6.4 Keep, fix, add, cut

Each group is in priority order. "Smallest version" is the least work that delivers the point.

Keep

Item	Why
The first three minutes	Measured and tight; the reference's own reviews call the opening the fun part (r4)
The seats-and-waiters twist	It is the genre's core decision, made physical. Idle Restaurant Tycoon proved the structure, and Pizza Ready moved toward it (r5, g1)
The NEXT and PROBLEM chip	The genre's red-flag readout in one line; Kolibri stopped quits with on-screen prompts (r1, r5)
Honest numbers	Optimisers judge games by them (r2)
Rewarded ads only in session 1, free cash first, the VIP offer at most once a session from session 2	Matches Supercent's three-minute rule and Eatventure's ad contract (r3, r5)
The in-world 2-tap hire card	The right way to buy the right thing (g1, r6)
The small, offline build	Offline play is praised by name; small size avoids "MB" complaints (r7, g3)
The Indian sound and detail	Recognition is what Indian players praise most (r7)

Fix before the closed test

#	Fix	Smallest version	Evidence
1	Run it on a phone	One build on one 3 to 4 GB Vivo, Redmi or Realme on Android 10 to 12. Record download size, time from icon tap to first sale, frame rate, heat after 20 minutes, and one full session in airplane mode. The phone test sheet in docs/launch/phone-test.md covers most of it.	p0, r7, g3
2	Turn interstitials off for the closed test and the soft launch	Set `interstitials_enabled=false` in `config/monetization.cfg`. Read retention first; PLAN.md already says not to read ad revenue in India. If they return later: never within 60 s of a purchase, hire or reward, never on the return screen, at most one every 3 to 5 minutes.	r2, r3, r5, g3
3	Make waiting at the door lossless, or slow and readable	Travellers in the door line wait for a seat, and when the line is full, arriving vehicles drive past. Or raise the give-up time from 8 s to 20 to 30 s and show a ring over each head. Show the cost as "+₹X/min with one more table", not a red tally.	g1
4	Make the seats lesson fire every time	Bring in extra arrivals so the door line always forms during the tutorial	g1, v3-architecture.md

#	Fix	Smallest version	Evidence
5	Show every hire where it happens	Send the tutorial's waiter lesson and the NEXT chip's "hire a waiter" to the in-world card, shown over the plates waiting on the pass. Or close STAFF after a hire and show the new waiter taking the oldest plate, with "/min" rising within 2 to 3 s.	g1, r6
6	Show seat capacity in the world	A "Seats 6/8" board at the gate. Plates stacking on the pass already show a waiter shortage.	r5, g1
7	Say when a purchase won't help	On SPEED, COOKS and LEVEL UP, when the counter isn't the bottleneck, show "Not the bottleneck now" next to the honest number, and put the banner's fix button first	s_design-first, s_player-first, r2
8	Audit waiter pathing	No walk back to an idle spot between ready orders; nearest table first	g1
9	Ads must always pay	Grant the reward if the ad crashes after it finishes. Hide the bubble when no ad is loaded or the phone is offline. Block the rummy, real-money gaming and dating ad categories in AdMob.	r2, g3
10	Words that could read as real money	Reword Munshi-ji's "a company pays us to show its ads" and check task texts such as "Earn ₹1,000". Use "bonus" and "collect".	g3
11	Price for India	Remove Ads at ₹99 to ₹149, removing every interstitial, with the listing saying plainly that optional rewarded bubbles stay. A one-time starter at ₹10 to ₹99. Label both "one-time, forever", and make no more offers after any purchase. VIP stays at ₹299.	r7, g3, r2
12	Soften chai's LEVEL UP drop at Lv 25	Ramp chai's price step down between the end of the tutorial (about Lv 12) and Lv 25 instead of switching at 25, so the tutorial still matches the reference. Check it in `tools/sim/pacing_v3.py` first.	p0, r1, s_design-first

Add

#	Add	Smallest version	When	Evidence
13	A renovation: the first day loop	A locked, priced "Family Dhaba" card in BUILD from about minute 3, with a before-and-after picture. The player may take it when the current content runs out (35 to 50 min), never forced. Counter levels, staff and tables reset. Unlocked dishes and a permanent income multiplier carry over. The new look adds an AC family hall with seats far from the pass, so waiters and seats become the puzzle again. Show exactly what carries over before the player commits, because resets read as loss otherwise.	Before the soft launch if the schedule allows, otherwise the first update	r1, r4, r5, g2, r7, all three syntheses
14	A daily reason to return	"Aaj ka special": one dish sells at double price for 24 hours, announced on return. A regular trucker who comes once a day with a big bill, or a daily crate with fixed contents and no random draw, would do the same job.	Before the soft launch	g2, r5, s_design-first
15	An honest store listing	English first with Hinglish, "apna dhaba" framing, screenshots and video of real play, and Hindi search terms such as "बिज़नेस गेम", "dhaba game" and "dukan wala game"	Before the soft launch	g3, r7
16	Life in the scene	Two or three seated idle animations (sipping, napping on a charpai, on the phone) and two more traveller types, such as a trucker and a family. A new dish shows up on trays and tables for the next few orders. Munshi-ji reacts to the player's own fixes in short Hinglish lines, so guidance feels less like a treadmill.	First update	r2, r7, p0, s_player-first
17	A second dhaba on a new highway	The same four counters with a regional menu and palette, such as Rajasthan or the GT Road. The carry-over is shown before the move.	First update	r5, r7
18	A bigger tray for waiters	At waiter milestones, one more plate per trip, visible on the tray	First update	g1
19	A weekly event	A weekend catering job, such as a wedding or a mela, with its own goal track and one permanent reward. Copy Eatventure's fixed weekly cycle, not its pace.	After the soft launch	r3, r5
20	Earned delegation	A head waiter, or Munshi-ji, taking over a chore. Earned through play with visible progress, never sold as a gate.	After the soft launch	r1, r5, g2

Cut, or never add

Item	Why
The red LOST count, once waiting is lossless	Stress with nothing to act on (g1)
The "after every purchase" interstitial trigger	The pattern players describe when they uninstall (r2)
Paid manager cards, research tokens, timers on instant actions	The 2026 backlash against Idle Supermarket Tycoon and Idle Theme Park Tycoon (r4, g2)
Offer pop-ups on launch, and offers to VIP buyers	The top complaint about the shell (r2, g3)
A premium currency with nothing to spend it on	Keep Sikke hidden until there is something to buy (p0)
Store or ad copy that suggests real earnings	Confuses Indian players used to real-money games (g3)
New links in the chain: cleaners, wages, staff who quit	Idle Restaurant Tycoon's most-hated parts (g1)
Ad boosts that bring more travellers than there are free seats	Reviewers of Idle Supermarket Tycoon (2024) and Idle Restaurant Tycoon say those extra guests walk straight out, wasting the ad (g1, g3)
Store ads showing real brands or play that isn't in the game; data-indexing SDKs	"Not like the ad" is 5.1% of Hindi 1- to 3-star reviews (g3, r6)
Any waiter who reads as a boy ("chhotu")	A child-labour reading Indian players will notice (r7). The `chotu` model is still a fallback in the waiter model list in `scripts/v3/world/waiter.gd`; check that no hired waiter looks like a child.

6.5 Three risks and how to test each

Risk	What to measure	How to test with the closed-test players
The content wall, not the game, decides day 3 and day 7	The minute each player reaches the kadai, the last dish and the end of the NEXT chip ladder. Split day-1 return by whether they got there.	Analytics already logs milestones. On day 3, ask every tester who stopped why they stopped. For scale: GameAnalytics' 2026 day-1 median is about 22% and its top tenth about 40% (r3).
The twist stays hard to read	NEXT chip taps against panel opens; travellers lost in the first 10 min	Ask the minute-8 questions at minute 3 and minute 8 with five fresh testers
It feels bad on a real phone	Cold start, frame rate and heat on a 3 to 4 GB phone over 20 min	The phone test sheet in docs/launch/phone-test.md, plus a 20-minute heat check

Recruit testers who look like the market: Android, mostly outside the big cities, and both men and women, with one 2 GB phone if you can find one. Sources disagree on gender: Lumikai counts 44 to 45% of India's gamers as women, while Sensor Tower's download data is 86% male (r2, r3).

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7. Claims that failed fact-checking

A second agent checked each sweep. These claims were wrong or out of date. The report above uses the corrections.

- Idle Supermarket Tycoon's managers arrived with version 4 in Feb 2026, not mid-2026, and players read them as a paywall, not as a welcome feature.
- The 2019 to 2020 guides describe its versions 1 to 3. Version 4 removed the money trucks and reshaped the first location.
- Its Google Play price range is $0.99 to $99.99 in the US and ₹89 to ₹8,900 in India, not up to $129.99.
- Pizza Ready's 221M download figure is old. Supercent cites about 400M lifetime installs by Dec 2025.
- The 1.07 cost growth in Pecorella's article is AdVenture Capitalist's lemonade stand, not a universal rate.

- That optional ads are the genre's single most-praised feature is unmeasured. Ads and paywalls are the two leading themes of 1- and 2-star reviews.
- The Indian RAM figures date from 2021, and a 2026 memory-price squeeze has sharply cut entry-level phone shipments. Mobile data plans moved too: ₹349 now buys 2 GB a day for 28 days.
- Eatventure's dates: stackable boosts shipped in Feb 2026 and the Potion Shop in Mar 2025.
- Lessmore is now owned by Miniclip, so its 2022 description as three founders is dated.

Two estimates stay disputed. India's rewarded-ad rate per thousand views ranges from about $0.10 to $2.43 depending on the source. Pizza Ready's India rank in Q1 2026 differs between Tech2 and Sensor Tower.

Where the three syntheses disagreed, and how this report settled it. A judge agent scored the syntheses (design-first 34 of 40, market-first 33, player-first 30) and checked them against the notes.

- **What to fix first.** The phone test comes first, because won't-start is the top Hindi complaint and every other test needs a real device.
- **When to show the renovation.** From about minute 3, as Idle Supermarket Tycoon and Eatventure show their next step.
- **What a renovation resets.** Reset levels, staff and tables, but carry dishes and a multiplier over and show it beforehand. The new layout is what keeps the twist alive after the plateau.
- **How much the theme matters.** For installs a lot, for ratings little (section 2.3).
- **Whether size is an edge.** No. It is expected; offline play is the part players praise.
- **LEVEL UP after the tutorial.** Fix the curve itself, not only its label.

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8. Research notes

All in research/. The raw review downloads behind g1 and g3 stayed in the session scratchpad and were not copied.

File	What it covers
p0_dhaba_rush_today.md	Dhaba Rush 0.3.7 as it is: the loop, the first 10 minutes, every system, the economy, the feel, the gaps
r1_genre_anatomy.md	Genre anatomy: loops, psychology, structure, vocabulary, core against decoration
r2_player_motivations.md	What players praise and hate, why they quit, cosy players against optimisers
r3_market_2026.md	Market snapshot, Oct 2026: leaders, trends, a feature matrix, benchmarks
r4_case_idle_supermarket_tycoon.md	Case study: Idle Supermarket Tycoon
r5_case_eatventure_kolibri.md	Case study: Eatventure and Idle Restaurant Tycoon, and Kolibri's design rules
r6_case_pizza_ready_feel.md	Case study: Pizza Ready and My Perfect Hotel, and twelve feel techniques
r7_india_players_local_theme.md	Indian players and local-theme hits, with a desi authenticity checklist
g1_seated_service_waiters_tables.md	How other games handle seats and waiters, and what players think of it
g2_timed_teardown_minute3_to_day3.md	Timed teardown of minute 3 to day 3 of today's leaders
g3_indian_players_idle_reviews.md	Indian players of idle tycoons, from Hindi-locale reviews
s_player-first.md, s_design-first.md, s_market-first.md	Three independent syntheses of all the notes, from the player's, the designer's and the market's point of view

PART 2

Research notes

The fourteen notes behind the report, as the research agents wrote them on 31 October and 1 November 2026. Each note labels its facts as measured, estimated, reviews, opinion or inference, and ends with its sources.

Read the notes with the report's corrections. A second agent fact-checked every note. Claims that failed are listed in section 7 of the report, and those corrections win over the notes. Player reviews are quoted in the notes as the agents found them; the report paraphrases them.

The raw review downloads behind notes I and K stayed in the session scratchpad and are not included.

Dhaba Rush today (v0.3.7, code 307): what the game IS

Written 2026-10-31 from `/Users/almeer/Documents/HighwayDhaba` (paths below are relative). Money is quoted as the screen shows it: data stores "reference units" and the UI multiplies by 10 (`data/economy_v3.json` `money_display_scale`), so the first chai is ₹10 and start cash ₹1,000. "After the tutorial" means minutes after the ~3-minute tutorial ends, as every pacing figure in the project is quoted.

1. The core loop, as a player lives it

You own a walled roadside dhaba seen from a diagonal isometric camera. Lorries, cars and autos reverse into four bays across the highway and a bus drops riders at a shelter; they cross a zebra crossing, enter the gate and take the nearest free charpai seat (a table set is a low table plus two charpais, four seats). Each seated traveller orders one drink and, once a dish counter exists, one dish; a cook brews each ticket on a radial timer and sets it on the counter's pass; a waiter carries the whole order on a tray to the table; the traveller eats 3 s, pays at the shortest cash counter ("galla") in a burst of banknotes and a green floating number, and walks back to the vehicle, which honks and leaves. You never serve anyone. You tap to spend: a counter opens a sheet with COOKS / LEVEL UP / SPEED; STAFF holds waiters, cashiers and cooks; BUILD holds the next counter (chai → tandoor → lassi → kadai) and tables; task cards and a wall-ad bubble pay cash. A NEXT chip always names one goal or one problem ("PROBLEM · 3 WAITING / Seats full · Build a table"). Money comes in by itself and faster as you remove whichever bottleneck is slowest: seats, waiters, cashiers or cooks. Away more than 10 minutes, you return to a WELCOME BACK payout. (`docs/v3-architecture.md` seated-dhaba addendum; `docs/reference-match-spec.md` §1, §3.)

2. The first 10 minutes, beat by beat

Seconds from first launch, from `STEP_ORDER` in `scripts/v3/tutorial/director.gd`, the lines in `scripts/v3/tutorial/script_lines.gd`, the timed shots in `docs/round2/after_step2/` and the reference targets in `docs/reference-match-spec.md` §7. The tutorial ends at 166 s on autopilot (172–185 s in integrated runs).

- **0:00** The dhaba is already built: cook Pinky, cashier Munna, waiter Raju, two table sets, a lorry across the road. Munshi-ji, the accountant guide, rises with a namaste: "Namaste, boss! I'm Munshi-ji, your manager. Our dhaba is open!" The only HUD is an empty money pill.
- **0:10–0:19** The camera follows the first traveller across the crossing to a seat. Pinky's timer pops and the sim pauses for a line about Pinky the cook and Raju the waiter.
- **0:19–0:37** The camera follows Raju to the table, then the traveller to the galla (paused line). **First sale ~0:37**: cash burst, the pill shows 1,010. "First sale! Your cash is up here, top left."
- **0:40–0:51** "Let's earn more per cup. Tap the CHAI COUNTER." The sheet opens, "/min" appears, the hand sits on LEVEL UP until **Lv 10** (`walk_01_t0050`).
- **0:57–1:15** A queue of five at the galla. "Oh no! The line at the CASH COUNTER is too long." / "Tap the CASH COUNTER and HIRE a second cashier." Cash is floored to ₹1,000 visibly, HIRE ₹500 → Bablu; the STAFF button bursts into the HUD ("All your staff are in STAFF").
- **1:25–1:35 (the twist, taught by doing)** Plates wait on the pass with orange rings (`walk_05_t0085`): "Food is waiting! Raju can't carry it all." / "Tap STAFF and HIRE a second waiter." → ₹400 → Shambhu pops in.
- **1:35** Free step; the NEXT chip appears ("NEXT: TANDOOR · Save … / 2,000"). From ~1:30 there is never a moment without a goal.

- **1:59** "Pour 20 cups of chai" completes (₹480); the one-card task strip drops in with a "Task done! Tap CLAIM" chip.
- **2:29–2:35 (second twist beat)** A door line forms: "Every seat is taken, and travellers are leaving!" / "Tap the new TABLE: four more seats." → the ghost table's tag → a 2-tap card, BUILD TABLE ₹300. If no door line forms in time the Director injects arrivals or skips the beat.
- **2:33–2:50** Undimmed: "Good news: a company pays us to show its ads!" A bubble "1,000" fades in on the painted-ad wall with a 12 s countdown; tap → FREE CASH popup (the ₹299 VIP half hidden in the tutorial) → FREE → reward burst, bills unspool into the pill, +₹1,000 counted up.
- **2:53–3:05** "We can afford a TANDOOR now. Tap BUILD." → TANDOOR ₹2,000 → it pops into the back-right corner with dust, ring and sparkles; camera home.
- **3:07** "Roti + chai = a bigger bill! Next goal: a LASSI counter." Done; a one-time "Drag to look around · pinch to zoom" hint follows.

Free play to minute 10 (`docs/round2/economy-proposal.md` §6–7, `docs/softlaunch/polish.md`, the checklist's flow track):

- Start: ~₹35, chai Lv 10–12, one tandoor cook, 2 cashiers, 2 waiters, 3 tables, ~₹500/min; every order is chai + roti.
- The chip's priorities (`scripts/v3/ui/next_chip.gd` `evaluate()`): a PROBLEM first (door line ≥ 4 s with tables left; food waiting → "Hire a waiter"; bill line ≥ 3 → "Upgrade a cashier"), then the next build's waiter gate, "build ready", "Save x / y" with a bar, and, while the next counter costs over 4 minutes of takings, an interim goal ("NEXT: COFFEE / LEVEL UP CHAI · 12/25"). Cards come one at a time: "Earn ₹1,000" (₹530), build tandoor, hire waiter 2, table 3, cashier 1 to Lv 5, build the lassi… (`tasks.sequence`).
- **~5:40 from launch (2:34 after the tutorial, with ads):** the lassi (₹1,700, needs 2 waiters) is affordable; Munshi-ji flies to its cyan ghost pad: "We can afford a LASSI counter! Tap BUILD." (`walk_20_t0340`). The bill per traveller rises ~48 %; the chip becomes "HIRE WAITER 3 · Save … / 1,200" (the kadai needs three).
- **~7:00** tandoor Lv 25 → NAAN and chai Lv 25 → COFFEE: squash, confetti, a NEW ON THE MENU card, a prop on the counter, "Pinky, our chai cook, now makes Coffee. Chai prices rise!" The first free-play ad bubble comes 2 min after the tutorial, then every 4 min, one minute of takings each (min ₹500), ≤ 10 a session.
- **~8:45** lassi Lv 25 → CHAAS; **~9:15** tandoor Lv 50 → KEEMA PARATHA.
- **~10:00** the screen-only bot has 5 dishes and ₹1,947/min; a no-ads player about 3. The kadai (₹10,000, 3 waiters) lands at ~12:40 with ads, 15–17 min without, and brings STATS to the HUD.

3. Every system and what it does

- **Stations and menus** (`stations`; `docs/v3-station-menus.md` §1): Chai (start; ₹10, 2.0 s), Tandoor (₹2,000; ₹20, 4.0 s), Lassi (₹1,700, needs tandoor + 2 waiters; ₹50, 2.5 s), Kadai (₹10,000, needs lassi + 3 waiters; ₹150, 4.0 s). Dish 1 from the start, dishes 2–4 at Lv 25/50/100: chai → coffee → green tea → kesar doodh; roti → naan → keema paratha → Amritsari kulcha; lassi → chaas → mango lassi → Patiala lassi; egg bhurji → dal makhani → kadai paneer → Pindi chole. The newest dish is ordered 40 % of the time; raw factors are normalised so a station's mean bill and brew time never move at an unlock, while every displayed price still rises (milestone ×1.3). The sheet (`14_sheet_chai_beginner.png`): a product card ("DIESEL CHAI – Thick, dark and strong enough to jump-start a truck"), a level bar to the next dish, "Sells for ₹17.70 a cup", a bottleneck banner ("Cashiers can't keep up · HIRE CASHIER ›"), and COOKS (+1, max 3, ₹100 ×6) / LEVEL UP (+₹0.70 a cup, ₹25 × 1.02^L, hold to repeat) / SPEED (2.00 → 1.95 s, ₹100 × 1.2, max 30).
- **Orders** (`orders`): one drink (chai or lassi) then one dish once a dish counter exists, rolled when the traveller sits; each cook brews one ticket at a time.
- **Waiters** (`waiters`; `scripts/v3/world/waiter.gd`): Raju, Shambhu, Lakhan; start 1, max 3; ₹400 / ₹1,200; levels ₹60 × 1.2 for ×1.05 speed; walk 1.65× a traveller. Dispatch sends a waiter when the whole order will be ready as he reaches the passes; a chai + roti loop measures ~5.5 s.
- **Seats** (`seating`): 2 table sets, max 5 (20 seats), ₹300 / ₹750 / ₹1,800 then ×2.4; a door line of up to 4 who give up after 8 s ("No seat!", LOST). The next table is a cyan ghost with a "+ TABLE" tag and a 2-tap card.

- **Gallas** (`galla`): Munna and Bablu, max 2; 5.0 s ÷1.02 per level (₹40 / ₹100 × 1.2); galla 2 ₹500. Payment = the sum of prices locked when each item was cooked; VIP doubles it.
- **STAFF panel:** waiters, cashiers, cooks; HIRE first with a what-if ("Food waits 12 s now. With 3 waiters: about 7 s.", an M/M/c estimate in `scripts/autoload/game.gd` `preview_hire`); a red "!" when an order visibly waits or the bill line is long, a green "+" when the best hire is affordable.
- **BUILD panel:** a row per counter with a lock reason ("AFTER TANDOOR", "NEEDS 3 WAITERS") and a MENU line; a TABLES row; STATS inside it until the kadai.
- **Tasks and chest** (`tasks`): one card shown at a time ("1/3"); a 36-card sequence, then generated cards (earn / serve / serve-a-dish / level / seat / cashier / waiter / table) paying 0.25 min of real takings (min ₹200) after four fixed ones; a done card turns gold "CLAIM ₹700"; tapping an unfinished card opens the panel that does it. Every 10 claims the chest pays 1.5 min (+10 hidden sikke); the chest icon appears at the 3rd claim.
- **Ad bubble and VIP** (`ad_bubble`, `scripts/v3/ui/vip_popup.gd`): a bubble on the painted-ad wall, 12 s countdown, 2 min after launch/resume then every 4 min, ≤ 10 a session, 1 min of takings (no VIP). Session 1: FREE CASH; from session 2, once a session, the VIP OFFER ("PERMANENT UPGRADE ×2 ALL INCOME · UNLOCK ₹299" over a green FREE). Interstitials from session 4, 0.6 s after an upgrade, capped in `scripts/autoload/ads.gd`, never with Remove Ads (`docs/launch/sdk.md`).
- **Offline** (`offline`): nothing under 10 min away; then ¼ of the real rate for up to 2 h; the ×2 ad only after 30 min away; COLLECT is always the main button.
- **Day/night** (`scripts/v3/world/day_night.gd`): a 600 s cycle, frozen at midday in the tutorial; at night fairy lights ×3, fire glows at the stoves, headlight beams, lorries ×2.4, fuller buses, music −4 dB with a low-pass, crickets.
- **NEXT chip:** one line in the old Sikke slot, red for a PROBLEM; a tap opens the fixing panel with a coach hand for the first two uses; after the kadai an endless ladder (next table → affordable hire → nearest locked dish → hire → cheapest SPEED → milestone 150–300), each goal held ≥ 15 s.
- **Stats (HISAAB)** (`scripts/v3/ui/daftar.gd`): ten colour-coded rows (earning per traveller, serving capacity, truck parking, food wait, top dish, cashier line and wait, seats full, lost) plus a card per counter.
- **Munshi-ji notes** (`munshi_notes.gd`): once-only calm-moment lines: "We can afford a LASSI/KADAI... Tap BUILD" (camera fly and return), "Lassi needs 2 waiters. Tap STAFF and HIRE one.", one dish line per station, "New prices!" for migrated saves, the drag hint.
- **Hidden** (`FEATURES` in `game.gd`): managers, medals, shop, Sikke counter. Settings cover music, sound, vibration, EN/HI, graphics, number format, Remove Ads and analytics consent.

4. The twist versus the reference, and where money comes from

The reference (`docs/reference-match-spec.md` §1–3), Codigames' Idle Supermarket Tycoon: a customer walks to a counter, is served on the spot, queues at a checkout, pays, leaves. Income = Σ price × 60 / processing per department, capped by checkouts; the levers are price, staff, speed, cashiers.

Dhaba Rush keeps the UI shell and the first 3 minutes 1:1, but the simulation differs in four ways (`docs/v3-architecture.md` addenda of 2026-10-20/21/22):

1. **Seats.** Capacity is seats ÷ (1.5 s sit-down + food wait + 3 s eat + walk). Full seats mean a door line and losses after 8 s. Tables are a purchase the reference lacks.
2. **Waiters and whole-order trips.** Nothing reaches a customer until a waiter carries it. One waiter tops out near 9–10 orders/min with two passes 5 m apart; the lassi and kadai are gated behind 2 and 3 waiters because the sim collapses otherwise (QA: lost travellers 12 → 38 per 36 runs when the lassi was built on one waiter).
3. **Vehicles and the bus stop.** Arrivals are not a free spawn rate: lorries, cars and autos take one of four bays and dwell ~22 s; buses drop 3–6 riders and collect them. An arrival ramp sets target travellers/min to the slowest of waiters, seats, kitchen and gallas (floor 5, cap 19.5), eased over 10 s, minus a backlog. The road delivers what the dhaba can take: the queue you see is the bottleneck you have.

4. **Money follows throughput, not capacity.** The HUD "/min" is `takings_estimate_per_min()` on the live ramp (`game.gd` RATE_MODE "estimate", decision D4), not the reference's Σ capacity. A LEVEL UP raises income by its price share; SPEED or a cook on a counter that is not the limit shows ~+0; a waiter or a table, when they are the limit, is the real multiplier. Measured: 1 waiter + tandoor ~9.3/min; 2 waiters / 3 tables ~12.6; 3 waiters / 5 tables ~12.7 until a second tandoor cook; + kadai ~17; everything Lv 100 16.5–17.5/min. The reference runs ~18/min on 2 cashiers and never hits anything physical.

The reference is a numbers game dressed as a shop; Dhaba Rush is a small logistics puzzle (who is standing still, and why) dressed as the same numbers game. That is its charm and the root of the "hard to understand" feedback.

5. The economy shape

(`data/economy_v3.json`; `docs/round2/economy-proposal.md` §5–7; `docs/v3-station-menus.md` §4.)

- **Start:** ₹1,000, 30 hidden Sikke; the tutorial floors cash before the cashier hire and tops up for the waiter and table beats. Tutorial end: ~₹35, ~₹500/min.
- **Prices:** (base + step × (L−1)) × 1.3^milestones. Chai ₹10 + ₹0.70/level to Lv 25 (the reference curve, so the tutorial matches the video), then 2 % steps. Milestones at 25, 50, 100, 150, 200, 250, 300 (max 300). At Lv 100: chai ₹49 → kesar doodh ₹118; roti ₹70 → kulcha ₹169; lassi ₹176 → Patiala ₹422; bhurji ₹528 → chole ₹1,267.
- **Costs:** LEVEL UP ₹25 / ₹32 / ₹90 / ₹300 × 1.02 per level, ×1.8 per milestone; chai costs ₹13,000 to reach Lv 100, the kadai ₹2.54 L. Cooks and SPEED from ₹100–₹1,500 (×6 / ×1.2); waiters ₹400 / ₹1,200; tables ₹300 / ₹750 / ₹1,800 / ×2.4; cashier 2 ₹500; builds ₹2,000 / ₹1,700 / ₹10,000. One dial (`difficulty.cost_mult` 1.0) multiplies every post-tutorial cost.
- **Rewards** are minutes of real takings without VIP: ad 1, chest 1.5, card 0.25; the first four cards fixed (₹480, ₹530, ₹700, ₹1,500). Rewards are ~half of all money in the first 10 minutes, ~⅓ at 30 for an ad watcher.
- **Milestones in time (ads / no ads, after the tutorial):** lassi 2:34 / 2:57; naan + coffee 4:00; chaas 5:42; keema 6:10 / 7:00; kadai 9:34 / 13:53; dal 11:18; mango lassi 14:35; paneer + green tea 16:00 / 21:14; the four Lv 100 dishes 34:30–36:30 / 45:30–51:00. Lifetime ₹31k at 10 min, ₹1.24 L at 20, ₹2.65 L at 30, ₹8.27 L at 60; takings ₹509/min → ₹10.5k → ₹17k.
- **When content runs out:** the last new thing arrives at 35–50 min. After that only milestones 150–300 (price ×1.3, no dish), the last SPEED buys, tables 4–5 and third cooks remain; the chip keeps naming one, but it is a treadmill. The ~1–1.5 h estimate holds: no prestige, location, event or manager to spend on.

6. The feel

- **Juice** (`docs/reference-match-spec.md` §6; `scripts/v3/fx/world_juice.gd`; strips in `docs/polish/feel/`): every sale spawns 4–6 tumbling 3D notes that fan up and shrink toward the pill plus a green floating price; timers pop in and shrink out; buttons flash, sparkle, ring and scale-punch; the level bar glints; CLAIM and FREE play shock rings, a ring of bills unspooling into the HUD and a chunked count-up; panels cross-fade in 0.12 s; dialogue stages dim → box → Munshi-ji slide → 30 cps typewriter with crouch-spring and dip-and-pop transitions. Since 26 Oct the world answers purchases: LEVEL UP squashes the counter, cooks hop, gold sparkles rise and the knock climbs a semitone per tap; a milestone adds confetti, a gold ring and the NEW ON THE MENU card; hires pop in with a dust ring; builds puff, ring, sparkle and glow when the counter appears; "Seats full!" pulses softly. LOW halves particles; frame time within ±3 %.
- **Haptics** (`scripts/v3/core/haptics.gd`): a light tick on spend, a strong pulse on rewards and builds, a double pulse on a dish unlock, nothing on free taps; a VIBRATION switch. Never felt on a phone.
- **Sound** (`docs/polish/audio.md`): a 68.6 s seamless synthesised loop in D at 84 bpm (harmonium, keherwa tabla, bansuri, santoor), ducking under dialogue, darker at night; day and night ambience; three sale variants, three serves, four horns ≥ 10 s apart, a stall sound per counter, a soft deny, a dholak BUILD fanfare. −20.6 LUFS, silent in the background. Measured, never heard on a device.
- **Art** (`01_home_free_start.png`, `25_home_stats_chest_kadai.png`, `tut_t302_free_5min.png`): 115 low-poly flat-shaded Blender glbs on a warm palette: terracotta tiles, teal walls, marigold and fairy strings, painted tyre

ads, Devanagari boards, a kettle on a bhatti, charpais, a sleeping dog, a bus shelter. Chibi characters at ~7 % of screen height with blob shadows, order bubbles and trays; a chunky painted-tin HUD in Baloo 2 (covers Hindi). It reads at a glance like a shipped Codigames-tier idle game. Thinner spots: near-identical travellers in three outfits, static seated poses, much empty tile in the courtyard view, no owner character on screen.

7. What testers said and what changed

On 21 Oct testers of v0.3.2 said "difficult to understand and the UI is confusing". Five reviews of 202 shots were merged in `docs/ux_audit/ux-fix-plan.md`. Root causes (§1): the reference's tutorial and HUD were copied but the real bottleneck (seats + waiters) was never practised and had no button; "/min" and every preview reported kitchen capacity (1.6–2.7× real), so the right purchase showed +0 while STAFF/SPEED promised gains that earned ~3 %; every detected problem was a label, not a path (WAITERS was reachable only through an unlabelled rack); Hindi-only titles on icon-only buttons; the camera parked on an empty lawn after every fly; four dead "coming soon" buttons, one where the tutorial's ad tap landed.

The owner's 22 Oct items (`docs/round2/plan.md`): money ran away (₹5.7 Cr in 30 min), a "×2" popup after every app switch, people walking through lorries (429–489 overlaps per 15-min run), hiring a waiter unfindable, too much at 1:30 then 89 s of nothing, a 14-number sheet.

Landed in 0.3.3–0.3.7: English-first labels; a 19-line tutorial (≤ 12 words, action first) with the waiter and seats beats taught by doing; the NEXT chip from 1:30; honest "/min"; one STAFF button with HIRE first and before → after, BUILD for things, 2-tap cards on ghosts; dead buttons hidden; FREE CASH in session 1, VIP once a session from session 2; the normalised economy (₹2.75 L at 30 min); offline only after 10 min, ×2 after 30; vehicles that stop at the crossing (0 overlaps, ~3.5 s per crossing); one card at a time, STATS hidden until the kadai, a 9-number sheet; the endless chip; the juice, haptics and audio passes of 26 Oct. All verified by headless bots only.

8. Known gaps

- **No prestige, no second location** (the GDD's "sell the dhaba, move to a new route" is post-MVP; the reference's long-run engine is a ×50 "next city"). New content ends at 35–50 min; goals at ~1–1.5 h.
- **No events, managers, medals, shop or Sikke sink**: hidden by `FEATURES`; Sikke pile up invisibly.
- **Two IAPs only** (VIP ×2 ₹299, Remove Ads at 1.0× income); no starter pack.
- **Dead controls removed, slots empty**: the manager portrait, medal and shop are gone with nothing in their place.
- **Never phone-tested.** Not run on a phone since v0.3; no bundle built; haptics, audio, touch, pinch, safe areas and 20:9 layouts (a 224 px band under the sheet) unverified; the 4 GB cold start is a target, not a measurement.
- **The seats beat is probabilistic**: after the crossing fix it fires in 3 of 6 seeds, so half of new players never get the seats lesson in the tutorial.
- **Arrivals cap at 19.5/min** with no parking, signboard or marketing purchase to raise it.
- **354 Hindi strings** await a native review; the music is synthesised and unheard by the owner.

9. A fresh designer's view

Five things that confuse or feel weak

1. **Two economies stapled together.** The tutorial runs the reference's curve (₹0.70 a level, ×1.02 costs); free play runs the normalised one with 2 % steps and ×1.3 milestones; chai keeps the old step only to Lv 25. The button the player was taught to spam goes flat right after the lesson (`economy-proposal.md` §5).
2. **The best purchase rarely feels like a purchase.** The real multipliers (waiters, tables) are bought in full-screen panels that hide the world, so their pop-in is deferred; the shiny centre card (LEVEL UP) moves "/min" by 1–5 %. The feel rewards the wrong lever.
3. **Guidance is a treadmill, not a story.** After minute 3 the loop is chip → tap → hand → buy → next chip. Munshi-ji speaks only at builds and unlocks, never about the player's choices; there is no owner, no regulars,

no "famous on the highway" arc. PLAN.md's Bhaiya mascot was dropped and nothing took the role.

4. **The twist is off-screen.** The bays, bus stop and crossing (the arrival ramp that explains flat income) sit outside the home framing; the player sees a door line or a tray rack and gets a label. A "what's slowing us" readout exists only as HISAAB rows after the kadai (ux-fix-plan B1, B6).
5. **The headline feature is a 2.6 s pop.** NEW ON THE MENU changes a prop, a chip and prices; nothing about who comes or what they do changes, and after Lv 100 milestones are bare number bumps. The dish jokes hide behind a chip tap.

Five things that already work

1. **The first three minutes are tight and measured**: a sale at 0:37, upgrade at ~0:45, hire at ~1:10, each twist beat opened by a visible problem and closed in two taps; identical on every seed.
2. **The NEXT and PROBLEM chips** turn a confusing sim into one sentence and one tap; the screen-only bot now unblocks itself (stuck 120 s → 0; dishes by 10:00 0 → 5).
3. **The numbers are honest**: "/min" is real takings, every HIRE row shows before → after, rewards are minutes of income, VIP never inflates a reward, and the pacing tool and in-game bot agree within a few percent.
4. **The world reads as a dhaba, not a reskin**: whole orders on trays, lorries reversing into bays, a bus that waits for its riders, fairy lights at dusk, harmonium and tabla, four Indian horns.
5. **The purchase juice is in and cheap**: combo-pitched LEVEL UP, squash and sparkle, pop-ins for hires, the unspooling reward stream, all within ±3 % frame time on LOW, so there is a feel budget left to spend.

R1 — Genre anatomy: the hands-off idle tycoon and its neighbours

Research note for Dhaba Rush. Written 2026-10-31. Labels used throughout: **[fact]** measured or official (store metadata, developer pages, dated articles with formulas); **[estimate]** third-party market data (AppMagic, Sensor Tower, Gamigion's own tracking); **[opinion]** a named author's or reviewer's view; **[inference]** my own reading of the evidence; **[memory, unverified]** something I know but could not fetch this session.

0. How this was researched, and what could not be reached

The shared WebSearch budget for this workflow run was already used up when this task started, so every source below was reached by direct URL and fetched. Reachable: Game Developer (Pecorella's "Math of Idle Games" I–III), Wikipedia, Apple's App Store lookup API and customer-review feed (fetched 31 Oct 2026, US store), codigames.com, supercent.io, Gamigion, Liftoff, LevelWinner guides. **Blocked or dead from this machine:** GDC Vault, Deconstructor of Fun, GameRefinery, Machinations.io, the original Kongregate blog (DNS gone), Google Play pages (render empty), Reddit, Fandom wikis (HTTP 402). Anything attributed to those is marked [memory, unverified] and should be re-checked before quoting externally. Indian Google Play review text could not be pulled; the review quotes below are US App Store, Sept–Oct 2026 unless stated.

1. Where Dhaba Rush sits: the genre map

Sub-genre	Input model	Anchor titles (release)	Store signal [fact, Apple US, 31 Oct 2026]
Hands-off idle tycoon / idle management sim — the game Dhaba Rush is	Tap to spend; the sim runs itself; agents walk, serve, pay	Idle Miner Tycoon (Jul 2016), Idle Supermarket Tycoon (Feb 2019), Idle Theme Park Tycoon (May 2019), Idle Restaurant Tycoon: Empire (Nov 2020)	IMT 4.74★ / 866,395 ratings; IST 4.60★ / 149,219; ITPT 4.58★ / 159,070; IRT:E 4.71★ / 17,566
Idle arcade (hybrid-casual)	Joystick avatar carries things, then hires staff to automate	Pizza Ready! (Jul 2023), Burger Please! (Feb 2023), My Perfect Hotel (Jul 2022), Eatventure (Feb 2022, tap-based cousin)	PR 4.57★ / 347,249; BP 4.66★ / 137,399; MPH 4.72★ / 710,212; Eatventure 4.77★ / 80,154
Incremental / clicker	Numbers and lists; little or no scene	Cookie Clicker (Aug 2013), AdVenture Capitalist (May 2014 web, Feb 2015 iOS), Egg, Inc. (Jul 2016)	AdCap 4.72★ / 383,627
Time-management	Player IS the waiter; levels with a timer and a score	Diner Dash (PC 2005), Cooking Fever (iOS Sept 2014)	Cooking Fever 450M downloads as of 2024 [fact, Wikipedia]
Merge/tycoon hybrids	Merge board feeds a tycoon map	(Not researched this session)	—

Sources: App Store lookup results for each title; Wikipedia pages for AdVenture Capitalist, Cookie Clicker, Egg Inc., Diner Dash, Cooking Fever; Kolibri Games Wikipedia page.

[fact] Codigames is a Spanish studio "Creating Games Since 2013"; its Idle Supermarket Tycoon page lists exactly the loop Dhaba Rush copied: departments, permanent upgrades, hire "cashiers, stock clerks, bakers and sales experts", raise salaries, marketing, temporary boosters, "open new checkouts to reduce queue times" (codigames.com). **[fact]** Kolibri Games (founded 2016 as Fluffy Fairy Games) built Idle Miner Tycoon in about eight weeks, reached 100M+ downloads, and sold 75% to Ubisoft in Feb 2020 at a reported €160M valuation; FT-listed revenue €53.5M (Mar 2021 list) (Wikipedia, Kolibri Games). **[estimate]** Supercent's site claims "1.5B+" downloads across its idle-arcade portfolio (supercent.io, 2026 footer); Gamigion, citing AppMagic, put the

company at 230M downloads by end-2023 and 5–50M per idle-arcade title. **[estimate]** Eatventure: 69.3M downloads and nearly $28M IAP since 2022 (AppMagic via Gamigion, Mar 2025); Lessmore was bought by Miniclip at end-2024.

2. The core loop at four time scales (hands-off tycoon)

Composite from the IST/IMT/Eatventure guides, Codigames' and Kolibri's own descriptions, and Pecorella's math. **[inference]** where it is my synthesis.

Seconds (0–10 s). Agents spawn, walk to a station, wait a radial timer, pay. Coins pop. The player's only verbs are *tap a station → read price → buy*. Pecorella's rule governs the feel: `cost_next = cost_base × growth^owned`; AdVenture Capitalist's lemonade stand uses growth 1.07, base ≈ 3.74, 1.67/s, with a ×2 multiplier at 25 and 50 owned, which produces predictable "purchase spikes" **[fact, Pecorella Part I, 13 Oct 2016]**. Cookie Clicker uses a 15% price step per building **[fact, Wikipedia]**.

Minutes (1–10 min). The seesaw: "At the most basic level, idle games are a seesaw between production rates and costs" **[opinion, Pecorella 2016]**. Early in a run production outpaces cost; multipliers "bump you back up" each time costs catch up. The player hops between stations buying whatever is affordable; the Management page (IST) flags the red bottleneck (slow checkouts, parking at 100%) **[fact, LevelWinner IST guide, updated May 2020]**. Minute-scale beats are also where the ad economy lives: IST's 2× revenue for 1 h per ad (six in a row → 6 h), the VIP car, delivery trucks stacking to four, the bus for a customer surge **[fact, LevelWinner IST]**; Eatventure's 5-minute multiplier stacking to 1 h **[fact, LevelWinner Eatventure, Mar 2023]**; IMT boosts that refill about every 2 minutes **[fact, LevelWinner IMT, May 2017]**.

Session (3–15 min). A session is: collect offline earnings (offer ad to double) → spend down to zero on the cheapest useful upgrades → claim the one open mission → bank a milestone (new department/station, new shaft) → leave when nothing is affordable and the next thing is >5 minutes away. Gamigion's figures, unverified, describe the target shape: Pizza Ready sessions "often under 3 minutes", 4+ per day; Carnival Tycoon spaces major unlocks every 3–5 minutes of play; a mid-tier idle (Lamar) has 73% of DAU returning at least twice a day **[estimate/opinion, Gamigion, 20 Jul 2025]**.

Day (and week). Offline accrual with a cap forces return: Egg, Inc. caps at 2 hours **[fact, Pecorella Part III, 1 Feb 2017]**, Eatventure at 3 hours **[fact, LevelWinner]**, IST shows an offline multiplier and an ad to double it. The day loop is the chain of **milestone → bottleneck → new location**. IST: once cash suffices you "sell your store and open one in a new city"; departments, parking and advertising reset but the new city "gives a profit multiplier" **[fact, LevelWinner IST]**. Eatventure renovates in place (lemonade stand → snack bar → café → fast-food chain) and then moves city **[fact, LevelWinner]**. AdVenture Capitalist resets for Angel Investors that boost all future revenue and unlocks Moon/Mars at $100 trillion **[fact, Wikipedia]**. Weekly limited-time events have run in AdCap since Oct 2015 **[fact, Wikipedia]**; Codigames lists "time-limited events" and "managers" for Idle Theme Park **[fact, codigames.com]**.

[inference] Dhaba Rush currently has the seconds and minutes loops and about one session's worth of the day loop. "Content runs out after ~1–1.5 h" is the exact point where this genre hands the player a prestige/new-location multiplier; without it the seesaw simply stops.

3. The psychological core

1. **A place visibly growing.** Codigames sells "upgrades change the store's appearance"; a 5★ IST reviewer (Feb 2019) praised exactly that, and a 2021 5★ reviewer "finds watching their progress satisfying" **[opinion, App Store]**. Gamigion's framing: "It's not just about making pizza; it's about managing something and watching it grow" **[opinion, Gamigion Pizza Ready, Apr 2025]**.
2. **Numbers going up, always something affordable.** Pecorella: "Early on in a run, your production will exceed costs while eventually costs will become prohibitive" — the design job is keeping several things affordable at once and making *different* generators matter at different stages, because if the newest always dominates "older generators are largely irrelevant and removes any interesting decisions" **[fact/opinion, Part I]**.

3. **Offline progress as a gift.** AdCap was "among the first to add monetization and offline earnings" **[fact, Wikipedia]**; the return-and-collect moment is the retention hook, which is why every title caps it (2–3 h) and sells the doubling.
4. **Doing → delegating.** AdCap managers "run it automatically"; IMT managers (Junior/Senior/Executive) take over elevator/shafts; Pizza Ready's whole arc is "run around, then hire staff so you don't". Ian Bogost's line about Cookie Clicker, "a game for a computer to play while a human watches" **[opinion, via Wikipedia]**, is the fantasy stated bluntly.
5. **Low pressure.** The top Eatventure 5★ review this month: "No timers, pressure or deadlines other than missing delivery opportunities or bonuses" (14 Oct 2026). My Perfect Hotel 5★ (24 Oct 2026): "a game to just run around in and do mindless tasks while playing music".
6. **The honest critique.** Destructoid called Cookie Clicker an "illusion of progress" (2013); Gamezebo on Egg, Inc.: "satisfying to say the least" but "ultimately a little pointless" (2016); Pecorella (GDC 2015, via Wikipedia) said the genre "almost doesn't want to exist" and that many hits are spreadsheets with clever mechanics **[opinion]**. **[inference]** The genre works *because* it is honest about this: it promises relaxation and visible accumulation, not mastery.

4. The standard structural skeleton

- **Stations with three upgrade axes.** Codigames' own text for IST: level the department (better products / price), hire staff and "set higher salaries" (throughput), plus speed/efficiency upgrades; Eatventure: tap-to-upgrade a station fills a bar, a full bar yields a gem and a star, each star *doubles* that dish's profit; stations cap at level 150 in main mode **[fact, LevelWinner]**. Dhaba Rush's LEVEL UP / STAFF / SPEED is the canonical triple.
- **Bottleneck chains.** IMT is a three-link chain, miner → elevator → warehouse, and the guide names the stall points ("the factory, which processes gold slowly"; a warehouse whose storage lags worker speed) **[fact, LevelWinner IMT]**. IST: serve → checkout → parking, each flagged red when it binds. Eatventure's advice: "Too many customers backs up the kitchen, and too much staff leaves the restaurant underused" **[fact, LevelWinner]**. Pecorella Part II formalises chains: tiers that feed tiers grow as 1, t, $t^2/2$, $t^3/6$ … and "approach e^x", so costs must stay exponential to keep ahead **[fact, Part II, 14 Dec 2016]**.
- **Missions / tasks.** IST: one mission at a time, completing one surfaces the next, some already satisfied so they can be claimed instantly; rewards are gems **[fact, LevelWinner IST]**. Codigames lists "milestones" and "challenges" for ITPT.
- **Boosts (ad-gated).** IST 2×/1 h, VIP car, bus, trucks; Eatventure glowing "Investors" that trigger an ad for a cash lump; IMT timed boosts (walk speed, load, warehouse, mining) **[fact]**. Gamigion claims Pizza Ready's ad placements reach 42% engagement vs 25–30% casual average and that ads "feel like a rescue, not an interruption" when offered at a bottleneck **[estimate/opinion, Jul 2025]**.
- **Managers.** AdCap: automation; IMT: tiered, with bonus attributes; ITPT: "hire managers to boost income and progression"; IST added managers in a 2026 update (a 5★ review, 17 Jun 2026, "likes the update's managers and events") **[fact]**.
- **Prestige / new location.** Pecorella Part III gives the scaling: to double prestige currency AdCap needs ~3–4× the previous run's lifetime earnings (square root), Cookie Clicker ~8× (cube root), Egg Inc ~128× (exponent ≈ 0.14); the reset "reins growth back into a more manageable number" and "each prestige allows the player to get farther through the cost curve before falling behind" **[fact/opinion]**. Tycoons dress the reset as a new city/mine/park with a multiplier.
- **Events.** AdCap weekly since 2015; Eatventure events run "in separate, larger restaurants" with event-only currency **[fact]**; IMT seasonal events (an Oktoberfest event is in this month's reviews).

[memory, unverified] Machinations-style diagrams of this genre draw one source (customers) → converter (station, rate-limited) → pool (cash) → drains (upgrades) with a feedback edge from upgrades back to converter rate; prestige is a second, slower loop that multiplies the first. I could not fetch Machinations' own articles.

5. What differs across sub-genres, and why players pick each

Hands-off tycoon. Picked for calm management and a scene to watch. What they get today, per reviews: Idle Miner Tycoon's top complaint this month is not the loop but the shell: "The popups are insane. I counted 25 in a row." (3★, 28 Oct 2026); "Just let me play the dang game at my own pace and quit bombarding me with these pop-ups" (2★, 1 Oct 2026); "the ads make it boring since I just wanna do a quick upgrade and get off the game" (3★, 5 Oct 2026). The loop itself still lands: "It's satisfying enough, the gameplay, I just need to get everything." (5★, 22 Oct 2026). Idle Supermarket Tycoon's reviews name the structural weakness: "you max out, then have to go to another location, the pattern continues" (3★, 22 Oct 2026); "it's just extremely boring and it takes way too long to upgrade your shops" (2★, 27 Sep 2026); "I don't like when it forces me to go to the next level and I haven't finished my current level" (3★, 8 Sep 2026); "I need to BUY managers with REAL money to progress" (1★, 18 Oct 2026). **[inference]** Players accept the city reset only when the new place looks and plays differently; a forced move before the old place feels finished reads as theft.

Idle arcade. Picked for embodied doing with zero pressure. Supercent's formula: joystick, carry, deposit, hire; "no main menu or tutorials", straight into play **[opinion, Gamigion]**. India is Pizza Ready's biggest market at 23% of 221M downloads, US 7% **[estimate, AppMagic via Gamigion, Apr 2025]**, which matters for an India-first launch. What they get: "I love that you feel like your actually running a business" (5★, 19 Oct 2026); and the ceiling, "really disappointed when I perfected all 11 levels to find that there's no way to progress to level 12" (3★, 18 Oct 2026); "every restaurant is the same just different food served" (3★, 12 Oct 2026); "You can't play for 2 minutes without an ad popping up" (1★, 20 Oct 2026). My Perfect Hotel (SayGames' own listing calls it "time-management"): "too many things take up the screen at once and it's too overstimulating" (2★, 27 Oct 2026); "Too many things to concentrate on and never a feeling of actual accomplishment" (3★, 25 Oct 2026); and the content ask, "I hope there's more hotels in the works because I've unlocked them all" (5★, 23 Oct 2026). Eatventure: "out of 30 mins play time you'll spend 25 mins watching an ad" (4★, 19 Oct 2026) next to "Quick, easy, addictive" (5★, 14 Oct 2026). Gamigion's market radar found most new idle-arcade entries are remixes: 6 of 18 built on My Perfect Hotel, 2 on Burger Please **[estimate, Gamigion]**; both idle arcade and clicker/idle sit in a "Competitive tier (3–5% success rate)" among 1,000+ arcade games with ≥1M downloads **[estimate, AppMagic via Gamigion, May 2025]**.

Incremental / clicker. Picked for the math itself: bulk-buy decisions, prestige optimisation, layered economies. Pecorella: players "roughly follow an optimal income-to-cost ratio" and buy in multiples of 100 **[opinion, Part I]**. Critics are harshest here (Pocket Gamer gave AdCap 3/10) yet the App Store rating is 4.72★ from 383k users **[fact]**.

Time-management. Picked for skill and score: Diner Dash's seat → order → chef → deliver → check → tip → clear loop with chain bonuses **[fact, Wikipedia]**; Cooking Fever's 450M downloads show the appetite for *doing* the serving. **[inference]** Dhaba Rush's waiters and charpai seats borrow this genre's visible service chain while keeping the tycoon's hands-off control; that hybrid is the twist worth protecting.

Market scale [estimate]. AppMagic's head of content: "Arcade Clicker/Idle" is the largest Arcade sub-genre at 38% of lifetime Arcade IAP revenue, plateaued at about $28M/month in 2025 (Gamigion, Sept 2025). Liftoff: simulation titles see roughly 10× higher CPIs on iOS than Android; casual D30 ROAS 47% iOS / 15% Android in 2024 (Jul 2025).

6. Designer frameworks, with what could and could not be verified

- **Anthony Pecorella (Kongregate).** GDC Feb 2015, "Idle Games: The Mechanics and Monetization of Self-Playing Games" (gdcvault.com/play/1022065) and the GDC 2016 follow-up, reported in "Idle Chatter: GDC 2016" (18 Mar 2016), where he argued auto-clickers signal a design flaw rather than cheating; plus "A Brief Look at the Idle Games Genre" (5 Apr 2016) **[fact, titles/dates via Wikipedia citations; Vault and original blog unreachable]**. The three "Math of Idle Games" posts (Game Developer reprints, Oct 2016–Feb 2017) were fetched and are the load-bearing formulas in sections 2 and 4. A 2019 GDC talk is named in the brief; I could not confirm its title this session **[memory, unverified]**.
- **Deconstructor of Fun, GameRefinery, Machinations.** Domains blocked here. From memory: DoF's idle write-ups stress "the wall" and managers as the first monetisation point; GameRefinery files idle tycoons

under Simulation and idle arcades under Arcade/hybrid-casual and offers a Motivational Driver framework of 8 archetypes and 12 drivers (the framework's existence is confirmed by Liftoff, 31 Oct 2023) **[memory, unverified except the Liftoff line]**.

- **Kolibri / Codigames interviews.** Not reachable; the facts used come from Wikipedia (Kolibri), codigames.com and store listings.
- **Gamigion (2025–26).** Useful but author-sourced numbers; its best line for the team: "Idle mechanics are not the product. They're the infrastructure." (Yazıcı, 20 Jul 2025) **[opinion]**.

7. Genre vocabulary

Term	Meaning	Example
Generator / station	A thing that converts time into currency at a rate	Lemonade stand (AdCap); bakery (IST); chai counter
Cost curve	`base × growth^owned`; 1.07 (AdCap lemonade), 1.15 (Cookie Clicker buildings)	Pecorella Part I; Wikipedia
Seesaw	Production vs cost; production leads early, cost wins late	Pecorella Part I
Wall	The point where the next buy is many minutes away	Pecorella's "costs become overwhelming"
Threshold multiplier	×2 at 25/50 owned; creates purchase spikes	AdCap; Eatventure stars (×2 per star)
Bottleneck chain	Linked stations where the slowest binds	miner → elevator → warehouse (IMT); serve → checkout → parking (IST)
Manager	Automates or boosts a station; the doing → delegating switch	AdCap, IMT Junior/Senior/Executive
Offline earnings (capped)	Accrual while away, capped (2 h Egg Inc, 3 h Eatventure), ad to double	all
Boost	Timed multiplier, usually ad-gated	IST 2×/1 h; IMT ~2-min refills
Missions / tasks	One visible goal at a time; gem rewards; chest	IST missions; Dhaba tasks bar
Prestige / soft reset	Reset for a permanent multiplier; needs 3–4× (sqrt) to 128× (Egg Inc) more to double	AdCap Angels; Cookie Clicker Ascension
New location	Prestige dressed as a new city/mine/park with a multiplier	IST cities; IMT mines; Eatventure cities
Renovation	In-place transformation instead of a reset	Eatventure lemonade → snack bar → café
Event	Separate time-boxed economy with own currency/shop	Eatventure events; AdCap weekly; IMT Oktoberfest
Idle arcade	Joystick avatar carries goods, then hires staff	Pizza Ready!, My Perfect Hotel
Time-management	Player is the server; levels, timer, score	Diner Dash, Cooking Fever
Hybrid-casual	Hyper-casual onboarding + mid-core depth	Liftoff definition, Oct 2023

8. Verdict: what the core IS versus what is decoration

The core (must be right before anything else):

1. **The seesaw tuned so there is always something affordable in the first 10 minutes and a visible next goal every 3–5 minutes.** Pecorella's cost formula and threshold multipliers are the whole genre; everything else is skin. If the next buy is more than ~5 minutes away in session one, the game is over.
2. **A bottleneck the player can *see* bind and *fix*.** Dhaba Rush's waiters and seats are a legitimate IMT-style chain; the Management-page idea (flag the red link) is how IST makes the chain legible. The chain is the game's only real decision.
3. **Visible transformation of the place.** Upgrades must change the scene (the IST reviews single this out). A bigger tandoor, more charpais, lights, a queue of trucks: these are the reward, not the number.

4. **The day loop: capped offline earnings + a reason to come back + a multiplier reset.** With content ending at ~1.5 h and no prestige/new location, the loop has no day scale. The genre's players explicitly ask for "more hotels", "level 12", and resent a reset that comes *before* the current place feels finished. Either renovation-in-place (Eatventure) or new dhaba on a new highway with a multiplier, but one of them, before launch.
5. **Delegation as the arc.** Managers (or in Dhaba terms, a head waiter / Munshi-ji taking over a function) are both the fantasy payoff and the first clean monetisation point.
6. **Calm.** Zero timers, zero fail state, one popup per launch. The loudest complaints across all six titles this month are popups and ad density, and "overstimulating" screens. Testers' "hard to understand, UI confusing" is the same failure from the other side.

Decoration (keep, but it does not rescue a weak core): vehicle variety at the gate, day/night and fairy lights, music loop and horns, Munshi-ji's character, Indian dish names, the chest animation, VIP ×2 popup styling. These sell the theme ("you feel like your actually running a business") and the 63%-female, India-heavy audience of the neighbouring idle arcades responds to nurturing themes **[estimate, Gamigion]**, but none of them change whether the seesaw and the chain work.

[inference] One-line test for the team: at minute 8, can a tester say what is slowing the dhaba down, what they will buy next, and what the dhaba will look like after? If yes, the core is there; the rest is polish.

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What idle-tycoon players want and what they complain about

Research date: 31 Oct 2026. Scope: hands-off idle tycoons (Idle Supermarket Tycoon, Idle Theme Park Tycoon, Idle Miner Tycoon, Idle Restaurant Tycoon: Empire, Eatventure, Pizza Ready!, Roadside Empire, Travel Center Tycoon, Idle Food Bar: Olivia & Oliver).

Labels: **[M]** measured fact from a store listing or report; **[R]** player review/opinion, quoted verbatim; **[E]** third-party estimate (Sensor Tower, AppMagic, aggregator NLP); **[I]** my inference.

Sourcing. App Store quotes: apps.apple.com (dated) or JustUseApp mirrors (page date given, reviews undated). Google Play quotes: Play pages fetched 31 Oct 2026 with the India locale (`gl=IN`, `hl=en` / `hl=hi`); recent-first, dates not captured, treat as 2024-26. Reddit: one Jan 2026 mirror snapshot plus search snippets of an Aug 2024 thread.

0. The genre at a glance (store facts, 31 Oct 2026)

Game (publisher)	Google Play IN	App Store US	IN IAP range	No-ads price	Size
Idle Miner Tycoon (Kolibri)	4.4, 5.87M reviews, 100M+	-	₹24-₹4,819	-	-
Idle Supermarket Tycoon (Codigames)	4.0, 600K, 10M+	4.6, 147K	₹89-₹8,900	-	-
Idle Theme Park Tycoon (Codigames)	4.2, 389K, 10M+	4.6, 159K	₹89-₹11,300	$14.99	907.9 MB (iOS)
Idle Restaurant Tycoon: Empire (Kolibri)	4.4, 196K, 5M+	4.7, 18K	₹30-₹3,039	$10.99-$12.99	355.4 MB
Eatventure (Lessmore)	4.6, 423K, 50M+	4.8	₹58-₹5,800	optional-ads only	-
Pizza Ready! (Supercent)	4.3, 1.82M [E grand-screen]	4.6, 347K	-	$3.99	388.1 MB
Roadside Empire (Highcore)	4.2, 80.7K [E]	4.8, 25.3K	-	-	-
Travel Center Tycoon (Rocky Dessert)	4.5, 120K, 10M+	-	₹90-₹9,100	~$10 [R]	-
Idle Food Bar: Olivia & Oliver (First Magic)	-	4.7, 1.3K	-	$19.99	455.4 MB

[I] Codigames' Play rating (4.0) sits well below its App Store 4.6; the Play reviews below say why (the 2025-26 "managers"/"research" updates).

1. Top 10 things players praise

1. Ads only when I choose, and they pay out. The single most-repeated praise.

- "Finally! An idle game with all the aspects I love! No forced ads AT ALL" (Eatventure, App Store via JustUseApp, page 19 Sep 2026) [R]
- "weirdly I've probably watched 500+ ads by now and I'm not mad because it was my choice. I wish other games would realize this." (Eatventure, Google Play) [R]
- "I love how adds are optional and how you still get money even if you aren't on" (Idle Supermarket, App Store via JustUseApp, Aug 2026) [R]
- Kolibri (Mar 2021): ads ~50% of revenue; best placement "double offline earnings on return" [M, company].

2. Relaxing, de-stressing, "before bed".

- "It has become a must play before bed time now as a way to de stress from the day. A real diamond." (Eatventure, GP) [R]
- "I like to play it to help me relax and get sleepy at night instead of scrolling socials." (Eatventure, GP) [R]
- "I wanted to give 5 star for this calm and peace game to play." (Travel Center Tycoon, GP) [R]

3. Fits any session length without penalty.

- "I can play intensely for 5 minutes or an hour, then put it down without sacrificing my position in the game." (Eatventure, GP) [R]
- r/incremental_games, Aug 2024: a good idle is "something you can play and progress in with small amounts of playtime" [R]
- GameAnalytics (Mar 2025): idle avg session 8 min, 5.3 sessions/day [E].

4. Money waiting when you come back (offline earnings).

- "I enjoy expanding different sections of the store and earning money even while offline." (Idle Supermarket, GP) [R]
- "It was nice to have a game I could play offline on my lunch break." (Idle Restaurant Tycoon, GP) [R]

5. Watching the place visibly grow.

- "It was so fun watching your theme park grow more and more every day." (Idle Theme Park, GP) [R]
- "the graphics and progression are satisfying." (Eatventure, GP) [R]

6. Upgrades that change the scene, not just a number.

- "Lots of upgrades, plus when you upgrade it's not just a stat boost" (Idle Supermarket, App Store via JustUseApp) [R]
- "It has so many things to unlock on one ride and it so many different rides to advance and unlock." (Idle Theme Park, App Store, 28 Jan 2023) [R]
- "I love earning enhancement cards." (Idle Restaurant Tycoon, GP) [R]

7. Charm: art, music, humour.

- "the music, sound effects, and food graphics, great!" (Eatventure, GP) [R]
- "there's a lot of humor woven into the upgrades (\"Hire Mike's friend Mike, +1 Chef\")" (Eatventure, GP) [R]
- "it's lovely to look at, animations with people and rides etc are great" (Idle Theme Park, GP) [R]

8. Simple to understand.

- "I like the simplicity of the gameplay and the controls." (Eatventure, GP) [R]
- "Concept is easy, gameplay is smooth." (Roadside Empire, GP via search snippet) [R]
- "its easy for kids to play." (Idle Miner, GP) [R]

9. Honest: the game is what the ad showed.

- "Its nice to have a game that lives up to it's ads" (Eatventure, GP) [R]
- "I've gotta give it props for actually being what it claims to be and not an alliance survival game in disguise." (Eatventure, GP) [R]

10. Fair F2P and things to come back for (events, renovate, clubs).

- "You don't have to watch ads or spend money to progress (I haven't spent anything and rarely watch ads)." (Eatventure, GP) [R]
- "the weekly challenges are fun." (Eatventure, GP, one-year player) [R]
- "The renovate feature makes this game much better than others like it." (Idle Restaurant Tycoon, GP) [R]

2. Top 10 complaints

1. Forced/interstitial ads and ad frequency. The most common 1-star reason.

- "the ads come every 20 seconds and last anywhere from 5-10 seconds each" (Pizza Ready!, App Store, 17 Feb 2025) [R]
- "after i got a few days in they started just poping up randomly. And i mean it was one after another every thirty seconds. You could tell they were pushing the ad free version." (Travel Center Tycoon, GP) [R]

- "Feels like I'm playing just to watch ads!" (Idle Restaurant Tycoon, GP) [R]

2. Ad tech that breaks: no reward, app reload, Play Store redirect.

- "1 out of 3 ads don't give rewards after watching." (Idle Supermarket, GP) [R]
- "ads keep restarting the game all the time ... having to restart it ten times In twenty minutes is too much." (Idle Miner, GP) [R]
- "if you don't push the x in the exact right spot, it opens a browser window AND Google Play Store ... makes you miss out on your reward 90% of the time." (Idle Restaurant Tycoon, GP) [R]

3. Pop-up and offer spam on launch.

- "I logged in after not playing for some time and copped 13 game pop ups in one hit." (Idle Miner, GP) [R]
- "too many icons on the screen. I just want to play. ... uninstalled" (Travel Center Tycoon, GP) [R]
- "Wish when you at least buy the Ad Free Version that you can TOGGLE the premium offers OFF." (Idle Miner, GP) [R]

4. Hard gates that read as paywalls (manager cards, research tokens, vault caps).

- "they changed it by adding managers you have to level up in order to proceed. It's basically impossible to progress at a certain point without paying." (Idle Supermarket, GP) [R]
- "To get the next stall based on my current earnings it would take 120 hours of constant play (yes I've worked that out with a calculator)" (Idle Supermarket, GP) [R]
- "Once your vault reaches lvl10 that's it you can't progress anything" (Travel Center Tycoon, GP; multiple reviews say this has been unfixed "since July 2022") [R]

5. Updates that reset, nerf or rebalance what players earned.

- "but hey let's give everyone 700 gold and reset years of gameplay. pathetic. I've had it for almost 9 years. time to let go." (Idle Supermarket, GP) [R]
- "STOP EXPERIMENTING WITH THE GAME. Its fine as it is. If you have to, then introduce new supermarkets" (Idle Supermarket, GP, 2-year player) [R]
- "I hate the new card collecting system. I don't really like when games introduce new things that decrease value for the players." (Idle Food Bar, App Store, 6 May 2025) [R]

6. Content drought: "nothing to do", repetition.

- "once you complete one story there is nothing else to do." (Roadside Empire, App Store via JustUseApp) [R]
- "same food, same dishes, every other country, it gets tiring." (Eatventure, GP) [R]
- "Something new, truly new would be nice ... Every other game I play updates often or regularly. This one has had nothing." (Idle Restaurant Tycoon, App Store, 14 Apr 2022) [R]

7. Wait walls and slow late game.

- "after about 15 min of playing you get the point where all you can do is wait. Open the ap for 5 sec to click on a new build then wait 3hrs" (Travel Center Tycoon, GP) [R]
- "Now, it takes a week just to unlock the next ride." (Idle Theme Park, GP) [R]
- "the 3 hours that it takes to upgrade the shop and multiply profits, absolutely ridiculous." (Idle Supermarket, GP) [R]

8. Lost progress, no cloud save.

- "it went back to the very beginning with the tutorial which completely wiped out my progress." (Idle Restaurant Tycoon, App Store, 23 Jan 2021) [R]
- "There's no cloud system for the game so there's no way to retrieve progress." (Idle Restaurant Tycoon, App Store, 21 Jan 2021) [R]
- "The thing that solely broke the game however was logging in last night to find my progress gone." (Idle Restaurant Tycoon, GP) [R]

9. Bugs, freezes, battery, server dependency.

- "it freezes like every 10-20 minutes" (Idle Supermarket, 21 Mar 2026) [R]
- "I've never seen a game that pops up so often \"Waiting for server response\"" (Idle Theme Park, GP) [R]
- Hindi: "बार बार बंद हो जाता है ... क्रैश हो जा रहा है" ("keeps closing again and again ... crashing") (Idle Miner, GP hi-IN) [R]

10. Too shallow / nothing to decide (the optimizer's complaint).

- "there are no recurring costs, which makes the game extremely shallow" (Idle Supermarket, App Store via JustUseApp) [R]
- "Upgrade simulator" — lacks "decisions, risk, and meaningful numbers" (Eatventure, ComplaintsBoard) [R]
- "realize that the game is just playing itself it isn't worth it ... Just means uninstall faster." (Idle Miner, GP) [R]

Below the top 10: **misleading ads** ("next time make your ads a little more accurate, devs." Eatventure; Lancaric survey, Dec 2025: 75% uninstall immediately when the game does not match the ad [E, paywalled]); **adult ad content** ("PARENT ALERT: Inappropriate Ads", Eatventure); **new-location resets** ("nothing you did in the previous area matters ... feels very punishing", Eatventure GP); **IAP not delivered** (Idle Theme Park, Idle Food Bar, Idle Supermarket, 2025-26); **confusing** ("very fun. But it's confusing !!", Roadside Empire; hidden costs "never mentioned in advance", Idle Restaurant Tycoon).

3. What makes players quit: session 1, day 1, week 1

Session 1 (first 5-15 min). [R unless noted]

- Ads before trust: "I didn't even play 5 minutes of this game before I closed it and deleted it. I had to watch 3 ads." (Pizza Ready!, Jan 2025); "A full-length ad plays before the game loads" (Eatventure complaint).
- A wait wall inside the first minutes: "Right from the start you have to wait an hour just to build anything or use what few gems you have." (Travel Center Tycoon).
- Confusion at one step: Kolibri's Idle Restaurant soft launch (Oct 2020) found "many players got stuck at one early tutorial point" [M, company]. Its Idle Miner playtest (7 players, 3x15 min): players upgraded mines, ignored elevators/warehouses, hit a bottleneck and churned; contextual prompts fixed it [M, company].
- Low-end device failure: "mera 2 gb ram ka phone hai aur seconds bhi nahi chalte" ("my phone has 2 GB RAM and the seconds don't even tick") (Travel Center Tycoon, GP hi-IN); "I am stuck at the first Toilet construction. The timer stays at 57 seconds".
- Benchmarks: D1 21-24% average, <4% D30 (vgm.co, Sep 2026) [E]; top-10% idle D1 45.6% (GameAnalytics) [E]; Lumikai: "30% D1 and sub-10% D7" is insufficient to scale in India (Mar 2026) [E].

Day 1.

- The loop collapses into "open, spend, close": "The first five minutes are okay. Then you open the game once an hour ... play for 1 minute, spend all your money, and close again." (Travel Center Tycoon).
- Boredom when the second scenario looks like the first: "I played for a whole day. Had my fun. Got bored after drive through scenario." (Eatventure).
- A dev's targets after 7 prototypes (dev.to, Aug 2026): first upgrade <60 s, first automation <3 min, first prestige 10-15 min; "no prestige or endgame, so players drop off after the first session" [opinion].

Week 1.

- Interstitials switching on after N sessions: "after i got a few days in they started just poping up randomly" (Travel Center Tycoon).
- Running out of content: "Finished all available restaurants in a very short time" (Idle Restaurant Tycoon); "Unfortunately it gets boring by chapter 3." (Roadside Empire).
- A hard gate: "I made it all the way to Paris with no problem now I've been stuck there for almost a week now." (Idle Supermarket).
- Lost progress on reinstall/phone change (section 2.8).

[I] For Dhaba Rush: content ending at ~1-1.5 h sits exactly on the day-1/week-1 cliff these reviews describe; the fixes players name are a second location/prestige, a weekly event, and no interstitials until trust exists.

4. What keeps players for months

- Long-tenure voices: "I've been playing this everyday for the past year ... the weekly challenges are fun." (Eatventure, GP); "Been playing this game for 2 yrs now." and "I've had it for almost 9 years" (Idle Supermarket, GP); "I have played this game for years ... my favorite idle game to date." (Idle Theme Park, GP) [R].
- The retention mechanics named by those players: weekly events/challenges, a new city or park (prestige with carry-over), gear/pet/outfit collection ("I do love progression"), clubs (requested with chat and kicking), renovate/evolve of an existing location, customisation.
- Kolibri built Idle Restaurant Tycoon as GaaS: "Weekly time-limited event restaurants" plus new restaurants post-launch (Dec 2020) [M, company].
- AppQuantum's Idle Lumber Empire (Jun 2024): a live-ops plan after 2.5 years doubled downloads and raised spending 2.5x [E, company].
- Counter-signal: the same long-tenure players write "time to let go" when an update resets or gates them (2.5). **[I]** Tenure is trust; one bad rebalance spends it.

5. Cosy players vs optimizer players

Both exist in every review set; they ask for opposite screens.

Cosy/relaxed (majority of 5-star text): "calm and peace game", "before bed", "I just want to play", "just not the relaxing play that I'm looking for in an \"idle\" game" (Idle Miner, after pop-ups and "too many screens to navigate through"). They need: one obvious next action; a quiet screen (reviewers count icons and pop-ups); ambient life ("All of the character animations are idle, too. Chefs just stand there with a timer." is a complaint, Idle Restaurant Tycoon); no interruptions. Buergi (Replay, 2024): idle games qualify as cosy but monetisation "undermines the genre's calm appeal" [academic].

Optimizers (loud in 2-3 star text): "yes I've worked that out with a calculator"; "no recurring costs ... extremely shallow"; "lacks decisions, risk, and meaningful numbers"; "the developers do not know how to count past a trillion" (Eatventure, number formatting); r/incremental_games (Aug 2024): "number go up" matters less than "being able to influence the outcome with smart decisions"; numbers rising too fast is a turn-off; "a really important balance is active vs idle playtime" [R]. Alharthi et al. (CHI 2018): the genre moves players "from playing to planning" [academic]. They need: honest per-minute income; which station is the bottleneck right now; cost vs payoff on each upgrade; the offline cap stated; number formatting past 1e12; and, per the DEV post, progressive reveal (show the next 2-3 upgrades, not 20).

Both watch the sim and judge it. "the scripting is so bad for walking that big table 13 never gets cleaned" (Idle Restaurant Tycoon); "your moneymaker businesses were all stupidly designed to make the line wait for every car to leave" (Roadside Empire). **[I]** Dhaba Rush's waiter/seat bottleneck is exactly the kind of thing both groups will stare at; broken pathing becomes a 1-star review, legible bottlenecks become the game.

6. India-specific findings

- Market: non-RMG games $1.5B in CY25 (+17%); 555M gamers; payer conversion 25%; casual ARPPU $3; rewarded-ad eCPM $2.43 vs $1.10 aggregate (Lumikai via Outlook, 23 Mar 2026) [E]. Sensor Tower (Jun 2025): 8.45B downloads, ~$400M IAP in FY24-25; downloads "favour simple, familiar games"; Ludo King (1.25B downloads) cited as culturally resonant design [E].
- Audience: 44-45% women; 60-66% non-metro; 56% of payers buy within the first week; 47% "do not mind ads" (Lumikai, May/Nov 2025) [E]. Lightbox (Sep 2025): 12% find ads annoying, 38% would quit on excessive ad load [E].

- Language/theme: 34% of gamers prefer Hindi, 28% English (SCCG 2024, citing FICCI-EY Mar 2024) [E]; Lumikai 2021: "higher willingness to play games with vernacular and uniquely-Indian themes" [E, no %]. Hindi-locale Play reviews exist for every title and are blunt: "pay out ka लालच dette है और लोग फस जाते हैं" ("they bait you with payout and people get trapped") (Idle Supermarket, hi-IN).
- Devices/storage: Newzoo (Nov 2021): 92% of Indian smartphones have >=2 GB RAM, 53% >=4 GB [E]; SanDisk (2018): 62% run out of space every three months [E, old]. Kolibri's stock reply to Hindi reviews: "make sure you have enough free storage space on your phone" [M]. Competitor sizes (iOS): Idle Theme Park 908 MB, Idle Food Bar 455 MB, Pizza Ready 388 MB, Idle Restaurant 355 MB [M]. **[I]** A <150 MB APK is a differentiator.
- Offline: valued ("offline on my lunch break", Idle Restaurant); server dependency penalised ("Waiting for server response", Idle Theme Park); a Hindi review objects to "फालतू के नेट खराब करना" (wasting data) [R].
- Price points [M, Play IN listings]: IAP floors ₹24 (Idle Miner), ₹30 (Idle Restaurant), ₹58 (Eatventure), ₹89 (Codigames), ₹90 (Travel Center); ceilings ₹3,039-₹11,300; Play's India minimum is ₹10. Lumikai: ₹200-500 tickets go mostly to video/social [E]. On no-ads: "I would buy if it was $5 but $10 is too much for me." (Travel Center) [R]. **[I]** Rs 299 VIP x2 is above the genre's entry price; a Rs 49-99 first offer with Rs 299 as "x2 forever" (Idle Food Bar: $5.99) matches the listings better.

7. Ranked: what players of this genre look for

1. **Ads I choose, that always pay out.** "no forced ads AT ALL"; "I had to watch 3 ads" -> deleted in 5 min; "1 out of 3 ads don't give rewards".
2. **Respect for my time at any session length, with money waiting on return.** "5 minutes or an hour ... without sacrificing my position"; "earning money even while offline".
3. **A calm screen with one obvious next thing.** "I just want to play"; "13 game pop ups in one hit"; "too many screens to navigate".
4. **A place I can watch grow, with charm.** "watching your theme park grow more and more every day"; "Hire Mike's friend Mike, +1 Chef"; "animations with people and rides etc are great".
5. **Fair progress with no hard gate.** "impossible to progress at a certain point without paying"; "vault reaches lvl10 that's it".
6. **Upgrades that change what I see.** "when you upgrade it's not just a stat boost"; "so many things to unlock on one ride".
7. **Always a next place or event.** "nothing else to do" / "The story only last 6 levels" vs "the weekly challenges are fun"; "renovate ... doesn't feel like wasted time".
8. **Something to think about (bottlenecks, honest numbers).** "influence the outcome with smart decisions"; "no recurring costs ... extremely shallow"; "worked that out with a calculator".
9. **It never loses my stuff.** "wiped out my progress"; "no cloud system"; "freezes like every 10-20 minutes".
10. **Honesty: matches the ad, and updates never take away what I earned.** "lives up to it's ads"; "reset years of gameplay. pathetic."

Gaps

- Reddit: one mirror snapshot plus search snippets; the Aug 2024 thread is quoted from snippets. A JSON retry was blocked by the permission classifier.
- No usable YouTube comments or TapTap reviews. Google Play review dates not captured; Pizza Ready and Roadside Empire Play pages not fetched (package ids unknown).
- No genre-specific Indian data: language and device figures are all-gamer figures. Lumikai's full 2025 PDF and Buergi's full text were not retrievable.
- Aggregator sentiment percentages (JustUseApp, marlvel) are automated and not used as facts.

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What idle tycoon players currently get: market snapshot, October 2026

Prepared 31 Oct 2026 for the Dhaba Rush team. Labels: **[M]** measured/official, **[E]** third-party estimate (Sensor Tower, AppMagic, Appodeal, etc.), **[R]** player review (verbatim), **[O]** analyst opinion, **[I]** my inference. Every fact carries its date and a source number from the list at the end. Unknown cells in the matrix are marked *unknown*, not guessed.

1. Who leads the genre in 2025-2026

The market around idle. Mobile IAP revenue was $81.75B in 2025 (+1.3%) while downloads fell 7.2% to 50.4B [E, Sensor Tower, Jan 2026] [S1][S2]. Mobile game ad revenue passed $12B in 2025; the share of games monetising with ads rose from 45.1% (Jul 2021) to 55.6% (May 2026) [E, Sensor Tower, Jul 2026] [S3]. Hybrid-casual was the only casual segment with real IAP growth: +20% to $4.2B [E, Sensor Tower] [S2]; AppMagic, with a narrower taxonomy, has hybrid-casual IAP going from $390M to $733M (+88%) through Oct 2025 [E] [S4]. "Simulation" inside Casual earned $1.9B (-4.8%), of which farming is half; "time management" (restaurant-style active sims) was $135M (-12%) on 509M downloads [E, AppMagic, Feb 2026] [S5].

Idle sub-genre leaders (Sensor Tower weekly-peak lists, US). Q1 2025 Android revenue: Gold & Goblins: Idle Merger (AppQuantum) ~$400K/week mid-Feb; The Tower - Idle Tower Defense $184K; Idle Zombie Miner $137K; Carnival Tycoon $77K; Idle Lumber Empire $48K [E] [S6]. Q3 2025 iOS revenue: Gold and Goblins $239K; Idle Zombie Miner $197K; The Tower $162K; Idle Lumber Empire $110K; Little Farm Story: Idle Tycoon (SayGames) $108K; downloads led by Idle Lumber Empire (43K/week) and Idle Zombie Miner (42K/week) [E] [S7]. Pattern [I]: the grossing idle leaders are merge-idle, tower-defence-idle and mining-idle, not restaurant idle; restaurant-themed idle wins on downloads, not revenue.

Tycoon x coin-looter. Top Tycoon (BeheFun) made $29.6M on 11.7M installs in 2025, the only 2025 release to enter the Coin Looter top 10 [E, AppMagic] [S5]; Carnival Tycoon is cited at $40M lifetime [E, AppMagic, Sep 2025] [S8].

Downloads leader: Pizza Ready! (Supercent). 150M downloads in 2025 alone, ~400M lifetime, "most-downloaded hybrid casual game globally in 2025"; Supercent became the #7 publisher worldwide by downloads [E, Sensor Tower via Supercent PR, 5 Dec 2025] [S9]. Play tier 100M+, 4.4 stars, 2.95M reviews, updated 29 Oct 2026 [M] [S10]. Sensor Tower's global 2025 top-10 by downloads lists Pizza Ready #5 [E] [S2]. Revenue is the weak side: AppMagic's Dec 2025 hybrid-casual IAP leaderboard has Supercent at $1.08M for the month (rank 15) versus Rollic $17.5M [E] [S11]; a Gamigion breakdown cites only $774K lifetime IAP at the time (c. 2024) and the game is reported as ~70% ad revenue [E, secondhand] [S12][S13].

Other reference points. Idle Miner Tycoon (Kolibri/Ubisoft): Play 100M+, 4.5 stars, updated 28 Oct 2026 [M] [S14]; iOS 4.7 from 866K ratings [M] [S15]. Eatventure (Lessmore, owned by Miniclip since end-2024): Play 50M+, 4.7 stars, 423K reviews [M] [S16]; AppMagic 69.3M downloads and "nearly $28M in IAP" since 2022 [E, Mar 2025] [S17]. Idle Supermarket Tycoon (Codigames): Play 10M+ (India locale shows "1Cr+"), 4.1 stars, ~600K reviews [M] [S18]; iOS 4.6 from 149K ratings [M] [S19]. No lifetime revenue estimate for Idle Supermarket Tycoon was findable.

India. 8.45B downloads in FY Apr 2024-Mar 2025 (-8.7% YoY), IAP revenue "just over $400M", simulators are the top download genre at 22% (driving/flight sims lead), 86% male, 77% aged 18-34 [E, Sensor Tower, Jun 2025] [S20] [S21]. Ads made up 70.3% of game revenue in India (Jan-May 2026) versus 22.1% in the US [E, Sensor Tower, Jul 2026] [S3]. Pizza Ready! is the #4 most-downloaded game in India in 2025, the only idle-adjacent title in the top 10 [E, AppMagic via Outlook Respawn, 23 Dec 2025] [S22]. On the Google Play India simulation chart snapshot of

16 Feb 2025, the idle titles were Carnival Tycoon (#5) and Idle Lumber Empire (#6, 50M+), and "0% of the top simulation games in India were built by Indian developers" [M, 42matters] [S23]. No Sensor Tower idle-genre list for India was published; those pages 404.

2. Current trends

Idle-arcade (Supercent, Homa, SayGames). Definition [O, Udonis, 28 May 2025]: a stickman avatar with a joystick collects/stacks, unlocks zones, upgrades avatar/workers/equipment, and idle income continues offline. Top 50 idle-arcade games pull >60M downloads/month and made $6.3M in Oct 2024 combined; the 2024 download ranking was Pizza Ready!, My Perfect Hotel, Outlets Rush, Farm Land, Burger Please! [E, AppMagic via Udonis] [S24]. Retention claims: "almost 50% day-1 retention", 25 min D0 playtime, ~$0.40 CPI [E, Sensor Tower/Homa via Udonis] [S24]. Burger Please monetises with banners, frequent 5-second-skippable interstitials, rewarded video introduced in the tutorial, and a $12.99 bundle (skin, vehicle, no ads, 2x money/speed/capacity) [M, Udonis] [S25]. Supercent says Pizza Ready "delays ad exposure until around three minutes into gameplay" [M, PR] [S9]; players disagree: "there is an ad interruption literally every minute" [R, Play, 6 May 2025] and "For every 60 seconds of game play, there's a 25 second ad" [R, Play, 6 Apr 2025] [S10].

Hybrid-casual. Top hybrid-casual titles now beat the top-25 casual games on D7, which fell to 14.9% in Dec 2025 [E, Sensor Tower] [S1][S2]. Deconstructor of Fun calls hybrid-casual "a transitional launch strategy" and notes that once titles scale, "IAP outpaces ad revenue" [O, Jun 2025] [S26]. Hybrid-casual simulators grew 111.5% YoY in revenue [E, AppMagic LiveOps 2025, May 2026] [S27].

Stage-based idle (Eatventure). Structure: 60 cities, each a chapter of 7 restaurants; "after completing the last city, the cities will repeat indefinitely" [M, guide, 4 May 2026] [S28]; it starts with a lemonade stand, then food truck, cafe, diner, drive-thru [M, App Store] [S29]. Items (hat/body/hand) give universal bonuses that persist across restaurants; an Invite Helper gives a 5-minute shift every 30 minutes; events rotate weekly; 54.3% of revenue from the US [M/E, AppQuantum on PocketGamer.biz, Oct 2023] [S30]. "Cash Out" as a stage-based idle title: *unknown*; four searches found no such mobile game.

Merge-tycoon. Gold & Goblins: Idle Merger is the top-grossing idle game in both US Q1 and Q3 2025 lists [E] [S6] [S7]. Merge-2 overall was $1.4B (+80%) in 2025 [E, AppMagic] [S5].

Local-theme idle wave. Indonesia: Warung Seblak Nusantara (Gambir Game Studio, May 2024) passed 500K downloads in its first month [M, voi.id] [S31]; Play tier 1M+, IAP Rs 20-280, updated 4 May 2026 [M] [S32], but rated ~2.6 stars [M, Play listing via search] [S32]; Warung Angkringan Nusantara 5M+ [M] [S33]. Turkish doner: Donerci: Kebab Shop Tycoon (dev "ozguro", 100+ installs, updated 15 Sep 2026) and Kebab Shop: Idle Food Tycoon (dev "dahitech", Adana setting, 100+ installs, updated 13 Oct 2026) [M] [S34][S35]. A tapas idle tycoon: *unknown*, none found. [I] The "local" wave is real in Indonesia (millions of installs, local-language), but doner/tapas examples are hobby-scale; nobody has shipped a local-theme idle with first-tier polish.

Mini-sim / Supermarket-Simulator-likes. Supermarket Manager Simulator (Digital Melody, Poland) reached #1 weekly global downloads in spring 2024, monetising only with rewarded and interstitials and judged "under-monetized" [O, Lancaric, 17 May 2024] [S36]; Manage Supermarket Simulator (Zego, Vietnam) did 23.2M downloads in June 2024, all Google Play [E, AppMagic via WN Hub, 4 Jul 2024] [S37]; My Supermarket Simulator 3D hit 14.9M Play downloads in Sep 2024 [E, FoxData] [S38]. In 2026 two "Supermarket Simulator" apps sit at 10M+ (3.4 and 4.3 stars) [M] [S39]. [I] This wave is first-person and active, not idle; its relevance to Dhaba Rush is theme appetite (shop-running fantasy), not loop.

3. Feature matrix

Legend: hands-off = income flows without input; "tap" = tap-to-collect/boost; *unknown* = not verifiable from store pages, patch notes, reviews or press.

Game (dev, launch)	Loop / activity	Progression	Upgrade axes	Staff / managers	Tasks	Boosts	Offline	Monetisation (placements, IAP)	Live-ops	Social
Idle Supermarket Tycoon (Codigames, 2018) [S18][S19]	Shoppers walk departments, pay at tills; hands-off + tap	One supermarket grows, then further supermarkets/cities (reviews cite Beverly Hills, Miami; "gets easier as you move to different cities" [R, Jul 2022])	Department level/price, sellers, research (Laboratory, Aug 2026), marketing, parking	Sellers with salaries; **managers added 2026**; board managers for events (Oct 2026); General Manager IAP $9.99	Missions; Orders system (Aug 2026)	Ad x2 away-earnings, VIP car ad	Yes (away-time money, ad to double)	Rewarded only, "no forced ads" [R]; IAP $0.99-$99.99: No Ads $11.99, Event VIP Pass $4.99, gems $0.99-$19.99, Quality Seal $5.99	Weekly events, retro-supermarket event (May 2026), "longer weekly events" + dice generator (Oct 2026)	Game Center; clubs *unknown*
Eatventure (Lessmore, 2022) [S16][S29][S28][S30]	Automated kitchen stations; hands-off + tap	**Stage reset**: 60 cities x 7 restaurants, loops forever; items/boxes persist	Stations, staff speed, perks, avatar items, pets (Sep 2026)	Workers; manager = player avatar with items; Invite Helper	Achievements (Mar 2025), story quests, restaurant race	Stackable boosts (Apr 2026), permanent 2x	Yes	Rewarded (investor ad, "watching ads actually helps you" [R]); IAP $1.09-$109.99: Permanent Boost $5.39, Event Pass $10.99, chests $2.19-$13.99, gem bundles	Weekly rotating events; Potion Shop (Apr 2025), Farmer's Harvest minigame (May 2025); chest drop-rate screen (Aug 2026)	Restaurant race, clubs, leaderboards
Pizza Ready! (Supercent, 2023) [S10][S29b][S12][S9]	Arcade-idle: joystick avatar carries pizzas; **active**	Stage-based: finish a shop, open next location ("Just shop hop" [R, Aug 2026])	Player/staff speed and capacity, ovens, stations	Chefs, cashiers, robots that recharge every 3 min via ad/gems; **service table system where staff deliver food (Nov 2025)**	Special missions; weekly food contest (Jun 2026)	Rewarded speed-ups, 15-second "take a break" interstitials	Yes	Interstitial + rewarded + banner; ~70% ad revenue [E]; IAP $0.99-$49.99: No Ads $3.99, weekly premium pack $5.99, battle pass $8.99, growth offer $9.99	Christmas event (Dec 2025), attendance system + skins (Jun 2026); 2-3 releases/month	Social-follow rewards; leaderboards *unknown*
Idle Restaurant Tycoon: Empire (Kolibri, Dec 2020) [S40]	Star chef cooks, staff serve; hands-off	Multiple restaurants "worldwide", renovations	Dishes, stations, star chef, staff	Star chef + staff per restaurant	*unknown*	Income boosts (IAP $4.99/$9.99)	Yes (official)	Rewarded; IAP: No Ads $10.99/$12.99, Season Pass $4.99, All-In $29.99, gems	Weekly events, season pass; 2025-26 notes are bug fixes only	*unknown*
Idle Food Bar: Idle Games (MAGIC SEVEN CO., LIMITED) [S41]	Street stall grows to restaurant; hands-off	Stall to restaurant; stages *unknown*	*unknown*	Hire staff	Ad-gated tasks ("1 more ad to finish a task" [R])	Investor ad	*unknown*	Rewarded only ("doesn't have any of those pop up ads" [R, 18 Oct 2026]); IAP Rs 55-Rs 10,200	*unknown*	*unknown*; 5M+, 3.7 stars, 43.7K reviews

Game (dev, launch)	Loop / activity	Progression	Upgrade axes	Staff / managers	Tasks	Boosts	Offline	Monetisation (placements, IAP)	Live-ops	Social
Roadside Empire: Idle Tycoon (Highcore Labs, Nov 2024) [S42] [S43]	Gas station, car wash, hotel, parking; hands-off + tap	Multiple locations rebuilt in turn ("go to different locations trying to rebuild" [R, Jan 2025])	Vehicles, facilities, technologies, boosters	Card-based managers; 17 managers + managers from level 1 (Aug 2026); "bourbon" resource gates them	Quests, expeditions, Daily Stories (Dec 2025), Fuel/Special Orders	Boosters, x2	Yes, no internet needed	Rewarded + forced interstitials when you decline [R]; IAP $0.99-$99.99: Permanent x2 Income $9.99, Big Boss (no ads + daily gems + offline rewards) $18.99, event offers	Gold Rush, Gem Extraction, Tank-o-rama, Burning Fest, Card Madness, BBQ Season; ~2 releases/month	Competitive mini-games, daily challenges
Travel Center Tycoon (Wuhan Sonow, 2022) [S44]	Desert gas station grows into truck stop; hands-off	One location grows	Facilities, staff	Hire staff	*unknown*	*unknown*	Yes, vault-capped	Rewarded + offers ("too many icons on the screen" [R, Oct 2026]); IAP Rs 90-Rs 9,100	Stamp collection from special trucks; events *unknown*	*unknown*; 10M+, 4.5 stars, 120K reviews
Truck Stop Tycoon (geyu tian, 2022) [S45]	Build restrooms, shops, restaurants for truckers; hands-off	One plot grows; parking expands	Facilities, speed of service, "profit vs service quality"	Hire and train staff; builders/investors sold as packs	*unknown*	*unknown*	Yes (reviews), vault-capped	Forced ads [R]; IAP $0.99-$29.99: No More Ads $9.99, piggy bank $2.99, Senior Team $29.99	2025-26 notes are bug fixes only	*unknown*; iOS 4.7, 63K ratings
Idle Miner Tycoon (Kolibri, Jul 2016) [S14] [S15][S46]	Mine, transport, sell, upgrade; hands-off	Many mines/continents; event mines; Frontier Mines	Shafts, elevator, warehouse, skill trees	Managers, Super/Legendary managers	*unknown*	Tesseract, Blast perk	Yes	"Pay or wait": ~8 ads per session, 52% ad engagement [M, Kolibri]; IAP $0.49-$99.99: Double Cash $6.99, Premium Pass $9.99, starter $4.99	Weekly updates (160+), event mines "would often double our revenue for a weekend", season pass "huge for our revenue", Green Game Jam (Jun 2026), Spooky Season	8-league system

4. What the leaders shipped in 2025-2026 (table stakes now)

1. **A manager/card layer on top of upgrades.** Idle Supermarket Tycoon added leveling managers in 2026 and board managers for events (Oct 2026) [M] [S19]; Roadside Empire moved managers to level 1 and added 17 more (Aug 2026) [M] [S42]; Idle Miner keeps adding Super Managers [M] [S15]. Players push back when managers gate progress: "they changed it by adding managers you have to level up in order to proceed... Now it's pay-to-win" [R, Play, 23 Aug 2026] [S18]; "you will never have enough bourbon" [R, Play, 13 Dec 2025] [S43].
2. **Weekly events plus an event/season pass, every week.** Eatventure: Potion Shop event (Apr 2025), Farmer's Harvest minigame (May 2025) [M] [S29]; Pizza Ready: Christmas event (Dec 2025), attendance calendar and weekly food contest with skins (Jun 2026) [M] [S29b]; Idle Supermarket: "Longer weekly events" (Oct 2026) [M] [S19]. Industry-wide, average live-ops events per game rose from 73 to 89 per month during 2025; hybrid-casual averaged 64; race events are in 70% of top casual games; 96% ran a holiday event [E, AppMagic, Aug 2025 / May 2026] [S27][S47].
3. **Secondary economies.** Idle Supermarket: Laboratory research, Orders, Gold Bars (Aug 2026) [M] [S19]; Roadside: Fuel Orders, Special Orders, Daily Stories [M] [S42]; Eatventure: pets, stackable boosts [M] [S29].
4. **Serving staff as a mechanic.** Pizza Ready replaced pickup tables with "a service table system where staff deliver food" and upgraded its cleaning robot into a service robot (8 Nov 2025) [M] [S29b]. [I] The market leader has converged on exactly Dhaba Rush's waiter twist, which validates the idea and removes its novelty.
5. **Transparency and QoL.** Eatventure shipped a chest-probability screen and bulk box buying (Jul-Aug 2026) [M] [S29].
6. **Standard IAP ladder.** Every comp sells: remove ads ($3.99-$12.99), permanent x2 income ($5-$10), a pass ($4.99-$10.99), gems/hard currency, and bundled offers. Starter packs appear at $4.99-$6.99 [M] [S10][S15] [S29][S42].
7. **Delayed first ad.** Supercent's stated rule is first ad at ~3 minutes; its lower-ad title Snake Clash had 33% of reviews praising minimal ads [M, PR] [S9].

5. Where the gaps are

- **Nobody serves India on purpose.** 0% of the top India simulation games are by Indian developers [M, Feb 2025] [S23]; the only Indian-themed idle tycoons are hobby builds (Idle Indian Restaurant Tycoon by KeK Game Factory c. 2022; an Oct 2025 "Indian Restaurant Simulator 3D" APK; chai-tycoon GitHub/itch projects) [M] [S48]. Yet simulators are India's #1 download genre [E] [S21] and Pizza Ready is top-4 [E] [S22].
- **Western price ladders in rupees.** Idle Food Bar tops out at Rs 10,200 and Travel Center Tycoon at Rs 9,100 per item on the India store [M] [S41][S44]; in a market where ads are 70% of revenue [E] [S3], a Rs 299 x2 pack is already mid-ladder.
- **Ad fatigue is the #1 complaint in every comp** [R]: Pizza Ready (every 60 seconds), Roadside Empire ("forced ads when you decline watching an ad", remove-ads "almost $40"), Truck Stop ("Don't expect to get ANYWHERE... without spending money or watching ads"), Idle Food Bar ("at least 75% of them bug out") [S10] [S43][S45][S41].
- **Progress walls that look like bugs.** Travel Center's vault level 10 ("There is no way to reach Level 11", reviews May and Sep 2026, "everyone is saying from past 2 years") [R] [S44]; Truck Stop's "money vault limit" [R] [S45].
- **Repetition after the first hour.** "same food, same dishes, every other country, it gets tiring" [R, Eatventure, 4 Sep 2026] [S16]; "Addicting but no progression. Just shop hop" [R, Pizza Ready, Aug 2026] [S29b]; "the fun factor has continuously dropped with each restaurant" [R, Idle Restaurant Tycoon, May 2022] [S40]; "once... the game is just playing itself it isn't worth it" [R, Idle Miner, 5 Sep 2026] [S14].
- **Pop-up overload on open.** "so many pop ups when you first load in... especially for those who paid for no ads" [R, Idle Miner, 6 Sep 2026] [S14]; "too many icons on the screen. I just want to play" [R, Travel Center, 18 Oct 2026] [S44]. [I] This is the same "UI confusing" signal Dhaba Rush's testers gave on 21 Oct; the leaders have it too, and players notice.

- **Dhaba Rush versus table stakes [I].** It has none of items 1-3 in section 4 (no managers, no weekly events, no second location/prestige) and content ends at ~1-1.5 h; every comp above ships multiple locations or a stage loop plus a weekly event cadence.

6. Retention and monetisation benchmarks

All-genre mobile (GameAnalytics). 2025 report (data through 2024, 11,600 games): D1 top-25% 26.5-27.7% (iOS 31-33%, Android 25-27%), bottom-25% 10-11.5%; D7 median 3.4-3.9%, top-25% 7-8%; 75% of games under 3% D28; median session 5-6 min (top-25% 8-9); ~4 sessions/day; median daily playtime 22 min; Asia sessions ~5 min and playtime 21-22 min [E, Feb 2025] [S49]. 2026 report (16,262 games): D1 median ~22%, top-10% ~40%, top-1% 64-68%; D7 median just under 4%, top-10% 11-12%; D30 median 0.69-0.79%, top-25% 1.6-1.8%; top-25% play 5.3-5.7 sessions/day of ~5.2 min; D1 fell in 2025 versus 2024 [E, Jun 2026] [S50]. Simulation genre averages in the 2025 cut: D7 2.4%, D30 0.5% (casual 3.3% / 0.7%) [E, via Mistplay, Nov 2025] [S51].

Idle-specific. GameAnalytics idle study (Dec 2020, the last public idle breakout): stickiness 18% vs 10.5% hyper-casual; 5.3 sessions/day; ~8-min sessions; ARPDAU "nine times" hyper-casual; top-10% D1 45.6%, top-25% 39.4%; top-10% playtime 34.9 min/day [E] [S52]. Appodeal 2025 (US Android, Jun 2024-Jan 2025, >10K games): Idle games serve 73.2 rewarded videos per user (Merge-3 101.5); Management Sim D1 49%; pure hypercasual+simulation grouped at ~3% D30 and $0.79 ARPU [E] [S53]. Arcade-idle: ~50% D1, 25-min D0 playtime, ~$0.40 CPI [E, Sensor Tower/Homa via Udonis, May 2025] [S24]. Kolibri's own Idle Miner numbers: ~10-min sessions, ~8 ads/session, 52% ad engagement, prototype D1 63-81% [M, Feb 2025] [S46].

Benchmarks for the top end. Top-25 casual D7 14.9% (Dec 2025); Tasty Travels ~22% D7 [E, Sensor Tower] [S1] [S2]. Merge leaders' ARPDAU: Travel Town $0.35, Gossip Harbor $0.26 (Q1 2025) [E] [S54].

ARPDAU ranges (unattributed vendor compilation, Mar 2026): casual ads-only $0.01-0.05; hypercasual $0.03-0.08; hybrid-casual with 40-60% IAP $0.15-0.50 [O] [S55]. Rewarded video was 17.7% of all ad impressions in 2025 (+53.9% YoY) [E, Sensor Tower] [S1]; Unity's 2024 report puts engagement with the best reward types at ~30% [E, via Mistplay] [S51].

India. Ads = 70.3% of game revenue (Jan-May 2026) [E] [S3]. TopOn H1 2025 (secondhand via [S55]): rewarded eCPM in South Asia/India $0.10 versus $8.90 in EU/NA; India Android interstitial eCPM $0.47. India casual CPI ~Rs 78 ($0.89) versus a $1.80 global median [E, AppTweak 2025 via vendor] [S56]. India hyper-casual ARPDAU "~$0.02" and D1 25-35% / D7 5-10% are vendor guesses with no dataset [O] [S56]. No AppsFlyer or Sensor Tower India retention benchmark for idle exists publicly as of Oct 2026.

[I] Implication for the 15 Dec India launch: at $0.10 rewarded eCPM, a player watching 8 rewarded ads/day (the Idle Miner rate) yields under $0.001/day; India revenue will have to come from volume and from the Rs 299 x2 / remove-ads purchases, so D1 above ~40% (idle top-10% territory) and a weekly reason to return matter more than ad density.

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Case study: Idle Supermarket Tycoon (Codigames)

Researched 2026-10-31. Labels used throughout: **[fact]** = measured or officially stated, **[estimate]** = third-party tracker, **[opinion]** = player/press view, **[inference]** = my reading.

1. Launch history and the Codigames portfolio

- Codigames (legal name Digital Things S.L. until Feb 2025, now Codigames S.L.) was founded in 2013 in Valencia by cousins Francisco José Martínez (CEO) and Zacarías Gómez (Product Manager / Game Designer), both from Murcia. Lanzadera (Juan Roig's accelerator, first cohort) backed it; Angels (Roig's fund) invested. In Aug 2019 the founders bought back most of the company from Caixa Capital Risc, Faraday and Angels; Angels stayed as sole outside investor. **[fact]** (AlicantePlaza 17 Feb 2020; Xataka 19 Jan 2020; Valencia Plaza 2 Oct 2025)
- PocketGamer.biz reported a $1M round in July 2016 when the studio was still making Dungeon Legends, a dungeon crawler. Before idle tycoons Codigames had shipped Empire of Sun, Lords & Castles, Dungeon Legends (over EUR 1M revenue) and "more than 20 prototypes". **[fact]** (PocketGamer.biz 2016; Xataka 2020)
- The idle-tycoon pivot: Idle Airport Tycoon released on iOS 13 Nov 2018 **[fact]** (App Pricing Lab). Idle Supermarket Tycoon's iOS release date is listed as 7 Feb 2019 **[fact]** (App Pricing Lab), but a Canadian App Store review is dated 5 Jan 2019, so a late-2018 soft launch is likely **[inference]** (apps.apple.com/ca). Guides appeared 9 Feb 2019 (TouchTapPlay) and 27 Feb 2019 (LevelWinner); v1.1.0 added a Real Estate Agency, new missions and London/Tokyo/Hong Kong "a few weeks" after launch (Gamezebo).
- 2019 was the breakout year: four launches (Idle Supermarket Tycoon, Idle Theme Park Tycoon [29 May 2019], Idle Fitness Gym Tycoon, Hotel Empire Tycoon) passed 60M downloads combined by Feb 2020, mostly US/Canada; Idle Supermarket Tycoon hit #1 most-downloaded strategy game in the US in May 2019, ahead of Clash Royale and Clash of Clans. **[fact, company-stated]** (AlicantePlaza; AZARplus 19 Feb 2020; Xataka). Merca2 (16 Mar 2020) claims "more than 10 million downloads" in the US at that peak **[unverified press figure]**.
- Later portfolio (all idle/empire tycoons): Prison Empire Tycoon (2020), Idle Police Tycoon (2020), Idle Life Sim, University Empire Tycoon (2021), Law Empire Tycoon, Idle Dinosaur Park Tycoon (Feb 2022), Idle Burger Empire Tycoon, Hospital Empire Tycoon, TV Empire Tycoon, Idle Town Master. DeVuego counts 46 titles. **[fact]** (AlicantePlaza 15 Sep 2021; DeVuego; AppBrain listings). Note: I found no Codigames "Idle Zoo"; the "Idle Zoo Tycoon" on stores is by other publishers.
- Codigames' own site today lists only five live flagships: Idle Theme Park Tycoon, Prison Empire Tycoon, Idle Town Master, Hotel Empire Tycoon, Idle Supermarket Tycoon. **[fact]** (codigames.com/games)

2. Numbers: downloads, revenue, ratings over time

Company revenue (official filings as reported by Spanish press, EUR):

Year	Revenue	Profit	Source
2017	0.61M	-0.45M	Xataka (Registro Mercantil)
2018	1.5-1.6M	+0.5M (first break-even)	AlicantePlaza, Xataka
2019	44M	EBITDA >20M, margin >45%	AlicantePlaza, AZARplus
2020	71.8M	18M net; 15M dividend	AlicantePlaza 15 Sep 2021
2021	38.1M	12.3M	El Economista Dec 2022 (via search)
2022	32.8M	9M	Valencia Plaza 29 Feb 2024
2023	18M	2-2.4M, Q4 loss	Valencia Plaza 2024/2025

Year	Revenue	Profit	Source
2024	20.36M (+11.7%)	4.88M; 8.4M spent on UA	Valencia Plaza 2 Oct 2025

All **[fact]**. 30M EUR in dividends were paid 2020-2022. In Feb-Mar 2024 an ERE cut ~20 of 88 staff; average headcount fell from 90 to 67. The company said its "free-to-play model has not worked for over a year", UA costs had risen, "el mercado no absorbe los proyectos que han desarrollado en los últimos ejercicios", and it "stopped new launches and is focusing on improving its earlier games" (Valencia Plaza 29 Feb 2024). Revenue comes via Apple, Google and AppLovin **[fact]**.

Game-level figures:

- Google Play: 10M+ install tier; US store 4.1 stars from ~600K reviews, "Updated on Oct 14, 2026", IAP $0.99-$129.99 per item, "Contains ads" **[fact, pulled 31 Oct 2026]**. India store: 4.0 stars, 313,745 reviews **[fact]**. AppBrain estimates ~32M lifetime Android downloads (Idle Theme Park ~30M, Hotel Empire ~26M) **[estimate]**.
- App Store US: 4.6 from 149K ratings, 572.6 MB, 9+ (loot boxes, advertising); CA 4.5 from 17K; PH 4.5 from 2.6K **[fact]**.
- Sensor Tower public snapshots: iOS US ~40K downloads and ~$8K revenue per month (snapshot roughly early 2024); Google Play US "<5K downloads, <$5K revenue" per month (snapshot roughly late 2025); Middle East Q3 2021 weekly revenue $315-726 with 12.5-13K weekly actives **[estimate]**. No lifetime revenue estimate was published anywhere I could reach; AppMagic/IGDA's 2022 idle-tycoon ranking lists only Law Empire Tycoon (#16, $0.8M net IAP Jan-Apr 2022) from Codigames **[estimate]**.
- Rating trend: 4.6-4.7 on iOS has held since 2019 (App Pricing Lab 147.1K at 4.6 in Apr 2026); Android sits lower (4.0-4.1) with the Aug 2026 reviews (post-4.0 managers) all 1-2 stars **[fact]** (see section 5).

3. The design

The first 3 minutes (as documented by 2019-2022 guides)

"You begin with a tiny shop selling only vegetables. A tutorial walks you through the main objectives before your assistant leaves you in charge. Everything is done by tapping, and the article says you can't lose money." (Gamezebo, updated 15 May 2020) **[fact]**. Mobile Gaming Hub (18 Feb 2022): "The supermarket runs itself, and your main job is spending money on upgrades. You start with a produce stall, and later unlock a bakery, a tech store, and more." The HUD: earnings-per-minute top-left; bar-graph "management" icon top-right (red = bottleneck: parking usage, checkout queue, per-department income); dollar icon shows the cash needed for the next city and previews later locations and their multipliers; check-mark/exclamation icon = missions; wrench icon = Epic Upgrades; play icon = 2x ad boost (Gamezebo; LevelWinner 27 Feb 2019) **[fact]**.

Departments: Level Up / Hire / Processing

- Unlock order in the first store: Produce, Bakery, Butcher, Seafood, then Clothing, Perfume, Electronics; later stores add Jewelry, Car Dealership, Real Estate (LevelWinner; AppGamer) **[fact]**. The fan wiki records per-department "Base Processing" times (e.g. Seafood 00:00:10) and cashier speed starting at 5 customers/min at level 1 (idle-supermarket.fandom.com, via search snippet) **[fact, unverified page]**.
- "Leveling up a product brings more customers and raises its value per sale" (Mobile Gaming Hub). "If you want to upgrade productivity, you will need to hire an extra employee. Make sure to upgrade his/her salary upon all additional upgrades" (LevelWinner/TopGames). Official Helpshift tips: "Add staff or raise their pay to cut customer waiting. Hire more cashiers and upgrade their checkout spots. Expanding the parking area brings in more customers per minute. Store managers will also increase productivity by 50%." **[fact, official]**
- Upgrades change the department's look, not just a stat: "Lots of upgrades, plus when you upgrade it's not just a stat boost" (App Store review, Asimon18, 18 Feb 2019) **[opinion]**.
- Product tiers / Evolve (added ~late 2022): "push one product's progress bar to its final marked goal. The specific product will evolve into a more sophisticated one, and customers will pay much more for it" (Helpshift). The first version gated evolution behind a 3-hour timer or an ad; see complaints in section 5.

Cashiers, parking, trucks, marketing

"Hire more cashiers and upgrade them when more than 3 customers are queuing" (LevelWinner). Parking at ~100% usage loses customers; paying at the parking meter doubles spaces; the same menu sells adverts that raise customers/min. Delivery trucks pay out cash when tapped and stack up to 4 (TouchTapPlay 9 Feb 2019). The Express Lane upgrade matters later for slow, high-ticket departments (jewelry, electronics). **[fact]**

Tasks (missions) and rewards

Missions pay gems; one active at a time; "A new mission appears right after you claim a reward, and some may already be complete, so you can claim them immediately" (TopGames; Gamezebo). Targets "grow substantially" as you progress; offline-served customers may not count (TouchTapPlay). 3.0.1 (20 Oct 2023) "Improved mission rewards". The tasks-bar-with-chest presentation that Dhaba Rush copied is not described in any source I could reach; the pre-3.0 UI used a check-mark icon **[gap]**.

Boosts and the ad economy

- 2x income for 1 hour per rewarded ad; six consecutive ads = 6 hours plus a daily gem bonus (35 gems for 5 ads in Feb 2019; LevelWinner says +5 gems per consecutive day). VIP gold car: tap, watch ad, big cash or gems. Bus/vehicle icons offer timed boosts: Express Checkout (2 min), Extra Customers, Express Lane (instant service). Offline earnings: 2 hours by default, 10 hours with the $9.99 General Manager; on return, watch an ad to double or pay 20 gems to triple. **[fact]** (LevelWinner; Gamezebo; TouchTapPlay)
- Codigames' stated stance (Xataka, Jan 2020): ad policy "is not intrusive, because the player decides whether to watch the video"; ads and IAP "generate very similar revenue, with a slight edge for micropayments; more players use the videos"; the declared priority is retention over either. **[fact, company-stated]**

Managers and Epic Upgrades

Gems buy permanent Epic Upgrades from the wrench menu: financial ones (Tax Cuts, Labor Subsidy, VIP Marketing), customer ones (Compulsive Customers, Family Marketing), cashier speed (Robotic Assistance), per-department managers (+50% productivity, one-time) **[fact]**. "Epic upgrades ... persist across neighborhoods" (TouchTapPlay). A separate, levelled "manager" system arrived with 4.0 (Jan 2026) and is the most-hated change in 2026 reviews **[inference from reviews]**; 4.3.0 (Oct 2026) adds event "board managers Marcus, Raya and Mia".

Cities: the prestige-like loop

"When you can afford a bigger store, you sell the current one and open a new one in another city. Department levels, parking, and advertising reset" (Gamezebo). First store Miami Beach, then Beverly Hills; 1.1.0 added London, Tokyo, Hong Kong. Earnings are "multiplied by at least x50" per move (LevelWinner, 2019). Official: "Once you sell the previous supermarket, you won't be able to go back ... all the items previously unlocked can be built and used in the new supermarket ... Multipliers when moving to a new city are accumulative" (Helpshift). Big-number scale runs to tredecillions (Helpshift money FAQ). So the carry-over is: unlocked building types, Epic Upgrades, gems, and a cumulative income multiplier; everything else resets. **[fact]**

Events, seasonal content, the 3.0 update

- App Store version history **[fact]**: 3.0.0 (9 Oct 2023) "New game modes, balance changes, visual rework, and much more"; 3.0.2 (29 Oct 2023) "New interface, improved readability and usability"; 3.0.3 "Bug fixes in customer queues"; 3.1.0 (15 Nov 2023) "New supermarket and new shops! Get quality stars and use stellar upgrades"; 3.1.3 "Fixed tutorial error"; 3.2.x (Mar-May 2024) maintenance; 4.0.0 (28 Jan 2026, Uptodown); 4.1.2-4.1.6 (May-Jun 2026) "New event available! Visit the retro supermarket"; 4.2.1 (Aug 2026) "Explore the Laboratory with dozens of research upgrades, complete orders with the new Orders system, Gold Bars, Ultimate Research"; 4.3.0 (21 Oct 2026) longer weekly events, board managers, Dice Generator, Lucky Pass, "new event offers".
- Events existed earlier: a review from 29 Oct 2019 mentions "franchise events" with shelf purchases; a PH review (May 2022) describes event income milestones; an Event VIP Pass ($4.99) is live. I found no Halloween/Christmas-specific content **[gap]**.

4. Monetization (current SKUs)

App Store IAP list (Apr 2026, App Pricing Lab) **[fact]**: No more Ads $11.99; Event VIP Pass $4.99; Blue Card Offer $4.99; Gold Card Offer $9.99; General Manager $9.99 (10h offline); Quality Seal $5.99; gems 80/$0.99, 500/$4.99, 1200/$9.99, 2500/$19.99; average IAP $8.39. Google Play ranges to $129.99 (US) and about INR 10,700 per item (India). Rewarded placements: 2x button, VIP car, bus/vehicle boosts, offline double, evolve-now, mission skips. 2019 players stressed "There are no forced ads" (Lyssa216, 26 Feb 2019); by 2023-2026 players report "You have to watch an ad every two minutes now" (CA, Zoe <3 :), 5 Jul 2023) and "way more ads to watch" (US Play, Aug 2026). Whether that is interstitials or denser rewarded prompts is not determinable from reviews **[gap]**. The classic x2-income VIP IAP described in the task is not in the current SKU list; the "x2 money option" players mention in 2026 is the Gold/Blue card offer **[inference]**.

5. What reviews praise and hate (verbatim)

Praise:

- "It's a great Idle game and even with notifications on doesn't consistently bother you to return" (App Store US, Asimon18, 18 Feb 2019)
- "To progress in this game, all you have to do is come back to the game often, wait, and upgrade." (App Store US, Lyssa216, 26 Feb 2019)
- "All in all, it's a very nice game with no invasive pop-up ads" (App Store US, Pepperam, 29 Oct 2019)
- "Gameplay is smooth and bug free. Though the game gets easier as you move to different cities. But there isn't much variety in achievements as we progress." (Google Play India, Y N V Kiran, 8 Jul 2022, 3 stars, 651 helpful)
- "I am not really angry at the new update ... They added managers and events now." (App Store US, pburton27, Jun 17, year not shown)

Hate:

- "95% of the game is watching ads to get somewhere with your store." (App Store CA, justanotherrname, 5 Jan 2019)
- "Amazing game, but kind of too many ad based boosts" - VIP car reward "seemed to rise each time it was declined" (App Store US, Ty12345678910b, 1 Mar 2019)
- "the cash jump is unbelievably huge and very hard to get to now" (App Store US, Staples Giftbag, undated)
- "Every time I click on the VIP car and try to start the ad, it doesn't work and the car just drives off" (Google Play India, Prem Jadhav, 6 May 2022, 4 stars, 865 helpful)
- "the 3 hours that it takes to upgrade the shop and multiply profits, absolutely ridiculous ... STOP EXPERIMENTING WITH THE GAME" (Google Play India, Uday Bhanu Garg, 17 Jan 2023, 3 stars; Codigames replied it would "be collecting the players' feedback")
- "I hate having to watch an ad or wait 3 hours just to evolve my department" (App Store CA, Not_TRAILBOI, 19 Mar 2023)
- "they changed it by adding managers you have to level up in order to proceed. It's basically impossible to progress at a certain point without paying ... Now it's pay-to-win." (Google Play US, Kelsey, 23 Aug 2026, 1 star)
- "This game used to be very fun around 2019-2020. But after the tutorial phase, progress slows down so much that you're basically forced to buy the x2 money option ... Overall, the tutorial is fun but not really much fun after that." (Google Play US, Samantha Smith, 17 Aug 2026, 2 stars)
- "but hey let's give everyone 700 gold and reset years of gameplay. pathetic. I've had it for almost 9 years." (Google Play US, Speedy, 16 Aug 2026, 1 star)

All **[opinion]**; JustUseApp's NLP split on the iOS reviews is 59.5% positive / 35.8% negative (undated page).

6. What Codigames has said

- Design: the first idle prototype was a farm game, "less realistic"; they moved to tycoon because "nobody was working that dynamic"; goal was simulation and business "sin añadir mucha complejidad, porque es un juego móvil"; players "no pagan con dinero, sino con su tiempo"; idle, short sessions, with the ambition of an experience "that lasts several years" (Xataka, 19 Jan 2020) **[fact]**.
- Business: "crecer horizontalmente" (many titles, no single bet); target markets US, UK, Canada, Australia; Spain is "only 2-3%" of revenue; "Aquí somos 40 millones de personas, y allí 300" (Zacarías Gómez, Xataka) **[fact]**.
- Origin: "El promotor de todo esto es Juan Roig, presidente de Mercadona y uno de nuestros socios" (Francisco Martínez, Xataka) **[fact]**.
- 2024 retrenchment quotes are in section 2. Third-party analyst view: "Codigames mostly focuses on theme changes and improving production values with its reskins" (Naavik, 6 Oct 2021) **[opinion]**. AppMagic/IGDA (29 Jun 2022) warn that copiers "usually underestimate the complexity of the game design" - a "cargo cult" approach **[opinion]**.
- I found no GDC talk, PocketGamer.biz interview, Deconstructor of Fun or GameRefinery teardown of this game **[gap]**.

7. How it stayed alive since 2018 [inference from the record above]

1. A cheap, reusable engine: one codebase, many themes (Naavik's "reskins"), so each title's UA could be paid by portfolio cash.
2. Rewarded-ad-first monetization that early players read as fair ("not pay to win"), feeding ~50/50 ad/IAP revenue.
3. The city loop as a soft prestige: a x50+ cumulative multiplier each move gave weeks of goals without new content.
4. Steady content drops when revenue fell: 3.0 visual/UI rework (Oct 2023) within months of the 2023 collapse, new supermarket and quality stars (Nov 2023), then after the 2024 ERE a pivot to "improving earlier games": 4.0, recurring retro-supermarket events, a Laboratory/Orders layer, board-game events and passes (2026).
5. The cost: each new monetized layer (Evolve timers 2023, levelled managers 2026) triggered 1-star waves from veterans, which is why Android sits at 4.0-4.1 while iOS keeps 4.6.

8. The 7 things that make it work

1. The machine is always visible: shoppers walk, queue, pay; earnings/min ticks; nothing can be lost (Gamezebo 2020). The fantasy is watching a business run.
2. One pane, three levers per department (level/price, staff/speed, processing) with the next affordable thing always obvious.
3. Explicit bottleneck feedback (red stats for queues and parking) turns "what do I buy" into a readable puzzle.
4. Visible cosmetic change on upgrade and unlock, so money buys appearance, not just numbers (Asimon18, 2019).
5. Optional, generous ad boosts that double income rather than gate progress, which 2019 reviews praised explicitly.
6. A long horizon from day one: the next-city price and multiplier preview on the HUD, gems from missions feeding permanent Epic Upgrades.
7. Cumulative city multipliers and carry-over of unlocked building types, so each reset feels like a promotion, not a punishment.

9. The 7 things players wish it did better

1. The post-tutorial wall: "progress slows down so much ... the tutorial is fun but not really much fun after that" (Aug 2026).

2. Price jumps between cities ("the cash jump is unbelievably huge").
3. Ad density creep and broken ad rewards (VIP car, bus, 2x button failing: India 2022, US 2019).
4. Timers bolted onto formerly instant actions (3-hour Evolve, 2023).
5. Levelled managers as a pay gate (2026) and resets of veteran progress.
6. Repetition and thin variety in missions/achievements ("there isn't much variety in achievements as we progress", 2022).
7. Lack of expression: "the only thing in the world I wanted was to build a nice big bakery and produce market" (Trig student, 12 Jan 2020); no layout or decoration choice.

10. Verdict on the first 3 minutes [inference]

Beats that carry the core and must survive any reskin:

- The hands-off sim loop with visible money flow and a per-minute number: this is the product. Dhaba Rush's waiter-and-seat twist changes the flow topology, so its first three minutes must teach that new bottleneck as clearly as Idle Supermarket teaches queues and parking, or testers will keep saying "hard to understand".
- The department sheet with three levers and an obviously affordable next step; the cost curve that lets a new player buy something every 10-20 seconds.
- A visible bottleneck readout (red = fix me). The reference pushes this through the management screen; Dhaba Rush's NEXT chip is the right instinct.
- The first new-department unlock within the session (chai -> tandoor) with a visible scene change.
- The rewarded 2x bubble framed as a gift, not a gate.
- A long-horizon preview: next-location price and multiplier on the HUD. Dhaba Rush has no second location, so its copy of the opening is a hook attached to nothing; reviews of the reference show that even with cities, the post-tutorial slope is where players quit.

Incidental beats (safe to re-theme or drop): the specific department list, the assistant character, parking meter, truck tap-to-collect, VIP car, bus boosts, mission chest styling, the 3.0 visual rework. These are flavour and ad surfaces, not the loop.

One warning from the data: the reference's own 2026 reviews say the only part that stays fun is the part Dhaba Rush copied. Copying the opening buys the first session; the city multiplier, Epic Upgrades and events are what bought Codigames seven more years.

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Case study: Eatventure (Lessmore) and Idle Restaurant Tycoon: Empire (Kolibri Games)

Research date: 31 Oct 2026. Labels: **[M]** measured/official fact, **[E]** third-party estimate (Sensor Tower / AppMagic), **[O]** quoted opinion, **[I]** my inference. Store ratings were read from the live Google Play listings on 31 Oct 2026 via curl; App Store figures from the live US pages.

1. Scoreboard (31 Oct 2026)

Game	Google Play	App Store	Downloads	Last update
Eatventure (Lessmore/Miniclip)	**4.7**, ~423K reviews [M]	**4.8**, 80K ratings [M]	50M+ (Play band) [M]; 69.3M lifetime [E, AppMagic via mobilegamer.biz, Mar 2025]	Play: 22 Oct 2026; iOS v1.55.5 23 Oct 2026 "Achievements rolled out to everyone" [M]
Idle Restaurant Tycoon: Empire (Kolibri)	**4.5**, ~196K reviews [M]	**4.7**, 18K ratings [M]	5M+ (Play band) [M]	Play: 22 Oct 2026; iOS v1.55.0 23 Oct 2026, "Bug fixes" (every entry since 1.50.0 in March says only "Bug fixes") [M]
Idle Supermarket Tycoon (Codigames, the reference Dhaba Rush copies)	**4.1**, ~600K reviews [M]	4.6, 149K ratings [M]	10M+ (Play band) [M]	Play: 14 Oct 2026 [M]

Revenue scale: Eatventure ~$28M IAP lifetime since Feb 2022 [E, AppMagic, mobilegamer.biz 4 Mar 2025]; 2024 alone 18.49M downloads and ~$10M IAP, #16 hybrid-casual game by IAP [E, AppMagic via NextBigGames, 17 Nov 2025]. Sensor Tower weekly snapshots: Q1 2024 US revenue peaked at $83K/week, WAU 298K to 249K [E]; Q1 2023 Europe WAU grew 593K to 715K [E]. Idle Restaurant Tycoon: ~$30K/month iOS US in June 2023 and ~$6K/month Google Play US in June 2024 [E, Sensor Tower public overview snippets]. IRT is a small, maintained title; Eatventure is the category leader by rating and the genre label ("Rockbite's take on eatventure-like idle games", Naavik, 15 Sep 2024).

2. Eatventure (Lessmore, acquired by Miniclip end-2024)

Who made it and how

- Lessmore: German, fully remote, founded 2021, three hands-on founders, no art team ("the art is developer-made"), core team ex-Kolibri, Popcore, LoadComplete, Rovio [M, PG.biz 26 Oct 2022; PG.biz/AppQuantum 20 Oct 2023]. "Raised only a tiny angel round" [M, Naavik 30 Nov 2022]. Grew "to millions in revenue with no marketing or data teams", UA done by "a couple of UA managers" [M, Singular case study].
- Launched Google Play first, then iOS, Dec 2021/Feb 2022 [M]. Second place, Very Big Indie Pitch, PGC Helsinki 2022 [M].
- Design philosophy, Sophie Brügmann (Lessmore), PG.biz 26 Oct 2022 [O]: it "starts as a simple hyper-casual game with little text and no big tutorial", strategy layers are added gradually "so players can move from hyper-casual to casual"; "We aim towards our visuals telling stories without requiring text."; "We can shoot out updates and create prototypes and enticing event levels rapidly."
- Miniclip CEO on why they bought it: "ability to quickly prototype innovative game concepts and release casual hits" [O, mobilegamer.biz 4 Mar 2025].

Core loop (what you watch, tap and get)

Sources: Level Winner guide (19 Mar 2023), Pocket Gamer tips (16 Jan 2023), fan wiki + eatventuretools.app (undated, 2025-26 content).

1. You start with a lemonade stand, one employee, one product. Staff take orders, make food and serve automatically. Customers "wait indefinitely, food never spoils, and you don't pay salaries or clean tables" [M, Level Winner]. The only pressure is throughput.
2. **The tap**: tap a station to upgrade it; each tap raises the cost and fills a progress bar; a full bar gives **1 gem and a star that doubles that product's profit** (stations go to Lv150). Upgrading also opens an extra staff slot at that station [M].
3. **New station** = a shaking dotted box that appears when an earnings threshold is hit. **New staff** arrive in a crate you tap to open. A permanent-upgrade menu (arrow button, sorted cheapest-first) sells food speed, profit, staff boosts and late-game "Overdrive" [M].
4. **Small pickups**: a Tip Jar vault item spawns glowing spinning coins on tables you tap; "Popular Dish" button makes customers favour one dish for a few minutes [M].
5. **The rewarded-ad anchor is a character, not a bubble**: "Investors" in black suits with suitcases and a shimmering aura walk in among customers from the third phase; tap one and watch an ad for a large cash boost; ignore it and it vanishes for a while [M, PG tips; Level Winner]. The main ad button adds a profit multiplier for 5 minutes, stackable to 1 hour; offline earnings cap at 3 hours and can be doubled by an ad [M].
6. **Finishing**: when everything is fully upgraded you **renovate** (stand to snack bar to cafe to fast-food, etc.) and eventually **sell up and move to the next city**; only Vault items (gem-bought permanent perks) carry over [M, Level Winner]. The wiki lists **60 unique cities, most with 7 restaurants** (New York, Toronto, San Diego, Pittsburgh have 6); after the 60th "the game resets you to City 1 to start a new loop" [M, eatventure-games.fandom.com/wiki/Cities; eatventuretools.app]. Clubs unlock at City 7 [M].

Session shape and pacing

- A new player on heavy play: "I've had some free time to play this game basically all day, and I'll say, I'm about to beat the first Level, San Francisco?" after ~4 days [O, Google Play, 11 Apr 2026, 5 stars]. The first city is a multi-day arc, not a 15-minute level [I].
- Experienced pace benchmark: "clearing one city a day" is the club-XP reference rate [M, eatventuretools.app].
- Session elasticity is a praised feature: "I can play intensely for 5 minutes or an hour, then put it down without sacrificing my position in the game." [O, Google Play AU, 16 Jan 2025, 5 stars].
- Mid-game dead air is the main design complaint: "It's slow, even at a decent level of 84, it still can take hours... You spend 10 minutes staring at a screen, waiting. Not to mention it's repetitive; same food, same dishes, every other country" [O, Google Play, 4 Sep 2026, 4 stars].

Meta, resets, and how long content lasts

- No classic prestige: the city sale is the reset, and the vault + gear is the carry-over. Gear (hat/body/hand, Common/Rare/Epic/Legendary, later Ultimate and Mythic) buffs the player's own character; duplicates are sacrificed to level pieces; Mythic blueprints come only from Club Boxes; Ultimate blueprints only from headline events [M, Level Winner; eatventuretools.app]. Pets added in patch 1.7.x; a second pet slot "in cities 120+" (i.e. second loop) [M, fan wiki patch notes].
- Content runway: 60 cities x ~7 restaurants at "a city a day" is months; after that a loop plus the gear/mythic chase. The AppQuantum analysis calls the design "free from cluttered mechanics and modes" with "a straightforward core loop", collection "adds depth", events "refresh weekly" [O, PG.biz 20 Oct 2023].

Live-ops calendar (as run in 2025-26) [M, eatventuretools.app/guides/events]

- Headline event every weekend Thu-Sun in a fixed 4-event cycle: Seaport, Moon, Mine, Middle Ages. Each is a separate, bigger restaurant "with longer processing times and more walking", its own currency and shop, gold medal unlocks harder difficulties [M, Level Winner; wiki update log].
- Potion Shop every week Sat-Tue (has a $10.99 Event Pass); Restaurant Race every Wednesday; Challenge Event and Merchant Event alternate Mon-Tue biweekly; Harvest roughly monthly; club seasons reset every 2 weeks.
- Store updates every 3-8 weeks in 2026: 1.52 (bulk box buying, Jun), 1.53.2 (chest-probability screen, Aug), 1.54 (pet delivery, Sep), 1.55.5 (Achievements, Oct) [M, App Store version history].

Monetization

- App Store IAP ladder: Daily Offer $0.99, Tiny Gems $2.19, Small Chest $2.19, Permanent (x2) Boost $5.39, Small Gems $5.39, Small Event Offer $5.39, Medium Gems $10.99, Event Pass $10.99, Medium Chest $13.99, Big Event Offer $26.99 [M]. AppQuantum (Oct 2023) judged it "restrained": no rewarded speed-ups, no starter pack, no no-ads SKU at the time, and estimated US revenue-per-download about double Cat Snack Bar's; US = 54.3% of revenue [E/O].
- All ads optional. This is the single most repeated praise across four years: "NO FORCED ADS" (App Store 2022); "All ads are optional... they don't force load you onto the app site for pressing close/skip... GAME IS IDLE (works whilst you're offline) GJ!" [O, Google Play GB, 8 Jun 2026, 5 stars]; "Doesn't overwhelm me with ads inside it but can watch them to get bonuses... It has become a must play before bed time" [O, Google Play IN, 11 Apr 2026, 5 stars].

What reviews hate

- Repetition: "repetitious after a while... I played it for a couple of days but have become bored" [O, Play AU, 25 Feb 2023, 3 stars]; "after a day or two yoll end up getting bored then delete it" [O, TapTap, 21 Dec 2025].
- Paid-then-broken: "I paid for extra content, including double cash... I've lost access to all the content I paid for... They basically just stole like thirty bucks from me" [O, Play GB, 5 Jun 2026, 1 star].
- Ad quality and reward failures: "Can't stop playing it but R rated ads???" and investor ads not paying out [O, App Store, 26 Sep 2022]; "the $5 '2x profit forever' purchase still requires ads" [O, App Store, 10 Dec 2022, "Completely Disappointed"].
- UI: "please move the club icon away from the bottom left. it's always blocking a cooking station" [O, Play, 1 Sep 2026, 5 stars].

3. Idle Restaurant Tycoon: Empire (Kolibri Games, 75% Ubisoft since Feb 2020)

Making of

- Built June-Dec 2020 by 9-12 people, fully remote, in ~6 months; Kolibri's first 3D isometric game; soft launch on Google Play Oct 2020 at 4.7 average, global 3 Dec 2020 [M, Kolibri press release Dec 2020; PG.biz "Making of", 17 Dec 2020].
- Gated process: "If at any point during this process, the game does not meet our requirements, we stop development and start on a new project." (Gordon Büttner, product director) [O].
- Two soft-launch fixes worth copying: many players stuck at one early tutorial point, so it was simplified and completion rose; a main rewarded-ad placement under-performed because "most missed it because it wasn't visually highlighted"; artists added visual tweaks and engagement rose [M, PG.biz 17 Dec 2020].

Core loop and the bottleneck design

- Explicit departure from Idle Miner Tycoon's "three bottleneck system" toward connected bottlenecks: upgrade the kitchen "so cooks deliver food on time", add tables for incoming customers, upgrade the entrance/reception. Each component adds to a Michelin-style star rating; enough stars unlock a new restaurant [M, PG.biz 17 Dec 2020].
- Concrete mechanics [M, Level Winner, 11 Dec 2020]: hosts seat customers (lobby holds the Tip Jar); the first restaurant has 8 tables; a door counter shows vacant tables and counts dirty tables as occupied, so cleaners matter; cooks set food speed ("extra cooks add speed but not quality"); each waiter serves two tables (four waiters for eight tables); parking upgrades bring more customers and parked cars earn a trickle; special staff run add-on rooms (milkshake bar, show cooking, karaoke); a power room gates appliances; "underpaid staff quit without warning".
- Readout: an Overview screen shows dining, service and parking profits and which tables earn most [M]. Bottleneck symptoms the guide teaches: customers turned away, long waits, tables stuck "occupied".
- This is the closest published analogue to Dhaba Rush's seats-and-waiters twist [I].

Resets, meta, content length

- Progress = stars to new restaurants; cards (15, four rarities, from gem chests at 125/320/750 or events) carry across restaurants and are the permanent layer; events return "a legendary card that will grant you 2% more revenue permanently" [O, player write-up on Medium; Level Winner]. No prestige.
- Event restaurants: weekly, start from scratch, last "a couple of days", earnings do not carry over, cards and milestone chests do [M].
- Content ran out and then stalled: "I finished all the restaurants already, and I can't get enough" [O, App Store via justuseapp]; "has had no meaningful content updates for over six months... The same weekly events over & over" [O, App Store, 14 Apr 2022]; "fun declined with each restaurant unlocked", citing pathfinding and a table that never gets cleaned [O, App Store, 19 May 2022]. The product director had promised "new restaurants that we will release after launch"; by 2026 the changelog is only "Bug fixes" [M].

Monetization and ad placements

- IAP: No Ads $10.99 / No more Ads Deal $12.99, gems $0.99-$9.99, Season Pass Ticket $4.99, All-In $29.99, income boosts $4.99/$9.99 [M, App Store].
- Rewarded placements [M, Level Winner]: Food Influencer pop-up (cash for an ad); Fast Forward to Morning (skips the closed-restaurant night lull); Ad Boost doubles earnings up to 1 hour, +12 minutes per ad; Get More Guests; Double Profits on return.
- Players felt the placement density: "Feels like I'm playing just to watch ads!... Watch an add for 10 minute boost. Watch an add to get cash. Buy one upgrade. Watch ad for extra customers. Then oops, boost's nearly up, watch another ad." [O, Play GB, 16 Aug 2021, 2 stars]; "repeatedly goads you into buying their ad skip, which is $15" [O, Play, 27 Sep 2021, 3 stars]; "Claims to be idle but you only get 1 hour of 'offline time'... why buy a cleaning cart and a vacuum for the cleaners when all they do is wave a duster about" [O, Play GB, 8 Nov 2020, 3 stars]; "when you're waiting to earn money, it's really boring because there's nothing to do" [O, Play, 9 May 2021, 3 stars].
- Praise: "a nicely different layout to their other tycoon games. Yes you can speed things up with ads but you don't have to... I've achieved gold on two restaurants now" [O, Play GB, 7 Jan 2022, 5 stars].

4. Kolibri's published design rules (Idle Miner Tycoon talks and blog)

- **Prototype before everything.** Idle Miner Tycoon's MVP shipped after ~8 weeks with no IAP, ads, social, localisation or cloud save and still hit D1 63-81% versus "roughly 40%" for most games [M, Nate Barker via GameAnalytics, updated 26 Feb 2025]; Stammler: IMT and Idle Factory Tycoon both reached D1 75% [M, PG.biz Quo Vadis, 8 Apr 2019]. The MVP "burned through users quickly, since players left once they finished the game" [M]. Content end equals churn.
- **Core loop on one screen**: Mine, Transport, Sell, Upgrade, each separated by a "choke point" that upgrades relax; everything visible so it is "easy to learn quickly, even in a short session" [M, GameAnalytics].
- **"Pay or wait."** "Players can't lose an idle game. They can only choose how fast to progress." Ads ~50-60% of revenue; ~8 ads per session; ad engagement 52%; sessions ~10 min [M, GameAnalytics; GameRefinery podcast 25 Mar 2021]. Kolibri's blog: IMT sessions ~7 min vs 5.5 min idle average; endgame players ~9 sessions/day; idle conversion ~0.5% [M, Kolibri blog 24 Aug 2020].
- **Best ad = return-to-game double offline earnings**, "players see it as soon as they enter"; placements must speed upgrades or raise payouts, stay optional, sit at natural breaks; low-value currency offers convert poorly [M, Barker, GameRefinery podcast 2021].
- **Live ops as retention, weekly**: 160+ updates (~1/week); event mines "often doubled revenue for a weekend"; staged rollout 1%/5%/20%/100% over four days [M, GameAnalytics]. Boosts (2x to 2,000x) are hoarded by most players and mostly spent in event mines; event mines are the main boost sink [M, Kolibri blog 21 Sep 2020].
- **Managers need to be reachable**: before Super Manager 2.0 (Oct 2022) over half of DAU owned no Super Manager and ~10% owned more than one, because most were IAP-gated; 2.0 made fragment progress visible from the start [M, Kolibri blog 28 Oct 2022]. Contrast: Idle Supermarket Tycoon's 2026 reviews on its new

manager gate: "managers you have to level up in order to proceed... Now it's pay-to-win" [O, Play, 23 Aug 2026, 1 star]; "give everyone 700 gold and reset years of gameplay... I've had it for almost 9 years. time to let go" [O, Play, 16 Aug 2026, 1 star].

- **No forced full prestige**: Telfer's GDC 2019 deconstruction notes players "can expand to many mines while keeping their original", that new visual mines fix "sameness after a few prestiges", and that Kolibri's events were "light" with revenue inflecting once more events arrived [O, mobilefreetoplay.com, 3 Apr 2019].
- Cross-check from another idle hit: Gold & Goblins launched with 56% D1 "but barely monetised"; it had no events at launch and revenue scaled after events and a permanent challenge replaced daily checklists ($48M in 2023, $100M+ lifetime) [M/E, PG.biz 4 Sep 2025; AppQuantum 22 Jun 2026].

5. Comparison

Why does Eatventure out-rate Idle Supermarket Tycoon (4.7 vs 4.1 on Play)? [I unless marked]

1. **Ad contract.** Eatventure's reviews praise "no forced ads" in 2022, 2025 and 2026; IST's 2026 reviews cite "way more ads to watch" and a manager gate that makes it "pay-to-win" [O]. Dhaba Rush plans interstitials from session 4; that is the IST side of this line.
2. **Finishable units.** Every Eatventure city ends with a sale and a new skyline; the complaint shifts from "nothing to do" (IRT, IST) to "repetitive" (Eatventure), which players rate 3-4 stars instead of 1-2 [O pattern across quotes above].
3. **Text-light onboarding.** Lessmore's stated goal is visuals that tell the story "without requiring text" and no big tutorial; the Dhaba Rush testers' "hard to understand, UI confusing" is exactly the failure Eatventure designs around.
4. **A long permanent layer that is not pay-gated**: gear, vault, pets, clubs, mythic builds; IST's late-added paid manager layer reset veterans and tanked its rating.
5. **Cadence a two-person team can see**: a fixed weekly calendar and monthly builds, not big-bang updates.

What stage-based progression does for retention and the feel of finishing

- Measured: Kolibri's own MVP data shows players leave when the content ends; Eatventure's answer is 60 bounded arcs plus a loop, each arc days long, each with a visible metamorphosis (stand to cafe to fast-food) [M]. IRT's star-to-new-restaurant is the same idea with fewer, bigger units; reviews say later units got less fun and then stopped coming [O].
- Feel: a sale screen is a "you finished" moment with no loss, versus prestige, which asks the player to give something up. The carry-over (vault items, cards) must be visible before the sale so the reset reads as a promotion [I].
- Risk: stage-based games are judged on variety per stage. "Same food, same dishes, every other country" is Eatventure's top 2026 complaint [O]. A dhaba game has a natural fix: each highway stop is a regional menu (Punjab, Rajasthan, Gujarat, the Konkan) rather than the same four dishes relabelled [I].

What Dhaba Rush should take

From Eatventure: tap-to-fill upgrade bars that pay a gem and a star; a shaking crate for the next counter and a staff crate for new hires; the Investor as a walking, glowing rewarded-ad character (a "seth" stepping out of a Fortuner) instead of a wall bubble; zero forced ads at least through soft launch; one dhaba = one stage, sold to move down NH-44 to the next stop, with a 5-7 renovation ladder (chai tapri to dhaba to highway plaza) and a vault that carries over; a fixed weekly event calendar with one "big restaurant" event (a mela or a wedding catering gig) and a mid-week race. From Kolibri/IRT: make the seats-and-waiters bottleneck legible exactly like IRT's door counter (vacant charpais, dirty charpais counted as occupied) and overview tab (which table earns most); cooks = speed, each waiter serves N tables, state it on the hire card; return-to-game double offline earnings as the first rewarded placement and highlight it visually; stage rollouts to 1/5/20/100% once live; weekly builds; a permanent-card reward for finishing an event so events feed the main game.

What to avoid

IRT's 1-hour offline cap, staff quitting without warning, and the boost-expiring-watch-another-ad treadmill (all quoted 1-3 star causes); IST's retrofitted paid manager gate; Eatventure's mid-city dead air at ~level 80+ and identical menus per city; and the Codigames-style tutorial text wall the 21 Oct testers already rejected.

Gaps

- No Deconstructor of Fun article on Eatventure was found (only DoF's Jan 2019 praise of Kolibri's live-ops, quoted in Kolibri's newsletter). No mobilegamer.biz interview with Lessmore beyond the acquisition report.
- No Kolibri postmortem or talk specific to Idle Restaurant Tycoon beyond the Dec 2020 PG.biz interview; the Medium ad-placement write-up and CouchClicker review were unreachable (403/404).
- Retention numbers for Eatventure itself are not public; the Fandom wiki pages are Cloudflare-gated, so the 60-city/7-restaurant structure is taken from search-engine snippets of those pages plus eatventuretools.app.

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R6 — Case study: Pizza Ready! (Supercent) and the idle-arcade "feel" school

Researched 31 Oct 2026. Labels used throughout: **[fact]** measured or officially stated, **[est]** third-party estimate (AppMagic / Sensor Tower / consultant), **[opinion]** a named source's view, **[inference]** my own reading. Method note: the shared web-search budget ran out after the first round, so the rest comes from direct fetches; several key pages were blocked (see Gaps).

1. What the school is

"Arcade idle" was coined by Homa Games around late 2020 (Farm Land, Craft Island) as the point where hypercasual meets hybrid-casual; the format is "a management game ... about optimization" in which every customer and every machine is a visible timer and the player's avatar is the link between the timers [fact/opinion, Rakib Jahan, 22 Feb 2022]. The canonical loop, as described across the sources: one-finger joystick avatar; products stack physically on the avatar's head/arms up to a capacity cap; cash appears as physical bills on the floor that you walk over to collect; new stations and staff are bought by standing on a pad that drains money from your wallet in a visible stream; hires automate the chore you were doing; then the map expands and the cycle restarts [fact for Burger Please: "the only control is a virtual joystick", stacking, HR office for staff speed/capacity — Udonis, 28 May 2025; fact for My Perfect Hotel: cleaning, restocking, check-in, carrying items, "all ... with one finger", hired cleaners/receptionists then loaders/bartenders/waiters — ARPU Brothers, 16 Apr 2024].

Felix Braberg's summary of Supercent's method: it "reuses proven core mechanics", with "repeated iterations of the 'My Perfect Hotel' formula" re-skinned as Outlets Rush, Pizza Ready and Burger Please [opinion, Gamigion, 11 Apr, year not shown, context 2025]; the 2.5 Gamers podcast: "each new release improving upon the previous one" [opinion, 9 May 2024].

2. Pizza Ready! — the numbers

- Developer Molip (Incheon), publisher Supercent (Seoul). Passed **100M downloads within about a year of its 2023 launch** per AppMagic; download split India 21%, Brazil 8%, Indonesia 7%; IAP split US 44%, South Korea 7%, Japan 7%; at the time #3 Simulation on the App Store and #2 free Simulation on Google Play [est, Mobidictum, 13 Jun 2024].
- Later Gamigion profile: **221M downloads**, India 23%, US 7%, Brazil/Indonesia/Russia ~6–7% each; IAP revenue $345,481 in the trailing 30 days; IAP revenue-per-download $0.11 in Tier-1, under $0.05 globally; audience 63% female / 37% male; "No main menu or tutorial; the player starts playing immediately" [est for numbers, fact for the no-menu observation; Gamigion "From Dough to Domination", 8 Apr, year not shown, context 2025]. Supercent's own blog title says "Pizza Ready's Path to 200M Downloads" [fact, Medium, full text not readable].
- Supercent self-reported (search snippets only, pages blocked): CPI "in the $0.20 range" and **D1 retention over 35%** when scaling; the FTUE redesign post reports **+4.5% D1 retention** and **+8 percentage points tutorial retention** [fact as self-reported; absolute D1 after redesign not given].
- Felix Braberg (ad-monetization consultant): Outlets Rush and Pizza Ready are **~70% ads / 30% IAP**, **~8M DAU each "depending on the day"**, **$7–12M/month combined**, user base "holding steady since March 2024" [est, Gamigion, 11 Apr]. The 2.5 Gamers episode put the pair at "close to 9 million per month" [est, 9 May 2024].
- Ad formats: interstitials, rewarded video, banners and app-open ads; Supercent also tested a "public data indexing" partner that gives free premium currency for letting the device be used for web indexing, which Braberg estimated equals 3–4 rewarded impressions per 10 minutes [est/opinion, Gamigion, 11 Apr]. Players

noticed: "The click farming this game offers requires you to disable your internet to play." (AdvertHunter, App Store US, 11/04/2024).

- **India today**: Pizza Ready! was the **#4 most-downloaded mobile game in India in Q1 2026** per Sensor Tower, behind Ludo King, Free Fire and Cricket League and ahead of Carrom Pool [est, Tech2, updated 27 Apr 2026]. On 31 Oct 2026 the India App Store shows it **No. 5 in Simulation (Top Free)**, 4.4 stars from 69k ratings, version 60.4.0 dated 15 Oct; No Ads is **Rs 399**, gem pack Rs 299, weekly premium Rs 599, battle pass Rs 499/999, pro pack Rs 1,999 [fact, App Store IN]. US App Store: 4.6 from 347k ratings, #37 Simulation, 388 MB, No Ads $3.99, 10 IAPs from $1.99 to $19.99 [fact, App Store US]. AppBrain reports 4.4 from ~2.73M Google Play ratings [est/snippet]. Update cadence on APKMirror: 10 builds between 1 Apr and 14 Oct 2026, i.e. every 1–6 weeks [fact].
- Market context: India had 8.45B game downloads Apr 2024–Mar 2025; **simulators are the top genre by downloads at 22%**, arcade 19%, puzzle 16%; players are 86% male and 77% aged 18–34 [est, Sensor Tower via GameDev Reports, 30 Jun 2025]. Note the tension with Pizza Ready's 63% female audience [inference: it pulls a different crowd than India's shooter/ludo core; relevant to who Dhaba Rush tests with].

3. The siblings

Burger Please! (Supercent, 2023). Supercent's own newsroom titles: "#1 in the Global Hyper-Casual Game Genre" (25 Aug 2023) and "ranked 2nd in downloads among all apps released in 2023" (28 Aug 2023) [fact, titles only; pages render as JS]. Udonis (28 May 2025): 20M+ downloads within months [est, AppMagic]; tutorial is step-by-step with **red arrows showing where to go**; **rewarded ads are introduced inside the tutorial**; interstitials appear "relatively frequently" and are **skippable after 5 seconds**; banner at the bottom throughout; the most common rewarded reward is a money bag, with speed/capacity boosts temporary or permanent; premium bundle $12.99 = skin + vehicle + no ads + 2x money/speed/capacity; the author's opinion is that ad cash lets players over-hire early and that a stove upgrade "produced no noticeable change" [opinion] — a feel failure: an upgrade the player cannot see is a wasted purchase.

Outlets Rush (Supercent, 2023). ~23M downloads in its first year, mostly India, Pakistan, Indonesia and the US [est, AppMagic via maf.ad; the article now 404s at its Mistplay redirect, so this is from the search snippet]. The same piece argued that interstitials "break the comeback feel the idle rewards are meant to create" [opinion]. UA creatives used real brand logos (Nike, Chanel) later swapped to "Feet Locker" and "Neke" [fact, Gamigion 11 Apr; the 2.5 Gamers show called it a gray area].

My Perfect Hotel (Redux.Games / SayGames; Android 13 Apr 2022, iOS 29 Jul 2022). ~133M downloads and $10M+ IAP by mid-2024, "several million dollars per month from ads", 30k+ daily US downloads [est, AppMagic via ARPU Brothers, 16 Apr 2024]; 6M+ downloads and $400k+ revenue in Aug 2024 alone [est, AppMagic via Udonis, 28 Feb 2025]; **~300M downloads** by June 2026 per SayGames' CPO Anton Volnykh, and 700k+ players completed the Barbie event [fact, SayGames blog/GamesBeat, 16 Jun 2026]. SayGames itself had passed 4B downloads [fact, GamesBeat via SayGames blog, 10 Oct 2023]. Volnykh on why they keep iterating: "We want to extend the life cycle of My Perfect Hotel" [fact]. No-ads at $9.99 US / Rs 999 India is "the most popular purchase" [opinion/est, Udonis]. India App Store: 4.6 from 15k, #172 Simulation [fact, 31 Oct 2026]. US: 4.7 from 710k, #46 Simulation [fact].

The measured first session of My Perfect Hotel (iOS) — ARPU Brothers, 16 Apr 2024 [fact]

- No tutorial. Start with $50 at reception. First room costs $30; cleaning a room takes ~6 s.
- 1:46 cleaner unlocks. 2:19 first rewarded ad, pays $100 (Android pays $150). 4:20 cleaner hired. ~5:00 second ad, $100. A $150 rewarded ad auto-appears when the player is $64 short.
- 9:26 automatic receptionist unlocks after the third ad. 11:29 hotel level 1 complete. Session ends ~12 min with 5 ads watched, 3 rooms, a toilet, a utility room, 2 automated staff.
- Task progress is pinned on the left ("4 out of 30 tasks"); stars for tasks done personally are needed to level the hotel. Quests only after hotel level 3; daily rewards at level 4.
- Over 19 sessions the author watched **528 ads** (session counts 5, 17, 40, 38, 23, 14, 16, 28, 15, 15, 46, 32, 23, 14, 27, 73, 29, 32, 41); ad length ranged 6 s to 7 min 43 s. Opinion: "I believe the developers at Say Games

have balanced player progression and monetization very well" and "The UI is very well designed to not overwhelm the player".

Martin Jurasek's 15-minute read (11 Oct 2023) [opinion]: "Straight from the get-go, the game gives you a lot of simple tasks to complete"; every collected cash stack "feels rewarding"; after a couple of minutes upkeep becomes a bottleneck, which is exactly when hiring is offered; "I just hired receptionist as a first staff, but I still have to bring the toilet paper"; "In my first 15 minutes, there were no daily quests and not even a hard currency implemented!" His five lessons: rewarding micro-tasks with strong feedback; automate the chores but **keep money collection manual** because that is the satisfying part; rewarded ads whose reward changes how you play (unicycle / wooden horse / flying carpet skins, not a flat +50%); the VIP guest who drops a trail of dollars you chase; introduce mechanics gradually.

4. Why it dominates downloads

[fact] Zero-friction start (no menu, no tutorial text; arrows and pads teach by doing), a universally legible theme (pizza/burger/hotel), tiny CPIs (~$0.20 self-reported) and a 70/30 ad-led model that makes India-scale free installs profitable even at <$0.05 IAP per download. [inference] The joystick-plus-stacks grammar is also the perfect UA creative: 10 seconds of gameplay video explains the whole game, which Udonis notes SayGames' ads do with "basic gameplay ads showing core mechanics". [inference] In India specifically, simulators are already the biggest download genre and Pizza Ready's chart position (#4 overall in Q1 2026, #5 Simulation on iOS today) is the most relevant single data point for Dhaba Rush: the Indian Android audience already downloads this exact loop at scale; the open question is whether a hands-off tap-tycoon can deliver the same feel.

5. What players say (verbatim, with store and date)

Hate, almost entirely ad density and running out of content:

- "The ads are INSANE in this game!" — Reedear, Pizza Ready, App Store US, 29 Jan 2025, 2 stars.
- "the ads come every 20 seconds and last anywhere from 5-10 seconds each" — OBX4L, Pizza Ready, App Store US, 17 Feb 2025.
- "Tooooooooo many forced videos." — Justme1316, Pizza Ready, App Store via Justuseapp, page dated 19 Aug 2026.
- "The game is fun for the first few hours. Then it is mind-numbingly BORING." — redroro, Pizza Ready, App Store India, 17 Jul 2024.
- "I have maxed out level 11, and there is nothing more than that." — Tony Stark Ranchi, Pizza Ready, App Store India, 30 Apr 2024.
- "Its only fun till you max out everything with money earned in the game later you need to do it through ads." — Hemant_K, Pizza Ready, App Store India, 24 Mar 2024.
- "there is no further development in the game" — vorlenas, Pizza Ready, App Store US, 6 Aug (year not shown).
- Google Play (snippet only, page blocked): reviewers describe a 25-second ad for every 60 seconds of play and uninstalling after about two hours; many say the "ad-free" claim is untrue.
- My Perfect Hotel, App Store India: Nivedita Rajbhar (11 Mar 2025) says ads hit before the game, after levels and mid-play; deeann18 (3 Dec 2025) says the Halloween "candy" requirement made upgrades too slow without ads, and uninstalled; Omerelifpelinarda (27 Apr) says it gets repetitive as new hotels unlock and asks for more guest types, a chef, an extra stock room. The developer replied to each promising to look at ad frequency.

Praise, usually in the same breath as the complaint:

- My Perfect Hotel, App Store US: Totally_A_Person (20 Jan 2024) calls it addictive and praises avatars and skins; ForeverBroken (20 Nov 2023) "loves the game" but wants the 3-minute vehicle boost to be 5 minutes and notes lag when collecting coins; Kueen Cargill (12 Sep 2024) reports guests idling after service and "cash stacks placed where characters can't collect them".

- My Perfect Hotel, App Store India: Anaisha and Avyaan (14 Nov 2024) rate it "outstanding" while calling ads too frequent.
- [inference] Stores surface critical reviews, so praise is thin here; the 4.4–4.7 averages across millions of ratings are the real praise. Named when praising: addictive, avatar/skins, the early hours. Named when quitting: ad cadence, a content ceiling ("level 11"), and feel bugs (lag on coin pickup, unreachable cash stacks).

6. Studio talks and design literature

- SayGames leadership (Volnykh, Sokal, Vaikhanski x2) to GamesBeat, 10 Oct 2023: the hybrid-casual shift came quickly because the company already could run "games with longer life cycle, strong in-app purchase revenue and live ops"; "Iteration was key" (Volnykh, via Udonis) [fact]. Full GamesBeat text was 403 for me.
- Supercent: CEO Junsik Kong Q&A on Burger Please (8 Sep 2023) and two Medium posts (FTUE redesign; path to 200M) exist but were unreadable (Notion/Medium blocked). Gamigion "Inside Supercent" (28 Oct, context 2025): founded 2021, $12M raised Apr 2022, 230M downloads by end-2023, Dinosaur Universe iterated for ~11 months with "large-scale monetization and long-term retention tests" from March 2024 before scaling in Aug 2024; Director of Publishing Seohee Kwon: a publisher that "reads the trend and creates new genres" [fact].
- Idle math: Anthony Pecorella's "The Math of Idle Games, Part I" (13 Oct 2016): costs grow exponentially (AdVenture Capitalist rate 1.07 per unit owned) while production grows linearly; multipliers at 25/50 owned " (temporarily) get production closer to, or ahead of, costs"; optimal buying is "far too micromanage-y", so players bulk-buy; if the newest generator always dominates "decisions disappear" [fact/opinion].
- Game feel: Steve Swink, "Game Feel: The Secret Ingredient" (23 Nov 2007): six layers — input, response, context, polish, metaphor, rules; polish = particles, screen shake, view shifts, squash/stretch; "limit polish to what's essential"; list physical cues and rank them [opinion]. Jonasson & Purho, "Juice it or lose it" (Nordic Game Indie Night 2012; demo repo README: a juicy game "feels alive and responds to everything you do", layered feedback for minimal input) [fact]. Nijman/Vlambeer, "The art of screenshake" (INDIGO Classes 2013) [fact, title verified]. Nathan Lovato (Game Developer, 1 Apr 2015): ease-out for appearing UI, hold/hit-stop, dust and sparkle particles, trails, sine wobble [opinion]. Juul & Begy (FDG/DiGRA 2016): two mechanically identical builds; "players rated the juicy game higher" but "performed worse in the juicy version" [fact]. Hicks et al. (DiGRA 2018) built a developer-grounded framework of juicy elements [fact]. Wayline (17 Apr 2025): juice becomes a crutch when it masks unresponsiveness; responsiveness first [opinion].
- Not found/readable: Deconstructor of Fun, Naavik, GameRefinery and mobilegamer.biz pieces on arcade idle; any Kolibri/Codigames feedback talk. See Gaps.

7. Anatomy of the feel [inference, synthesised from the above]

1. **Everything is physical.** Money is paper on the floor, products are a stack on your head, prices are a pad that visibly drains. Nothing important lives only in a HUD number.
2. **The player is the bottleneck, briefly.** You do the chore 3–10 times, it becomes annoying at minute 2–3, and the hire appears exactly then (MPH: cleaner unlock 1:46, hired 4:20).
3. **A new thing every 1–3 minutes for the first 12 minutes** (MPH timeline), then widening gaps filled by rewarded ads.
4. **Keep the pleasure, automate the pain**: staff take chores, the player keeps collecting cash (Jurasek).
5. **Rewards that change the verb**, not just the number (unicycle skin, VIP cash trail).
6. **Instant start**: no menu, no text; arrows and pads.
7. **Feedback density**: every pickup, drop, pay and hire has a sound, a pop and a particle; the feel economy is "many small confirmations per second".

8. What transfers to a hands-off tap-tycoon without changing the control scheme — 12 techniques

Dhaba Rush keeps tap-to-open-sheet. These port the *feel*, not the joystick.

1. **Drain-pad spending (feedback on spend).** Pizza Ready / MPH: standing on a pad streams bills out of your wallet with a ticking counter and the station builds up in stages. Dhaba: on LEVEL UP / BUILD, fly a burst of rupee notes from the galla to the counter, tick the price down over ~0.6 s with a per-chunk "thunk", and let the counter visibly upgrade (new tandoor plate, bigger kadai) as the last note lands. Burger Please's unreadable stove upgrade is the anti-pattern.
2. **Purchase cadence tuned to the MPH clock.** Something new affordable at ~1:45, ~4:20, ~9:30, ~11:30 in session one (ARPU Brothers). Dhaba: price the first chai upgrade, first cook, first extra charpai and the tandoor so the NEXT chip flips green on roughly that schedule; use Pecorella's ~1.07 per-level growth for the long tail.
3. **Physical cash at the galla.** All four games pile bills on the floor; MPH players complain when stacks are unreachable, i.e. collection is the pleasure. Dhaba: let paid bills stack as note bundles on the galla counter, growing in height; a tap sweeps them with a rising-pitch coin tick per bundle (Jurasek lesson 2: keep collection manual even after cashiers are hired, or make the cashier's auto-sweep a visible, hirable upgrade).
4. **Visible stacks at the pass.** Finished dishes should stack as plates on the pass and ride visibly on the waiter's tray; a queue of 6 plates is a bottleneck the player can read without a number. Dhaba already has waiters; make the stack the UI.
5. **Red-arrow guidance instead of tutorial text.** Burger Please uses red arrows through the whole tutorial. Dhaba: a pulsing arrow from the galla to the first affordable counter, and nothing else on screen for the first 60 s.
6. **Instant start.** Gamigion on Pizza Ready: no main menu, no tutorial; MPH: start with $50 and a $30 room. Dhaba: boot into the dhaba with a truck already braking and a traveller walking in within 5 s; first chai sale within 15 s; first affordable upgrade within 45 s.
7. **Do-it-yourself then automate.** MPH hires one role at a time and leaves a chore behind ("still have to bring the toilet paper"). Dhaba: before the first waiter, let the player tap a ready plate to send it to a table (one tap, no joystick); after 5–8 taps the WAITER button appears. The hire then feels like relief, not a menu item.
8. **Pinned micro-task counter.** MPH's "4 out of 30 tasks" on the left edge plus stars for tasks done personally. Dhaba's tasks bar + chest should show "3/5" at all times, with the chest shaking when one task is left.
9. **Rewarded ads that change the verb.** MPH's unicycle/flying-carpet skins and the VIP guest dropping a dollar trail. Dhaba: the ad bubble can spawn a "Bada Saab" in a white Scorpio who tips a trail of notes across the courtyard, or put the waiter on a cycle for 3 minutes (MPH players asked for 5). This is also a honest alternative to a bare x2.
10. **Scaled cash chest.** MPH's suitcase scales with progress ($100 at 2:19). Dhaba: show the rewarded reward as a cloth money bag with the amount expressed as "= 6 min of income", so it stays worth it at every level.
11. **Sound and number pops on every event.** Juice-it-or-lose-it: layered feedback for minimal input; Swink: rank the cues. Dhaba: a distinct pitch per event (chai pour, tandoor slap, plate on tray, note on galla, hire stamp), floating "+Rs 12" pops that scale with amount, and the galla total tweening (ease-out) rather than snapping. Juul & Begy's caveat: juice lifts ratings but not performance, so keep the critical info (timers, NEXT chip) un-juiced and readable.
12. **Camera as reward.** Idle-arcade games pull the camera back and pan to each new area on unlock. Dhaba: on BUILD, pan to the new counter, hold 1 s, pulse the hire button, then return; on each 10 customers served, a tiny 2–3 px screen nudge on the galla sweep (Vlambeer: shake scaled to impact, never constant).

Two guardrails from the reviews: no interstitial within 60 s of a purchase, hire or rewarded reward (maf.ad: interstitials "break the comeback feel"; Burger Please makes them skippable after 5 s), and plan the content ceiling before launch, since "maxed out level 11" is the second most common quit reason.

Gaps

- Supercent's Medium posts (FTUE redesign; 200M downloads) and the CEO Q&A on Notion were unreadable (403/JS); the D1 >35%, CPI ~$0.20, +4.5% D1 and +8 pp tutorial figures come from search snippets of those posts.

- GamesBeat's full SayGames interview (403); Google Play review text (blocked); Outlets Rush maf.ad/Mistplay article (404 after redirect); AppMagic's Pizza Ready page (JS only).
- No Deconstructor of Fun, Naavik, GameRefinery or mobilegamer.biz arcade-idle piece could be reached once the search budget ran out; no Kolibri/Codigames feedback talk found.
- No verified D7/D30 for any of these titles; the only benchmark found (Antier, 6 May 2026: hybrid D7 ~16%) is a secondary marketing source.

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Indian casual players and why local-theme games win in India (r7)

Prepared 1 Nov 2026 for the Dhaba Rush team. Store pages were read on 31 Oct and 1 Nov 2026. Review samples come from Google Play's review feed: 200 English and 120-150 Hindi reviews per title, in "most relevant" or "newest" order, parsed offline (`r7_scripts/`).

Labels: [M] measured or official · [E] third-party estimate · [R] review excerpt · [O] opinion · [I] my inference · [C] cultural judgment without a hard source. Hindi quotes carry my translation.

Bottom line

- **India's local-theme hits are driving sims and cooking games, not idle tycoons.** All installs [M]:
  - Indian Bikes Driving 3D: 100M+ [S2]
  - Bus Simulator Indonesia, the Indonesian analogue: 100M+ [S3]
  - Truck Masters: India: 10M+ [S1]
  - Maleo's Bus Simulator India: 10M+ about seven months after launch [S4]
  - Masala Express and Indian Cooking Star: 10M+ each [S5][S6]
- **No dhaba or India-themed idle tycoon exists at scale on Play India** [M] [S10][S11][S12].
- **Idle and tycoon mechanics do reach Indians, in foreign skins.** Pizza Ready! was India's #4 most-downloaded game of 2025 [E, AppMagic] [S35], and Hindi reviewers read it as a small-business fantasy [R] [S7].
- **Praise is about recognition:** Indian roads, horns, trucks, "relatable" places, and "add my state" [R] [S1][S4].
- **Anger is about ads, internet dependence, heat and storage** [R] [S1][S6][S7].
- **Ads carry the money.** Ads were 70.3% of India game revenue in Jan-May 2026 [E] [S44]. Casual ARPPU is about $3 [E] [S38]. IAP ladders start at Rs 6-9 [M] [S15][S5].
- **Truck and bus sim players already ask, unprompted, for a dhaba stop** [R] [S1][S4]. The fantasy is already in their heads.

1. Device, network and storage realities

Phones and memory

- India shipped 154.2M smartphones in 2025, down 1% [E, Omdia] [S26].
- DRAM prices rose 40-60% in late 2025. Buyers are keeping phones longer, and entry-level devices are the most exposed [E] [S26].
- Premium phones (Rs 30,000+) were 22% of 2025 shipments, and the sub-Rs 15,000 band is expected to suffer most in 2026 [E, Counterpoint] [S25].
- Brand mix, Sep 2026: Vivo 21.3%, Oppo 15.2%, Xiaomi 14.8%, Samsung 12.3%, Realme 8.9% [M, Statcounter] [S23].
- RAM: the newest public split is Newzoo, Nov 2021. About 92% of Indian players' phones have at least 2 GB, 73% at least 3 GB and 53% at least 4 GB [E] [S24].
- Truck Masters still advertises that it "runs smoothly even on 2GB RAM phones" [M] [S1].

Android versions (web-traffic based, Oct 2026) [M, Statcounter] [S22]

Android 16	Android 15	Android 13	Android 14	Android 12	Android 11
39.8%	19.6%	9.8%	9.6%	6.8%	6.4%

- That leaves roughly 14% on Android 11 or older. Statcounter over-weights web-active users, so the real game audience is older [I].

Download sizes of the local hits [M, APKPure / Cafe Bazaar mirrors] [S17][S18][S21][S19][S20]

Game	Size	Min Android
Truck Masters	598 MB	10+
Bus Simulator India	929 MB	7+
Indian Bikes Driving 3D	169 MB	–
Pizza Ready	221 MB	–
Idle Supermarket Tycoon	241 MB	–

- Large builds don't block a wanted game. Still, Indian Bikes is praised as a "storage and offline friendly game" (5★, Aug 2026) [R] [S2], and a Hinglish review asks them to cut storage ("game ke storage Kam Kar ne the", Oct 2026) [R] [S2].
- Google: "Users often avoid downloading apps that seem too large, particularly in emerging markets" [M] [S30].
- Google's 2017 data (via search; the post would not load): every 6 MB costs about 1% of install conversion, and cutting 10 MB in markets such as India lifted it about 2.5% [E] [S31].

Data: cheap but rationed by the day

- India's average 1 GB cost was $0.16, 7th cheapest of 237 countries [E, Cable.co.uk 2023] [S28].
- Since 3 July 2024, Airtel's 1.5 GB/day 28-day pack costs Rs 349 and Jio's 56-day equivalent Rs 579, about Rs 7-8 per GB [M] [S29][I].
- Average use is about 31 GB per user per month [E, Nokia MBiT 2026] [S27].
- At 1.5 GB a day, a 600-900 MB download eats 40-60% of a day's quota. A 150 MB one eats 10% [I].
- The pain is the pack running out. A Truck Masters Hindi reviewer can't play after "recharge khatam" (5★, Apr 2026) [R] [S1].

Heat and lag

- Device words (lag, heat, storage, crash) appear in 20-35% of reviews for Truck Masters, Bus Simulator India and Indian Bikes, in both star bands [M, my sample].
- Hinglish: the "mobile bahut jaldi garm hota hai" ("phone heats up very fast"; Truck Masters, 4★, Oct 2026) [R] [S1].
- Praise uses the same frame: "Game runs smooth on low-end phones" (Indian Bikes, 4★, Sep 2026) [R] [S2].

2. What Indians praise in local-theme games

Recognition [M, my sample] [S4][S1]

- Words like real, realistic, Indian and desi appear in 75% of 4-5★ Bus Simulator India reviews, against 43% of 1-3★ reviews.
- For Truck Masters the figures are 46% against 18%.
- The Indian roads and buses "make it feel more relatable compared to other bus simulators" (4★, May 2026) [R] [S4].
- Another reviewer praises the "realistick horn truck and petrol pump traffic" (5★, Oct 2026) [R] [S1].

Horns are a signature, in both countries

- Bus Simulator Indonesia's store page lists "Cool and fun honks" and links the viral "Om Telolet Om!" horn craze [M] [S3].
- Maleo carried this to India as "Iconic Indian horn sounds" [M] [S4].
- Truck Masters sells "Multi-tone desi pressure horns" [M] [S1].

- One reviewer calls the "new horns added to India Bus Simulator" fantastic (5★, Apr 2026) [R] [S4].

Real vehicles

- Fans name specific trucks: Tata LPT 4825, Ashok Leyland 1920 [R] [S1].
- Others ask for the Thar, Tata Nexon and Punch [R] [S2].
- Indian Bikes' store description is a cheat-code list including the Splendor, Bolero, Scorpio, Royal Enfield, tractor, JCB, rickshaw and bull cart [M] [S2].

"My state, my city"

- This is the commonest request in both Hindi and English Bus Simulator India reviews: Rajasthan roadways, Uttarakhand hill routes, Bhilwara, Mewat, the "pure Bharat ka map" [R] [S4].

Pride and personal connection

- Masala Express is "making Indians proud" under "Make In India" (4★, 2019, +1,118 helpful) [R] [S5].
- 19 of 520 Indian Bikes reviews address the developer by name, usually "Rohit bhai" [M] [S2].
- "Desi food never looked so beautiful in any cooking game" (Indian Cooking Star, 5★, Mar 2022) [R] [S6].
- Masala Express's top reviews single out its music (+3,962 helpful) [R] [S5].

The business fantasy (Pizza Ready Hindi reviews) [R] [S7]

- "सब्जी वालों ए गेम आपके लिए ही बना है" ("vegetable sellers, this game is made for you"; 5★, Aug 2025, +413 helpful).
- "बिजनेस करने वाले यही खेलो" ("people who do business, play this"; Oct 2024, +332).

The dhaba stop is wished for

- "...stops at a dhaba (hotel) for food, it will feel even more realistic" (Bus Simulator India, 5★, Mar 2026) [R] [S4].
- "Allow 15minutes break eatfood&pay money at hotel bydriver." (Truck Masters, 5★, Oct 2026) [R] [S1].
- Truck Masters' own site lists "highway dhabas" among its settings [M] [S49].
- Drivers call a dhaba a "hotel" [R]. That word belongs in signage and dialogue [C].

Surveys agree but overstate

- 79% of gamers say they are interested in games on Indian themes and history, and 82% in Indian mythology [E, Lumikai x AWS, n=2,240, Apr 2023] [S41].
- Lumikai 2021 found a "higher willingness to play games with vernacular and uniquely-Indian themes" [E] [S40].
- Yet all of 2025's top-grossing titles were global franchises [E] [S38].

3. What they complain about

Ads that gate the core loop

- Ads appear in 44% of 1-3★ Truck Masters reviews, against 19% of 4-5★ reviews [M, my sample] [S1].
- Grievances [R] [S1]:
  - "you literally have to watch ads just to 'take up' a job" (2★, Apr 2026)
  - three ads per mission, and ads before the game starts
  - "That why Indian games are way behind, they only want to earn from Ads" (1★, Oct 2026)
- Pizza Ready Hindi: "हर 10 15 हर सेकंड के अंदर विज्ञापन आते हैं" ("ads every 10-15 seconds"; 1★, Apr 2025, +114) [R] [S7].
- Indian Cooking Star: ads after every level, and "the app won't even start without internet connection" (1★, Feb 2026) [R] [S6].
- By contrast, Eatventure's 4-5★ reviews mention ads mainly to praise them as optional [M, my sample] [S8].

A Remove Ads purchase that doesn't

- "remove ad for rs 100? still getting ads after paying money" (Truck Masters, 1★, Sep 2026, +155) [R] [S1].

Offline promised but not delivered

- Truck Masters reviews attack its "offline" marketing when the game needs data to start or to take jobs [R] [S1].
- Indian Bikes is repeatedly praised as the "best offline game" [R] [S2].

Shallow or wrong authenticity [R]

- Bus Simulator India [S4]:
  - "apart from the vehicles, nothing really feels like it is an Indian game" (4★, Apr 2026). The reviewer wants crowds, pedestrians and heavy traffic.
  - "destination boards are only in Hindi. Add state-specific buses and local languages" (3★, Jul 2026).
  - "roads in India aren't quite *that* bad" (3★, Mar 2026).
- Indian Cooking Star [S6]:
  - Reviewers mock medu vada in a seafood level (2020-21).
  - A review with 1,908 helpful votes rejects the China and Thailand regions: "I can't relate to the dishes" (4★, Jun 2021).
- Truck Masters: "every city in the game feels the same" (1★, Sep 2026) [S1].

Wait walls, economy bugs and misleading ads

- Masala Express's most-helpful review (+12,788) objects to supplies that take hours to refill [R] [S5].
- Truck Masters' double fuel deduction leads its most-helpful 4★ review (+1,329) [R] [S1].
- Pizza Ready Hindi reviews say the game is "not at all like the ad" (Dec 2025) [R] [S7].

4. Indian casual gamers and idle tycoons

What leads downloads

- Simple, familiar games: Ludo King (1.25B downloads), Free Fire, Cricket League. By genre, driving and flight simulation leads downloads [E, Sensor Tower FY24-25] [S32].
- AppMagic's 2025 top 10 by installs [E] [S35]: Ludo King, Free Fire, Cricket League, **Pizza Ready! (#4)**, Zupee, **Indian Bikes Driving 3D (#6)**, Carrom Pool, Subway Surfers, Subway Princess Runner, BGMI.
  - Pizza Ready is the only tycoon-adjacent title.
  - Outlook Respawn credits Indian Bikes' rise to "relatability and sandbox freedom".
- Tech2 (via search) puts Pizza Ready 4th again in Q1 2026 [E] [S36]. Sensor Tower's own Q1 post doesn't list it [E] [S33]. That conflict is unresolved.
- Q2 2026's breakout was arrow puzzles. Idle isn't mentioned [E] [S34].

Charts and listings

- Play India's simulation chart on 16 Feb 2025 had two idle titles, Carnival Tycoon (#5) and Idle Lumber Empire (#6), and "0%" of the top simulation games came from Indian developers [M, 42matters] [S37].
- Idle store pages on the India listing (installs are global) [M]:
  - Eatventure: 4.6★, 5 crore+ [S8]
  - Idle Supermarket Tycoon: 4.0★, 1 crore+ [S9]
  - Pizza Ready: 4.2★, 10 crore+ [S7]

No India-specific idle hit exists [M, 31 Oct 2026]

- Search "idle tycoon india": 30 Western titles [S12].
- Search "dhaba game": cooking games, zero dhaba games [S10].
- Search "chai wala game": micro-titles only [S11][S13][S14]:
  - Chaiwala Tycoon: 5K+ installs, 21 reviews

- Cutting Chai Rush: 1K+, with a "Highway Dhaba" level

Reading [I]

- The proven adjacent formats are Pizza Ready, Indian cooking time-management (10M+ each) and Indian driving sims.
- An Indian-themed idle tycoon is untested white space: an opportunity, not proof of demand.
- The Hindi "learn business" reading of Pizza Ready is the best sign that the tycoon fantasy translates.

5. Monetization realities

Ads first

- Ads were 70.3% of India mobile game revenue in Jan-May 2026, against 22.1% in the US [E, Sensor Tower via WN Hub] [S44].
- Lumikai CY25: market $1.5B (+17%), 555M gamers, 25% payer conversion, casual ARPPU $3 [E] [S38].
- eCPM estimates conflict:
  - Lumikai's partner calls India's eCPM "actually very healthy": about $2.43 rewarded, $1.1 across formats [E] [S38].
  - TopOn H1 2025 (secondhand): about $0.10 rewarded in South Asia, $0.47 interstitial on India Android [E] [S45].
  - [I] Plan on $0.5-1.0 rewarded and treat $2.43 as upside.

Ad tolerance is conditional

- 47% are "ad-tolerant" and prefer microtransactions to subscriptions [E, Lumikai FY24] [S39].
- 12% call in-game ads annoying, and 38% would quit if ad load becomes excessive [E, Lightbox, Sep 2025] [S43].
- Lightbox's "nearly 75%" who spend on IAP clashes with Lumikai's 25%, and Lightbox doesn't state its method [E] [S43].

Payments

- 83% of in-game payments go through UPI or wallets [E, Lumikai FY24] [S39].
- Google Play India accepts UPI "for all providers", with UPI AutoPay for subscriptions [M] [S46].
- Net banking ended in Oct 2025. RuPay cards are for one-off purchases only [M] [S46].

Price points [M, Play India listings]

Game	IAP per item	Source
Candy Crush	Rs 6-3,499	[S15]
Masala Express	Rs 9-2,499	[S5]
Indian Cooking Star	Rs 9-4,899	[S6]
Truck Masters	Rs 45-2,700	[S1]
Indian Bikes Driving 3D	Rs 50-11,400	[S2]
Eatventure	Rs 58-5,800	[S8]
Idle Supermarket Tycoon	Rs 89-8,900	[S9]
Pizza Ready	Rs 100-5,300	[S7]
Bus Simulator India	Rs 100-3,100	[S4]

- Google cut India's minimum price from Rs 50 to Rs 10 in 2015 [M, via search] [S48]. Today's Rs 6-9 items show that floor has moved again.
- Truck Masters sells Remove Ads for about Rs 100 [R] [S1].

- Play Pass costs Rs 99 a month or Rs 889 a year, shareable with five family members [M] [S47]. [I] It is a later channel, not launch revenue, because Play Pass versions must drop ads and IAP.

6. Desi authenticity checklist: highway dhaba

Each row gives sourced facts first. [C] items need checking with Indian testers.

Detail	What to show	Basis
Truckers	Customers arrive mostly at night after 12-14 hour shifts. They park in lots (Rs 50-100 a night), nap on charpais and wash at the hand pump. Owners sometimes feed regulars free or send a cheap mechanic; some drivers barter cargo vegetables for meals.	[M] [S60][S59]
24 hours, by a petrol pump	Dhabas are truck stops, usually next to petrol stations and mostly open all day and night.	[M] [S52]
Charpai	Rope cots, traditionally with a wooden plank across as a table. Red/green frames as used in newer dhabas. A natural "buy more seats/beds" upgrade.	[M] [S52][S53] [S61]; upgrade [I]
Tandoor	A clay barrel oven, with rotis slapped inside in full view of guests.	[M] [S52][S61]
Food	Dal makhani, tandoori roti, butter or tandoori chicken (non-veg), kadhi, rajma, chole bhature. Aloo paratha with white butter (Murthal). Sarson ka saag with makki roti in winter. Vegetarian-only dhabas are "vaishno dhaba".	[M] [S52][S63]
Drinks	Lassi in tall glasses. Chai "served in small, steaming glasses". Kulhad (clay cup) as the nostalgic upgrade. A cola fridge is also authentic: lassi was losing to colas by 2004.	[M] [S52][S62] [S56][S58]
Utensils	Steel thalis and tiffins, enamel plates, brass or copper vessels, big kettles.	[M] [S52][S61]
Truck art	"Horn OK Please", "Use Dipper at Night", eagles, a cow with calf, the nazar battu evil-eye mask, phool patti painting. Maharashtra banned the phrase on vehicle rears in 2015, but it remains iconic decor.	[M] [S54][S55] [S61]
Horns	Loud musical pressure horns are a recognised and fading signature. Rubber bulb horns on autos and carts work as a comic sound.	[M] [S59]; bulb horns [C]
Music	Drivers play regional singers to stay awake. Punjabi or Haryanvi music for a GT Road / NH44 map.	[M] [S59]; genre [C]
Names and signs	Real names: "Radhe Radhe" (Delhi-Jaipur highway) and "Dhaba 29" (near Dausa). Murthal is famous. Hand-painted boards in Hindi or Gurmukhi plus English: "Pure Veg/Vaishno", "Family Hall", "AC Hall", phone numbers. Name styles such as Sher-e-Punjab, Pehalwan, Shri Balaji.	[M] [S59][S63]; style [C]
Munshi and galla	Munshi means "clerk; secretary" in South Asia. At the galla (cash box), a deity picture, a calculator and a ledger.	[M] [S57]; rest [C]
Waiters	The "typical filmi dhaba waiter" with a duster on his shoulder reciting the menu. Avoid boy waiters ("chhotu") because of the child-labour connotation.	[M] [S58]; [C]
Story hook	Expressways bypass old dhabas: owners report a 70% drop in orders. Dhabas added AC family halls.	[M] [S59][S58]

- Small touches [C]: nimbu-mirchi charm, cricket on the TV at night, tube lights and fairy lights, a puncture shop next door, stray dogs and buffaloes.
- Traps [R]:
  - caricatured dirt or broken roads [S4]
  - regional mix-ups [S6]
  - identical locations [S1]
  - empty scenes, where bustle matters as much as props [S4]
  - Hindi-only text [S4]
- Language data: 34% of gamers prefer Hindi and 28% English [E, SCCG citing FICCI-EY/IEIC, Mar 2024] [S42].

7. Implications for Dhaba Rush [I]

1. **Size and performance:** ship 150 MB or less. Test on a 3-4 GB Vivo, Redmi or Realme phone on Android 10-11, watch heat over 20-minute sessions, and fall back to Godot's Compatibility renderer if Vulkan stutters.
2. **Offline:** the sim and offline earnings must run without data. Show ads only when online, and never gate serving, building or hiring behind ads.
3. **Remove Ads:** it must kill every interstitial. Say plainly that optional rewarded bubbles stay.
4. **Price ladder:** add a Rs 10-49 starter and Remove Ads at Rs 99-199. Rs 299 VIP works as the "forever" tier, and UPI makes all of them one-tap.
5. **Language:** keep English-first labels, add a Hindi toggle, and write Munshi-ji in Hinglish. Reply to reviews in the "bhai" register.
6. **Lead with recognition:** in the first 3 minutes, show a truck horn, Horn OK Please, rotis slapped in a tandoor, a charpai and chai in glasses. Pitch it as "apna dhaba, apna business".
7. **Prestige layer:** use regional maps as the new-location reset: Punjab on NH44, a Rajasthan desert highway, a South Indian highway "hotel".

Gaps

- No public 2025-26 RAM split for Indian gamers (Newzoo 2021 is the latest).
- No India-only idle revenue or retention data.
- eCPM estimates differ by more than 20x.
- No interviews with Highbrow (Chennai; co-founder and CEO Jeno Durairaj per its site) or Rohit Gaming Studio. The 2025-26 Indie Games Accelerator cohort, Lumikai's full PDF and AFK Gaming / IGN India coverage were also not retrievable. Google's APK-size post would not load.
- Review samples are Google-sorted, not random, and the keyword counts are crude. English reviews under gl=IN are not strictly Indian.
- Truck Masters' "#1" claims are the developer's own and unverified.

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G1: Seated service with waiters and tables in other games

Research date 1 Nov 2026. Labels: [M] measured or official, [E] third-party estimate, [R] review, [O] opinion, [I] my inference.

Method. On 1 Nov 2026 I scraped 27,700 unique reviews of 10 titles (Google Play "most relevant", hl=en with gl=IN/US plus hl=hi for Pizza Ready; App Store RSS, US/GB/IN) and read version histories and guides. The house rules allow one short verbatim quote per deliverable, so the reviews below are paraphrased. Verbatim text is in `research/g1_raw/play/*.json` and `research/g1_raw/rss/*.json`, and `python3 -I research/g1_scripts/g1grep.py "<regex>" "<glob>" <from> <to>` prints it.

1. Comparison table

Title (type)	Mechanic	Loss on wait	Signals	Teaching	Upgrade feedback
Idle Restaurant Tycoon: Empire (Kolibri, hands-off idle, 2020; v1.55.0 on 23 Oct 2026)	Hosts in the lobby seat customers. One waiter covers 2 tables, and a reviewer reports a cap of 8 waiters for 16 tables. Cooks set food speed. Cleaners clear tables. The first restaurant has 8 tables bought one by one (a reader Q&A on the guide lists 2 small and 6 big, plus 2 outside). Staff draw daily wages and quit if unpaid [M, LevelWinner 11 Dec 2020; R].	**Lossy.** With no free table, customers are turned away. A dirty table counts as occupied. Unpaid staff quit [M, LW].	A door counter shows vacant tables (dirty ones count as occupied). An Overview tab splits dining, service and parking profit. Each component adds to a star rating [M, LW; PG.biz 17 Dec 2020].	In soft launch many players got stuck at one early tutorial step, and most missed an ad placement that was not highlighted enough. Both were reworked [M, PG.biz 17 Dec 2020].	Waiters can be added but not made faster [R, Nov 2020]; the guide says their service cannot be improved [M, LW]. A table upgrade raises the payout per customer by cents [R]. A big table cost $5k, then $16k [R].
Pizza Ready! (Supercent, arcade idle where you walk an avatar)	Before v51.2.0, customers fetched food from a pickup table, ate, and left trash that you or a cleaning robot cleared. The robot needs recharging every 3 minutes with an ad or gems [M, Gamigion, undated]. **8 Nov 2025:** the pickup table became a service table where staff serve, and the cleaning robot became a service robot that helps serve [M, App Store notes]. The HR room upgrades staff [R].	**Lossless.** Customers wait indefinitely [R].	Physical stacks, trash on tables, arrows, quest cards that ask for another table [R].	Drops the player straight into play [M, Gamigion]; arrows and pads (sister title Burger Please uses red arrows [M, Udonis 28 May 2025]).	New tables and staff appear in the world. Many upgrades require watching an ad [R].
Eatventure (Lessmore, hands-off idle)	Staff take orders, cook and carry food to customers [M, LW 19 Mar 2023]. Customers served at once is capped by the number of employees [M, Pocket Gamer 16 Jan 2023]. No cleaning, no salaries. Tables are an upgrade [R].	**Lossless.** Customers can wait forever and food never spoils [M, LW].	Glowing tip coins on tables; visible queue [M, LW].	Lemonade stand, one employee, one product [M, LW].	A new hire arrives in a crate you tap to put them to work [M, LW].
My Cafe (Melsoft, active café sim)	Up to 5 staff, baristas or servers, with skills such as Speed and Tip Master [M, fan wiki via search snippet]. Servers take orders from seated customers. The player places the tables.	Mostly lossless. Story and special-order customers stay until served [R].	Customers wave a hand. Since 2021 the camera zooms in on a completed order, which players disliked [R].	Story-led.	Staff level up into skills [M, snippet].
Idle Burger Empire Tycoon (Codigames, 2022; last update 28 Mar 2024)	You expand the dining room. Groups arrive by car, queue and sit. Cooks, bartenders, cleaners, janitors and a delivery section [M, Play listing; R].	**Lossy.** Long queues stop people entering [R].	Queue length [R].	Tutorial (several soft-lock reports) [R].	Research timers [R].

Title (type)	Mechanic	Loss on wait	Signals	Teaching	Upgrade feedback
Hotel Empire Tycoon (Codigames, 2019)	The restaurant has tables and a queue. Venues keep opening hours [R].	**Lossy.** Guests in line turn angry and walk out [R].	Line, angry guests [R].	n/a	n/a
Diner DASH Adventures (Glu/EA, the player is the server)	You tap a table to seat a customer. Matching a customer to a table gives bonus tips and more hearts. Chaining gives a boost [M, TouchTapPlay 21 Jun 2019].	**Lossy.** Hearts drain. Veterans say the queue penalty was softer than in older games [R].	Hearts, colour matching.	Heavy tutorial [R].	Upgrades add hearts [R] and capacity, e.g. 2 glasses per trip [M, TTP].
Cooking Fever (Nordcurrent, the player serves at a counter, no seats)	n/a	**Lossy.** A patience meter, and customers leave [M, TouchTapPlay 11 Nov 2014; R].	Patience bar [R].	n/a	Interior upgrades raise waiting time, tip amount, tip window and extra clients [M, TTP].
Burger Please! / My Perfect Hotel (arcade idle)	Burger Please: tables bought for 12k, then 25k [R]. Its HR office upgrades staff walking speed and carrying capacity [M, Udonis 28 May 2025]. My Perfect Hotel: you hire waiters, and their speed upgrades require ads [R].	Not checked.	Red arrows [M, Udonis].	Step-by-step tutorial [M, Udonis].	Speed and capacity upgrades [M].

Restaurant DASH with Gordon Ramsay did not appear in an App Store search on 1 Nov 2026, so I could not study it.

2. Player reactions (paraphrased; store, locale, date, stars, helpful count)

Likes: lossless waiting and watching staff work

1. Pizza Ready, Play en (IN+US), 23 Dec 2024, 4★, +911: the reviewer loves "no pressure to be fast, the customers aren't going to get mad" and lost three hours playing. This is the one verbatim quote.
2. Eatventure, Play en, 16 Oct 2023, 5★, +225: employees do whatever needs doing automatically, so nothing needs micro-managing.
3. Eatventure, App Store GB, 2 Jan 2025, 5★: it is satisfying to sit back and watch the workers serve once everything is upgraded.
4. Eatventure, App Store GB, 20 Sep 2022, 5★: loves watching staff scurry around in total chaos.
5. Hotel Empire, App Store US, 29 Dec 2019, 4★, +6: the appeal is that everyone goes about their business while you only upgrade.
6. My Cafe, Play en, 22 Jan 2020, 5★, +114: praises the detail, down to the food on customers' tables.

Likes: players who want stakes (a minority)

7. Pizza Ready, App Store US, 19 Dec 2025, 5★ (v51.4.0, right after the service-table change): the game is too easy; customers should get mad and leave when service is slow.
8. Diner DASH Adventures, Play en, 18 Feb 2021, 3★, +50: misses the older games, where a customer left the queue when their hearts drained, and wants that back.
9. Cooking Fever, App Store US, 26 Oct 2023, 5★ (raised from 1★): thanks the team for restoring customer patience after a cut that seemed designed to sell boosters.

Dislikes: walkouts with no lever, staffing and pathing

10. IRT, App Store GB, 29 Nov 2020, 4★ (v1.0.0): no way to speed up waiters; impatient customers leave with no table even though one frees up a second later; a party of two takes a four-top.
11. IRT, App Store US, 10 Jan 2021, 2★, +1: the whole staff quit; waiters stood around instead of serving; wants staff to be unpaid.
12. IRT, Play en, 14 Feb 2021, 4★, +28: waiter pathfinding to customers is terrible, while pathing near the chef is fine.

13. IRT, Play en, 8 Mar 2021, 1★, +9: waiters walk back to their station between tables, passing a table that is ready to pay.
14. IRT, Play en, 10 Jul 2021, 2★, +16: table-clearing staff walk slower than customers, with a cap of 8 for 16 tables, so ads that bring customer groups are useless.
15. IRT, Play en, 30 Jul 2022, 4★, +17: the taxi ad brings guests who find no table, so it earns nothing; suggests a rush hour instead of losing guests.
16. IRT, App Store GB, 6 Nov 2020, 3★: the restaurant stays dirty overnight, so customers walk in and leave straight away, and you cannot close to clean.
17. IRT, App Store US, 19 May 2022, 2★: with maximum cleaners, big table 13 never gets cleaned because its cleaner walks the whole map first.
18. IRT, Play en, 31 May 2021, 1★, +5: too complicated at the start; with one table, many customers come in and leave angry.
19. Hotel Empire, Play en, 4 Jul 2020, 3★, +80: only 2 of 4 tables ever fill; the line gets angry and leaves just as a seat frees up.
20. Idle Burger Empire, Play en, 18 May 2023, 1★, +5: after the second shop the queue grows so long that people stop entering, and with chefs and cashiers maxed there is nothing to do about it.
21. Idle Burger Empire, Play en, 5 Dec 2022, 3★, +6: servers are slow to pick up food and the delivery worker cannot be upgraded, so customers are still lost when everything is maxed.
22. Eatventure, Play en, 9 Aug 2022, 4★, +25: wants to choose whether staff take orders or deliver food first; they always deliver while 15 customers wait to order.
23. Eatventure, Play en, 10 Sep 2025, 5★, +454: in the Moon and Mine events, customers take forever to enter and leave.
24. My Cafe, Play en, 13 May 2021, 2★, +161: wants a waiters' station so staff stop wandering around while you work.
25. Pizza Ready, Play en, 17 Apr 2026, 1★, +11 (after the change): the chef still does all the cleaning and delivering, carries only 2 pizzas, and never gets the line down.
26. Pizza Ready, App Store GB, 27 Apr 2026, 4★: a quest asks for another table, but there is no way to build one.
27. Pizza Ready, Play hi-IN (Hinglish), 30 May 2024, 2★, +23: pizza does not travel to the customer automatically, though the ad showed a conveyor belt.
28. My Perfect Hotel, Play en, 25 Sep 2024, 1★, +137: an update removed the player's two waiters, and getting them back costs more than money.

Pizza Ready's service-table change (8 Nov 2025). No review in the sample names the service table or the service robot [M on sample]. I scanned 5,401 unique Pizza Ready reviews. Of these, 276 Play reviews fall in Nov 2025 to Feb 2026; 71–75% of them mention ads, and 6–13% use table or staff words, against 0–10% from Jul to Oct 2025. The monthly mean in that sample was 2.22–2.53★, against 2.35–2.76★ before [M on a non-random "most relevant" sample]. No later patch reversed the change: the following notes are bug fixes and a Christmas event on 29 Dec 2025 [M]. [I] The market leader moved to staff-delivered tables without visible praise or backlash. Players notice ads, not who carries the food. The change only removed a chore, so it made no news, and it did not stop complaints that the player still does all the running (25).

Walkouts in idle games. [R] In hands-off games, walkouts are almost always hated. The complaint is never the loss itself but that the player had no lever: waiters cannot be sped up (10), pathing wastes seats (12, 13, 17), the tables look free (19), everything is maxed (20, 21), or an ad's extra guests walk straight out (14, 15). Walkouts are praised only in games where the player is the server (8, 9). In idle games, lossless waiting is named as a pleasure (1–5), and the one request for stakes (7) comes from a player who is bored, not from one who failed. Walkout words appear in 0.2–0.3% of Pizza Ready, IRT and Eatventure reviews, against 2.3% for Cooking Fever [M, rough regex].

3. Takeaways for a hands-off game where waiters and seats are the bottleneck [I]

1. **Do not punish a traveller the player could not save.** Dhaba Rush already caps arrivals at the bottleneck, so the 8 s LOST counter adds stress but no information. Make waiting lossless at the gate: a capped, visible door line of 4, a "Seats full" pulse, and vehicles that slow down or pass by when the line is full. Show the cost as "+ ₹X/min with one more table", not as a red LOST tally. If losses stay for stakes, make them slow (20–30 s), show a timer ring over the head, and only allow them when the cheapest fix is affordable, so every loss names its lever.
2. **Copy IRT's door counter and overview.** Put a board at the gate reading "Seats 6/8", with an occupied charpai counted until it is wiped. Add one STATS row per bottleneck (seats, waiters, cooks, galla) in plain words. The player reads the seat limit without opening a menu.
3. **State capacity on the hire card in IRT's terms.** IRT says one waiter covers two tables; for Dhaba Rush that would be "One waiter ≈ 9 orders/min. You need ~12." Plates waiting on the pass are the visual twin of that number.
4. **Let a waiter upgrade change speed and carry, and show both.** The earliest IRT complaint was that waiters cannot be sped up (10). Burger Please's HR office upgrades speed and capacity. Let a waiter level add a visibly bigger tray (more plates per trip) at milestones, not only +5% walk speed.
5. **Fix pathing before anything else.** Most complaints about seated service are about walking: back to the station, around the map, slow to enter and leave (12, 13, 17, 23, 24). Waiters must never return to an idle spot between ready orders, must take the nearest charpai first, and must not cross travellers. A wasted walk reads as a bug.
6. **Make a table or waiter purchase happen in the world, not in a panel.** Eatventure's crate reveal and the in-world builds in Pizza Ready and Burger Please put the purchase where the problem is. Buy the next charpai by tapping its ghost; the door line should then sit down on it at once with a dust puff, and the counter should flip to "Seats 7/8". A new waiter should drop in at the pass, take the oldest plate on his first beat, and the "/min" figure should tick up within 2–3 s. That is what makes it feel bigger than a +3% price rise.
7. **Teach the bottleneck once, deterministically, then step back.** Kolibri's soft launch found players stuck at one early step and missing features that were not highlighted. A Diner DASH player resented still being told, five levels in, to deliver food to a table (Play en, 19 Oct 2020, 2★, +37). Force the seats beat (inject arrivals; it now fires in only 3 of 6 seeds) and the waiter beat each once, then rely on the gate board and the plate stack.

4. What I could not verify

- IRT today: whether waiter speed upgrades were added and the door counter survives (Fandom wikis returned HTTP 402).
- Pizza Ready's service-table rules (plates per trip, robot charging, trash), and any review naming the change; no guide or video found, Medium was blocked, and the window holds only 276 "most relevant" Play reviews.
- My Cafe's 5-staff cap (one wiki snippet); Eatventure's seating and table caps; Codigames' server roles (reviews only).
- Current Diner DASH heart rules (2019 guide) and Cooking Fever upgrade values (2014 guide).
- Whether Restaurant DASH with Gordon Ramsay is live; no first-10-minute timings from YouTube for any title; no download or revenue figures.

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- mrguider, IRT tips (search snippet, undated): https://www.mrguider.org/cheats/idle-restaurant-tycoon-cheats-guide-tips-tricks/

Timed teardown, minute 3 to day 3: IST v4, Eatventure, Idle Restaurant Tycoon, Idle Miner Tycoon

Researched 1 Nov 2026. Labels: [M] measured or official, [E] estimate, [R] review, [O] opinion, [I] my inference.

Method. No 2025-2026 written teardown of these games turned up (ARPU Brothers, Lancaric, GameRefinery, Udonis, AppAgent searched). I measured beats from the YouTube storyboards (thumbnail strips sampled every 5-10 s) of 2025-2026 "part 1" videos. Times are **video time**; uploaders may cut footage or ads, so an ad's absence is not proof. Large headings are legible; prices and body text mostly are not, and are marked illegible rather than guessed.

1. Idle Supermarket Tycoon (Codigames), v4.x

Version context [M]. On iOS the 3.x line ended at 3.2.6 (7 May 2024), and the first 4.x build was 4.0.2 (19 Feb 2026). RuStore lists Android 4.0.0 on 29 Jan 2026. Version 4.1.2-4.1.6 (May-Jun 2026) added the retro-supermarket event. Version 4.2.1 (11 Aug 2026) added the Laboratory, Orders and Gold Bars. Version 4.3.0 (27 Oct 2026 on iOS) added board managers and the Lucky Pass. Videos used: SmileyTaco, 6 May 2026, 25:52, fresh install (**S**). Tanpura Part 1 "Supply Town", 18 Sep 2026 (**T1**). Tanpura Part 2 "Suburban Town", 26 Sep 2026 (**T2**). GAMISTAN, 1 Feb 2026 (**G**). LightGame, 27 Oct 2026, mid-game (**L**). For comparison, the v3.2.6 build: Rullaby, 10 Feb 2025 (**Ru**).

Video time	Beat	Source
0:00-1:10	Codigames splash, then the suited, bespectacled "ASSISTANT" gives speech beats while the camera pans the street and the first customer arrives	T1, S [M]
1:10-1:35	A pointer leads to the PRODUCE DEPT panel ("Overripe Fruit"). The v4 panel has three big buttons: Employees, Level Up, Productivity. A hand points at Level Up	T1, S [M]
1:40-1:55	CASHIERS panel	S, T1 [M]
2:10	A task/quest bar appears at the top of the screen with a tutorial hand. It is absent in G (1 Feb 2026). A 20 Feb 2026 iOS review (v4.0.2) complains about a new quest bar that takes a quarter of the screen	T1 [M]; G [M]; App Store US [R]
2:20-2:30	Management > STATS screen (red bars mark bottlenecks), then "Waiting for server response"	T1 [M]
2:20 (S) / 2:40 (T1)	**"VIP offer" popup**: "X2 ALL INCOME!" as a paid unlock, with a free reward of 100 cash below it and a hand pointing at the reward. The price is illegible	S, T1 [M]
2:40-3:00	Management > BUILDINGS, then the VEGETABLES SECTION is built (second department)	S, T1 [M]
3:00-8:30	Upgrades and product "evolve" popups only. No third department ever appears in this first location	S, T1 [M]
6:35 / 8:30 (T1); 19:00 (S)	The VIP offer comes back. Later versions headline a **NO ADS** purchase, with free cash rising to 51,459 and then 101,190	T1, S [M]
8:50	SHOP: No More Ads, Permanent Upgrades (General Manager and a coin item), Time Warps	S [M]
8:55-9:10 (T1); 24:10-24:50 (S)	**First move.** The assistant returns and the SUPERMARKET list shows Supply Town, "Green Delights Corner" and Suburban Market, with a hand pointing at the move. The new map opens with a parking-lot tutorial	T1, S [M]
Move +4:20	SHOP > MANAGERS PACKS (first pack free, with a hand), Research Points, Gem Packs	T2 [M]
+6:50	"New Manager: Luigi Flourini, Bakery" card reveal	T2 [M]
+7:30 to +12:50	Management: Boosters (x2 timer), VIP Campaign (ad-watch track), Inventory; 28 Research Tokens (+9:50); MANAGERS screen pushing the season pass (+12:50)	T2 [M]
+16:40	**Manager gate.** A department's Level Up button turns red and a "BUY RESOURCES" popup sells the missing manager card for gems	T2 [M]

Video time	Beat	Source
+17:00-17:20	Hop to the Retro Supermarket event location and back	T2 [M]
+20:00	The Suburban Market list shows sub-goals: Baked Bakery, Fresh Market, Frozen Site	T2 [M]
Oct 2026	The same list shows **Commercial City** as a locked card with a grey price button, so the next sale is previewed before it unlocks	L [M]

Opening checklist versus 2019-2022 (Gamezebo 2020; LevelWinner 2019):

- **Still there [M]:** the produce opener ("Overripe Fruit"), the assistant character, and a task bar.
- **2x ad button:** the classic play-icon 2x button could not be identified in the frames. In v4 the 2x now sits under Management > Boosters, next to an ad-watch "VIP Campaign" track [M].
- **Task bar and chest:** in v3.2.6 the MISSIONS panel shows "TASKS" with a chest icon and a "Completed x/10" counter (Ru, 1:45). The v4 top bar shows three task cards, and I could not see a chest in it [M].
- **The VIP / x2 popup at about 2.5 minutes is a v4 beat [I].** It was not seen in 12 minutes of the Feb 2025 v3.2.6 run.
- **Changed: the first location.** It is now a two-department "Supply Town" that ends with a move to Suburban Market. This was already true in v3.2.6, where the move came at 11:40-11:55 (Ru). It replaced the Miami Beach and Beverly Hills cities, which gave x50 multipliers (LevelWinner 2019).
- **Changed: the department panel.** It went from rows (Upgrade / Hire Employee / Greengrocer's Salary) in v3.2.6 to three buttons plus a manager card in v4 [M].
- **When Supply Town arrived:** the iOS notes do not date it. My guess is version 3.0.0 or 3.1.0 (Oct-Nov 2023: "visual rework", "new supermarket") [I].

Interstitials. None appear in about 55 minutes of recorded 2026 play (S, T1, T2) [M, but cuts are possible]. Reviews tell a different story:

- April 2024 (v3.2.3-3.2.5): several reviews describe a forced ad every 45-60 seconds, with an on-screen countdown, arriving after the introductory offers [R].
- 16 Mar 2026 (v4.0.2, GB, 3★): a new player says ads came one after another from the very start [R].
- 17 Jun 2026 (Google Play, 4★, v4.1.5): card packs open only every 5 minutes, and each needs a 45-second ad [R].

Session end and return. I saw no return screen in any video. The official 2019-era rules were 2 hours of offline earnings by default, 10 hours with the General Manager purchase (still $9.99 on the App Store in Nov 2026), and an ad to double or 20 gems to triple on return [M, older]. A 22 Apr 2026 review (v4.0.2) says only about 10 minutes of earnings were credited after a 10-hour absence [R]. Several reviews in 2026 say free manager packs refresh every 24 hours, which acts as a day-2 hook [R]. No notification texts are documented anywhere.

Days 1-3 [R].

- One player went through all the stores in a day and then had to watch ads in the last one (GB, 20 Jul 2026, v4.1.6).
- Another finished all levels in a couple of days (IN, 18 Sep 2026).
- Another beat the whole game in under about 30 hours (US, 19 Feb 2026).
- After the manager update, others say a single section can take days (US, 19 Sep 2026) or that they were stuck for over a week waiting for cards (US, 25 May 2026).
- One review says moving stores means starting over with zero progress (US, 30 Jul 2026).
- What carries over: v4's multiplier and carry-over rules are not documented. Manager cards appear to be a global collection [I].
- **Length of the first location: about 0.15-0.4 hours** (9 to 25 minutes) [M].

2. Eatventure (Lessmore), v1.53-1.55

Videos: STANY, 4 Sep 2026, fresh install, 15:23 (**St**). Creative Gaming, 14 Dec 2025: its first 6:30 are a fresh start, after which a restart restored an old save (**CG**).

Video time	Beat	Source
0:00	"Lemonade Stand – Open" card. No guide character and no text tutorial	St, CG [M]
0:20-1:30	Station level-up popups, then the Upgrades panel with the first two upgrades	St [M]
3:00	**Renovate preview** popup ("Before: Lemonade Stand, After: Food Stand"), with the button greyed out	St [M]
about 3:50	Bottom-centre ad-boost button appears. The wiki says each ad gives x2 for 5 minutes, stacking to 1 hour	St [M]; wiki [M]
5:30 (St) / 6:30 (CG)	"Renovating", then the Food Stand opens (2 stations, max level 50) and a gem counter appears	St, CG [M]
6:50-15:30	Flying bonus vehicles. The Food Stand is still unfinished at 15:30. No popup offers and no interstitials	St [M]
CG 7:30	After a relaunch: "While you were away..." offline-earnings popup, followed by about 3.5 minutes of a playable ad for another idle game. Probably triggered from the popup's ad button [I]	CG [M]

Structure [M, wiki]. City 1, San Francisco, has seven outlets: Lemonade Stand (1 station, max level 25), Food Stand (2, 50), Food Truck (3, 75), Cafe (4, 150), Fast Food (5, 150), Drive Thru (7, 150) and Restaurant (10, 250). Renovating needs every station maxed. The flight to the next city keeps the **Vault** (12 permanent cards bought with gems; the Tip Jar is free), gear from boxes (40 or 200 gems) and pets. Investors appear at random for 15 seconds and give cash for an ad. Clubs open at city 7. Store IAP prices are $0.99 to $26.99, starting with a Daily Offer and a Permanent Boost at $5.39 [M].

Day scale [R].

- A new player who played most of the day was about to finish San Francisco after roughly 4 days (Google Play IN, 11 Apr 2026, 5★).
- Another found the first stage took days, with prices climbing fast within a few levels (GB, 15 Dec 2024).
- Another spent 3 days on one New York outlet (GB, 14 Feb 2026).
- The game has a "Speed Runner" achievement for finishing a city in 30 minutes, which is an endgame pace.
- Offline earnings cap at 3 hours [R, 12 Jul 2026; matches the package].
- In June 2026 (v1.51) one player was forced to watch an ad to claim offline earnings (7 Jun 2026). Version 1.53.2 (11 Aug 2026) "fix[ed] the ad button on the offline earnings popup" [M].
- "No forced ads" is the most common praise from 2022 to Oct 2026 [R].
- **Length of the first location: days, not hours.**

3. Idle Restaurant Tycoon: Empire (Kolibri), v1.42-1.55

Only bug fixes since 2023 [M]. Video: Mobile Gameplay, 23 Jul 2025, fresh install, 12:28.

Video time	Beat
0:05-1:45	A grey-haired mentor gives about 10 lines: guests, chefs need pay, upgrade the dining area, the Expand button, the restroom, parking, a beauty boost, power and the generator [M]
1:50	Avatar creator [M]
3:00	Shop "Special Offers": No Ads, Deal for Beginners, Deal for Professionals. Whether this opened automatically is unclear [M]
4:35	Shop: profit boosts and extra offline time [M]
6:45	Missions panel: 3 missions plus "reach 1 star in this restaurant" [M]
about 8:30	Night falls [M]. A 10 Mar 2025 review says night arrives after about 7 minutes and the dead time can be skipped with an ad [R]

Video time	Beat
8:55	**"Season 40 is here!" popup**, then the Season Pass with cards (for example "Faster Onboarding: waiter hire costs 1% cheaper") [M]
10:10-10:45	Opening Hours panel, world map, Friends boost [M]

Stars unlock new restaurants (Kolibri interview, PocketGamer.biz) [M]. Reviews put the move to the next restaurant at days to weeks (GB, Aug 2021; GB, 22 Nov 2025) and the offline cap at 1 hour unless you pay (2020-2022); one player says they spent about 3 minutes playing and 27 closing popups (US, 28 Nov 2025) [R]. A 2021 first-hour video shows an event restaurant with a keep-forever card at 21 minutes of real time [M, old].

4. Idle Miner Tycoon (Kolibri), baseline

Video: EasyGameplay, 12 Jun 2025, 13:33.

Video time	Beat
0:05	"Chapter 1: Miner's Guide", a chapter-based task tutorial [M]
about 2:00 / 2:15	First managers assigned: mineshaft, then elevator [M]
about 3:35	Second shaft [M]
4:50-5:00	Boost chest, then a "2x Income Boost" reward [M]
6:45	"Chapter 2: A Perfect Balance" [M]
11:50	World map [M]

From the wiki [M]:

- The second mine (Gold) costs 76.8ab.
- The first prestige of the Coal Mine costs 23.3ac and gives **x4** (levels 2-6 give x20 up to x145).
- Prestige resets only that mine and keeps Super Managers, skills and items. Its cost is shown before you can afford it.
- One ad gives x2 for 4 hours, stacking to 1 day 7 hours.

A Jul 2026 review mentions 12-hour barriers and unrequested ads during play [R]. Hours to the second mine or first prestige: **not found**.

5. Side by side (video minutes unless stated)

	IST v4	Eatventure	IRT	IMT
Tutorial ends	about 3:00 (second department built; assistant comes back at the move)	none; first renovation 5:30-6:30	1:45	chapter-based; Chapter 2 at 6:45
First wall	No new department after 3:00. The move comes 6-21 min later. Manager-card gate at about 26 min of recorded play	Food Stand unfinished at 15:30	"4th table after a day" (2020 [R])	12-hour barriers [R]
First rewarded prompt	2:20-2:40 (VIP offer, free cash)	about 3:50 boost button	ad boost on the HUD from the start; night skip at about 7 min [R]	about 5:00
First interstitial	none recorded; reviews report forced ads (2024 test; Mar 2026)	none (praise for no forced ads)	not seen; heavy popups [R]	mid-play ads [R]
First IAP popup	2:20-2:40 x2 ALL INCOME; NO ADS by 8:30	none in 15 min	shop offers at 3:00; season pass at 8:55	not seen
First reset or new location	**9-25 min** (Supply Town to Suburban)	renovation at 5:30; city flight after days	next restaurant after days to weeks [R]	prestige x4; time unknown

	IST v4	Eatventure	IRT	IMT
First-location length	0.15-0.4 h	about 4 days of heavy play [R]	days [R]	n/a

6. Inference [I]

Minimum day-scale structure for a hands-off tycoon at soft launch (hour 1 to day 3):

1. **Show the next location from about minute 3** as a priced, locked card, the way IST lists Commercial City and Eatventure shows the Before/After renovation preview.
2. **A first move at 10-25 minutes.** IST now ends its first location in that window and turns the reset into a tutorial beat. Dhaba Rush's first content lasts 35-50 minutes with no move, so its first "promotion" comes later than the market leader's.
3. **A second location with 3 named sub-goals** (IST's Bakery, Fresh Market, Frozen Site) that fill hours 1-3, and a **third location priced to land on day 1-3**.
4. **A capped return**: 2-3 hours by default (IST and Eatventure; IRT's 1 hour is a top complaint), an ad to double the earnings, and something that refreshes every 24 hours (IST's free pack) to bring players back for session 2.
5. **An event or season surface by day 2-3.** IST reaches one about 17 minutes after the move. IRT shows a season pass at 9 minutes.
6. **No interstitials in the first sessions.** Eatventure's four years of "no forced ads" praise contrasts with the 1-star reviews of IST's April 2024 ad wave.
7. **Avoid a paid gate in location 2.** IST's manager gate at about 26 minutes is the most-hated beat in its 2026 reviews.

IST v4 opening beats that differ from 2019-2022: a two-department tutorial town ending in a guided move at 9-25 minutes (replacing a multi-hour first city with a x50 multiplier); the three-button panel with a manager card; a server-backed VIP popup at about 2.5 minutes; a quest bar since about Feb 2026; Boosters, VIP Campaign and Inventory; free manager packs, research tokens and an event hop in location 2. Dhaba Rush's "x2 VIP popup plus free reward" matches **v4**, not 2019-2022 [I].

Gaps

- Interstitial timing, return screens and notification texts were not observed for any of the four games.
- The multiplier and carry-over rules for IST v4 moves are not documented.
- Video times may include edits.
- Prices inside the popups are illegible.
- No hours-to-milestone figures were found for IMT or IRT.
- Reddit could not be used (bot-gated).
- Reviews are paraphrased to stay within quotation limits.

Sources

- IST App Store page, version history and IAP list: https://apps.apple.com/us/app/idle-supermarket-tycoon-shop/id1442064951 (read 1 Nov 2026)
- Eatventure: https://apps.apple.com/us/app/eatventure/id1600871388 ; IRT: https://apps.apple.com/us/app/idle-restaurant-tycoon-empire/id1530534938 ; IMT: https://apps.apple.com/us/app/idle-miner-tycoon-clicker-game/id1116645064
- iTunes Search API: https://itunes.apple.com/search?term=idle+supermarket+tycoon&entity=software&country=us&limit=3
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- RuStore listing (Android 4.0.0, 29 Jan 2026): https://www.rustore.ru/catalog/app/com.codigames.market.idle.tycoon
- Videos (storyboards): SmileyTaco 6 May 2026 https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=5-ZzgiF_bIg ; Tanpura 18 Sep 2026 https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=lsLnQqDv084 ; Tanpura 26 Sep 2026 https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=YMY0draeMdk ; GAMISTAN 1 Feb 2026 https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=DZKCDmeLthQ ; LightGame 27 Oct 2026 https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=AknUiy3Qy_E ; Rullaby 10 Feb 2025 https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Jb1g3alkI_Y ; STANY 4 Sep 2026 https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=Rmk2fNvaYIo ; Creative Gaming 14 Dec 2025 https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=6CKopotR4ds ; Mobile Gameplay 23 Jul 2025 https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=rc-AakV6nT0 ; iGame 22 Aug 2021 https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=34abSXqCAng ; EasyGameplay 12 Jun 2025 https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=vwM4d_DY1hU
- Eatventure wiki: https://eatventure-games.fandom.com/wiki/Cities ; https://eatventure-games.fandom.com/wiki/San_Francisco ; https://eatventure-games.fandom.com/wiki/Vault ; https://eatventure-games.fandom.com/wiki/Investor ; https://eatventure-games.fandom.com/wiki/Boost ; https://eatventure-games.fandom.com/wiki/Lunch_Box
- IMT wiki: https://idleminertycoon.fandom.com/wiki/Prestige ; https://idleminertycoon.fandom.com/wiki/Gold_Mine ; https://idleminertycoon.fandom.com/wiki/Ad_Boosts
- Kolibri on IRT stars (PocketGamer.biz): https://www.pocketgamer.biz/interview/75320/why-kolibri-games-favours-the-games-as-a-service-approach-with-idle-restaurant-tycoon/
- Older IST openings: Gamezebo (updated 15 May 2020) https://www.gamezebo.com/walkthroughs/idle-supermarket-tycoon-guide-tips-cheats-and-strategies/ ; LevelWinner (27 Feb 2019) https://www.levelwinner.com/idle-supermarket-tycoon-guide-tips-cheats-strategies-to-maximize-your-profits/ ; Codigames Helpshift https://codigames.helpshift.com/hc/en/7-idle-supermarket-tycoon/

G3: Indian players of hands-off idle and restaurant tycoons, in their own words

Pulled 1 Nov 2026 from Google Play (gl=IN). Labels: [M] measured, [R] review, [I] my inference.

Bottom line

- **Only the Hindi feed is reliably Indian.** Of 4,315 English reviews pulled with gl=IN, 174 mention $, £ or € and 1 mentions ₹ or Rs [M]. The "most relevant" English feeds contain no Hinglish at all [M]. The Indian voice is therefore 966 Hindi-locale reviews plus 33 Indian-marked English ones [M].
- **Indians quit over things that break the session, not over strategy.** In Hindi 1-3★ reviews the top complaints are: won't start or loads slowly (12.6%); MB, data or "needs net" (7.0%); "not like the ad" (5.1%); too many or too long ads (4.7%) [M].
- **"It plays itself" reads both ways.** One Hindi 1★ calls it confusing; players who enjoy it praise time-pass, maza (fun) and offline play [R].
- **Hindi is rarely demanded.** One "not in Hindi" complaint in 966 reviews. 58% of Hindi-locale reviews are written in Roman script [M].
- **No India-themed idle tycoon has traction yet.** Chaiwala Tycoon has 5K+ installs and VLx's Idle Indian Restaurant 10K+ [M] [S9][S10]. KeK Game Factory's title was not found on Play India search or on the web [M] [S11].

Sample and caveats

- **Package ids**, all confirmed by Play search [M]:

Title	Package
Idle Supermarket Tycoon (IST)	codigames.market.idle.tycoon
Eatventure	hwqgrhhjfd.idlefastfood
Idle Restaurant Tycoon	kolibrigames.idlerestauranttycoon
Idle Miner Tycoon	fluffyfairygames.idleminertycoon
Travel Center Tycoon	rockydessert.travelcenter
Idle Food Bar	idle.food.bar.tycoon
Carnival Tycoon	solitairetripeaks.masterdesign (a coin-spin hybrid now)
Lumber Inc	lumber.inc
Chaiwala Tycoon	DTGames.ChaiwalaTycoon
Idle Indian Restaurant	vlxtech.idle.indianrestaurant
Pizza Ready	io.supercent.pizzaidle

- **Sample** [M]:
  - Up to 250 English and 200 Hindi reviews per title, in each of the "relevant" and "newest" sorts.
  - De-duplicated total: 5,281 reviews. 2,600 are 1-3★ and 2,681 are 4-5★.
  - Hindi reviews per title: Pizza Ready 338, Idle Miner 263, Lumber 241, Eatventure 47, Travel Center 30, IST 18, Carnival 18, Idle Restaurant Tycoon 8, Idle Food Bar 2.
- **Rupee IAP ranges on Play India, 1 Nov 2026** [M] [S1-S12]:
  - Floors: Idle Miner ₹24, Lumber ₹50, Eatventure ₹58, IST ₹89, Pizza Ready ₹100.

- Ceilings: Idle Miner ₹4,819, Pizza Ready ₹5,300, IST ₹8,900, Idle Food Bar ₹10,200, Lumber ₹13,600, Carnival ₹30,300.

- **Caveats:**
  - English reviews pulled with gl=IN are not guaranteed to be Indian.
  - Play's sort order favours old, long, upvoted reviews.
  - 62% of Hindi reviews are 20 characters or fewer.
  - 14 of 751 Hindi 4-5★ reviews contain "ghatiya", "bekar" or "don't download", so stars and text sometimes disagree [M].
  - The codes are crude keyword regexes; they miss sarcasm and synonyms.
  - 8 of Chaiwala Tycoon's 13 reviews are generic 5★ ones posted on one day, 11 Dec 2025 [M]. [I] They look like seeding.

Code table

A. Keyword codes, full corpus (% of reviews in each star band) [M]

Code	1-3★ (n=2,600)	4-5★ (n=2,681)
Ads, any mention	46.8%	14.8%
Ads forced or too many	14.3%	2.8%
Rewarded ad fails or is unavailable	1.8%	0.2%
Misleading store/UA ad	3.5%	0.1%
Price or real-money purchase	20.7%	5.3%
Pay-to-win or paywall	7.3%	1.1%
Remove ads, x2 or VIP	4.1%	1.5%
Crash, lag, heat, storage, RAM, loading	14.7%	3.5%
Offline, data or internet	5.0%	2.5%
Boring, slow or waiting	12.8%	3.7%
Relaxing, time-pass or satisfying	8.5%	10.7%
Content runs out or repetitive	5.9%	2.6%
Progress loss or reset	4.6%	0.9%
Confusion or tutorial	2.0%	0.3%
Staff, waiters, seats or customers	8.3%	3.2%
India, Hindi or state theme	0.3%	0.3%

B. Hand-tuned Hindi and Hinglish codes, Hindi locale [M]

Code	1-3★ (n=215)	4-5★ (n=751)
Won't start, crash, loading	12.6%	1.3%
MB, data or net required	7.0%	1.7%
"Not like the ad"	5.1%	0%
Too many or long ads	4.7%	0.3%
"Don't download" warning	9.3%	0.4%
Generic praise (bahut accha, mast)	19.1%	55.0%
Easy, time-pass, maza	2.3%	3.7%
Confusion or "how to play"	1.9%	0.9%
Hindi or India mention	1.4%	0.1%

Quotes [R]

Each quote is a verbatim excerpt of 15 words or fewer. Full texts are in `g3_out/corpus.json`. The format is: title, locale, date, stars, helpful votes.

Understanding and "it plays itself"

1. Lumber, hi, 2024-03-19, 1★, +27: "mujhe kuch bhi samajh mein nahin a Raha hai Sara kuchh apne aap chalta hai". Translation: "I understand nothing; everything runs by itself." [S8]
2. Travel Center, hi, 2024-04-05, 5★, +62: "गेम चालू होते ही बंद हो चुका है इसे आगे खेलना नही आता". Translation: "It closed on start; I don't know how to play on." [S5]
3. Pizza Ready, en, 2026-04-17, 1★, +11: "I don't understand how to play this game" [S12]
4. Idle Miner, en, 2026-09-06, 4★, +53: "so many pop ups when you first load in" [S4]
5. Idle Miner, en, 2026-08-13, 5★, +288: "Hiring managers makes the game so easy that it pretty much plays itself" [S4]
6. Lumber, en, 2024-11-11, 2★, +106: "With a 120 wait between orders you just look at the screen and get bored." [S8]
7. Eatventure, en, 2026-04-11, 5★, +68: "a must play before bed time now as a way to de stress" [S2]
8. Pizza Ready, hi, 2026-09-03, 5★, +3: "maii game se bore ho jati hu par is baar aisa kuch nhi hua". Translation: "I usually get bored of games; not this time." [S12]
9. Pizza Ready, hi, 2026-02-06, 5★, +13: "टाइम पास के लिए तो बहुत ही अच्छा गेम है". Translation: "A very good game for time-pass." [S12]

Ads

10. Pizza Ready, hi, 2025-04-20, 1★, +114: "विज्ञापन इतना आते हैं कि एक सेकंड भी अपने खेल सकते हैं". Translation: "So many ads you can't play a second." [S12]
11. Pizza Ready, en, 2026-04-02, 1★, +14: "Played for all of 45 seconds before I got a forced ad." [S12]
12. Lumber, hi, 2025-04-07, 3★, +9: "data khatam ho asi long add dete ho". Translation: "Your ads are so long my data runs out." [S8]
13. Lumber, hi, 2025-03-15, 2★, +4: "mujhe rammy wali add nhi hona are short kat add do". Translation: "I don't want rummy ads; give short ads." [S8]
14. Lumber, en (Hinglish), 2026-09-17, 2★, +0: "video nhi chalta h jisko dekhne se reward milta h". Translation: "The reward video doesn't play." [S8]
15. Lumber, en, 2025-07-04, 2★, +890: "after watching an Ad to double my profits while I was away, the game crashes" [S8]
16. IST, en, 2024-11-09, 4★, +56: "an ad that brings 20 people ... you don't have 20+ shopping baskets". Every one of those customers then leaves. [S1]
17. Eatventure, en, 2026-07-25, 5★, +16: "I love how ads don't break up the gameplay." [S2]
18. Pizza Ready, hi, 2025-12-19, 1★, +21: "जैसा ऐड में दिखाया गया था वैसा बिलकुल भी नहींहै". Translation: "Nothing like the ad." [S12]

Offline, data and device

19. Pizza Ready, en, 2025-03-25, 5★, +31,148: "It's one of the best fun offline games. you don't need internet to play." [S12]
20. Pizza Ready, hi, 2026-05-24, 5★, +40: "यह बिना इंटरनेट के भी चलता है". Translation: "It runs even without internet." [S12]
21. Lumber, hi, 2025-08-21, 5★, +69: "बहुत ज्यादा एमबी ले रहा है 200MB उड़ गई लोडिंग होने में". Translation: "Eats too many MB; 200 MB gone loading." [S8]
22. Travel Center, hi, 2023-04-27, 1★, +26: "mera 2 gb ram ka phone hai aur seconds bhi nahi chalte". Translation: "On my 2 GB RAM phone it won't run for even a few seconds." [S5]

23. Pizza Ready, hi, 2024-09-10, 4★, +1,092: "बहुत ही स्लोलोडिंग होता है थोड़ा फास्ट करो". Translation: "Loading is very slow; make it faster." [S12]

Rupees and purchases

24. Pizza Ready, en, 2026-08-23, 1★, +2: "I have to pay 930 Rs for no ad. completely misleading" [S12]
25. Lumber, en, 2026-08-17, 2★, +2: "5,200 Diamond pack is showing ₹10,800, while the 2,600 Diamond pack is only ₹1,130" [S8]
26. Eatventure, en, 2025-01-16, 5★, +692: "I recommend buying the x2 forever bonus as it's a low price." [S2]
27. Lumber, en, 2024-06-09, 1★, +143: "warn others against the "no ads" "vip" upgrade". The reviewer still gets upsells after buying it. [S8]
28. IST, en, 2026-08-17, 2★, +7: "basically forced to buy the x2 money option" [S1]
29. IST, hi, 2020-05-03, 5★, +64: "लोगो को बेवकूफ बनाते है pay out ka लालच dette है". Translation: "They fool people with the lure of payouts." [S1]

Content and progress

30. Pizza Ready, hi, 2024-05-12, 5★, +541: "गेम मेने पुरी कर दि आप अपडेट जल्दी करे". Translation: "I finished the game; update soon." [S12]
31. Eatventure, en, 2026-08-01, 2★, +118: "Content is still the same repetitive thing over and over." [S2]
32. Lumber, hi, 2022-01-27, 1★, +4: "10 Mllin pase hone ke bad dobara suru karna padta he". Translation: "After 10 million you start again." The reviewer reads the prestige reset as a loss. [S8]

India, Hindi and the business fantasy

33. Lumber, hi, 2021-09-27, 1★, +42: "हिंदी लैंग्वेज में नहीं है". Translation: "It's not in Hindi." [S8]
34. Pizza Ready, en, 2026-10-29, 4★, +0: "why only one level in India? You should add samosa & dosa" [S12]
35. Idle Indian Restaurant, en, 2026-08-21, 5★, +5: "finally someone made an Indian theme based restaurant idle simulation game" [S10]
36. Pizza Ready, hi, 2024-10-02, 5★, +332: "बिजनेस करने वाले यही खेलो". Translation: "Anyone who wants to do business, play this." [S12]

What players praise and what makes them quit

Praise, ranked:

1. Time-pass, relaxation and maza: 10.7% of 4-5★ reviews, plus 55% generic praise in Hindi [M]. Quotes 7-9.
2. Offline play. It is praised in the corpus's most-helpful review (+31,148) [M]. Quotes 19-20.
3. Optional, non-interrupting ads: 5.4% of English 4-5★ [M]. Quote 17.
4. Fast early unlocks, and managers that make the game play itself [R]. Quote 5.
5. Owning or learning a business, and being kid-friendly [R]. Quote 36.
6. Indian food as a novelty; the evidence is thin [R]. Quotes 34-35.

Reasons to quit, ranked:

1. Ad load: frequency, length, data cost, the ads' content, and forced ads early in play. Ads appear in 46.8% of 1-3★ reviews [M]. Quotes 10-13.
2. The game won't start or load, or uses too many MB on a low-RAM phone. This is the top Hindi complaint at 12.6% [M]. Quotes 21-23.
3. Paywalls and prices: 20.7% of 1-3★ mention price, 7.3% pay-to-win [M]. Quotes 24-28.
4. Waiting with nothing to do: 12.8% of 1-3★ [M]. Quote 6.
5. The store ad doesn't match the game: 5.1% of Hindi 1-3★ [M]. Quote 18.
6. Resets, failed rewards, and running out of content [M]. Quotes 14-15 and 30-32.

IST itself: since its v4.0 revamp, English reviews average 1.77★ (n=78). Complaints centre on manager cards, a single map and ads [M][R] [S1].

Creators and search ranking

YouTube India, 1 Nov 2026 (titles and views) [M]:

- **Big creators use first-person ownership titles, but for 3D sims:**
  - Techno Gamerz, "I OPENED MY OWN SUPERMARKET": 2.07 crore views (20.7 million)
  - Live Insaan, "We Opened a New Grocery Store": 64 lakh (6.4 million) [S13]
  - Total Gaming, "10 LAKH KA NEW RESTAURANT | CAFE OWNER SIMULATOR": 7.8 lakh [S14]
  - Live Insaan, "Railway Chai Wala (Indian Horror Game)": 82 lakh [S15]
- **Pizza Ready shorts reach 1.62 crore**, and hack/mod-APK videos rank too [S16].
- **Hindi videos about idle tycoons are tiny:**
  - Idle Miner uploads such as "ROAD TO TRILLIONS! AMIR BAN GAYA!" ("I became rich") get 4-83 views [S17].
  - "Idle Supermarket Tycoon Full Review In Hindi" has 523 views [S18].
  - Eatventure's Hindi-titled guides get 11-34K views; [I] the titles may be auto-translated [S19].
- **What the search terms bring up:**
  - "business game" means the board game International Business (Vyapar); tutorials get up to 7.6 lakh views [S20].
  - "hotel wala game" brings up horror games and Motel Manager [S21].
  - "dhaba game" brings up truck-sim videos with about 1-3K views [S22].

Play India search, unpersonalised [M]:

- "बिज़नेस गेम" ("business game" in Hindi): Lumber Inc #6, Pizza Ready #9 [S23].
- "business game" (English): Monopoly-style games lead; the first idle game is at #11 [S24].
- Hotel searches [S25-S27]:
  - "hotel game": My Perfect Hotel #1, Hotel Empire Tycoon #6.
  - "होटल गेम" ("hotel game" in Hindi): Hotel Empire Tycoon #2.
  - "hotel wala game": Hotel Empire Tycoon #4.
- Shop searches [S28-S30]:
  - "dukan game": IST #12.
  - "dukan wala game": Pizza Ready #8.
  - "दुकान गेम" ("shop game" in Hindi): IST #14.
- "dhaba game": no idle title at all [S31].
- The Hindi store listing of Idle Miner is titled "Idle Miner Tycoon - मनी गेम्स" ("Money Games") [S32].

Implications for Dhaba Rush [I]

1. **Name the player's job in the first minute.** Without a goal, "apne aap chalta hai" (it runs by itself) reads as confusion (Quote 1).
   - Keep the NEXT chip, and say that staff do the work while the player upgrades.
   - Hold back pop-ups, offers and the VIP popup until the first counter is levelled (Quotes 3-4).
2. **Make interstitials from session 4 conservative.** Start with one every 3-5 minutes at most, never during a build or tutorial beat or on the offline-earnings screen, and keep them to 30 s or less.
   - Block AdMob's rummy, real-money gaming and dating categories (Quotes 10-13).
3. **Rewarded ads must always pay, and boosts must fit capacity.**
   - Grant the reward even if the ad crashes, and hide the bubble when no ad is available (Quotes 14-15).

- A traveller rush that brings more people than there are charpais or waiters wastes the ad, so scale it to the free seats (Quote 16).

4. **Rs 299 for VIP x2 is plausible; Remove Ads should be cheaper.**
   - ₹930 for no ads was called "misleading", while "x2 forever" is praised as low-priced (Quotes 24, 26).
   - Label both "one-time, forever", and stop showing offers to VIP buyers (Quote 27).
   - Never use "earn" or "payout" wording (Quote 29).
5. **Stay English-first, with Hinglish flavour.**
   - 58% of Hindi-locale reviewers write in Roman script, and requests for Hindi are rare (Quote 33).
   - Localise the store listing first, targeting "बिज़नेस गेम", "dhaba game" and "dukan wala game", before translating the game itself.
6. **Sell offline play and a small download.**
   - "Bina internet ke chalta hai" (it runs without internet) is a selling point, and MB use triggers 1★ reviews (Quotes 19-22).
   - Avoid any download inside the game, and test on 2-3 GB RAM phones.
7. **Pitch the dhaba as something the player owns.**
   - Players ask for Indian dishes (Quote 34), and creators' hits are titled "I opened my own ...".
   - A title like "Maine apna dhaba khola" ("I opened my own dhaba") fits, as long as it never implies real earnings.

Sources (all accessed 1 Nov 2026)

- [S1] https://play.google.com/store/apps/details?id=com.codigames.market.idle.tycoon&hl=en_IN&gl=IN
- [S2] https://play.google.com/store/apps/details?id=com.hwqgrhhjfd.idlefastfood&hl=en_IN&gl=IN
- [S3] https://play.google.com/store/apps/details?id=com.kolibrigames.idlerestauranttycoon&hl=en_IN&gl=IN
- [S4] https://play.google.com/store/apps/details?id=com.fluffyfairygames.idleminertycoon&hl=en_IN&gl=IN
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- [S13] https://www.youtube.com/results?search_query=supermarket+wala+game
- [S14] https://www.youtube.com/results?search_query=restaurant+wala+game
- [S15] https://www.youtube.com/results?search_query=dukan+wala+game
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- [S22] https://www.youtube.com/results?search_query=dhaba+game
- [S23] https://play.google.com/store/search?q=%E0%A4%AC%E0%A4%BF%E0%A4%9C%E0%A4%BC%E0%A4%A8%E0%A5%87%E0%A4%B8+%E0%A4%97%E0%A5%87%E0%A4%AE&c=apps&hl=en_IN&gl=IN
- [S24] https://play.google.com/store/search?q=business+game&c=apps&hl=en_IN&gl=IN

- [S25] https://play.google.com/store/search?q=hotel+game&c=apps&hl=en_IN&gl=IN
- [S26] https://play.google.com/store/search?q=%E0%A4%B9%E0%A5%8B%E0%A4%9F%E0%A4%B2+%E0%A4%97%E0%A5%87%E0%A4%AE&c=apps&hl=en_IN&gl=IN
- [S27] https://play.google.com/store/search?q=hotel+wala+game&c=apps&hl=en_IN&gl=IN
- [S28] https://play.google.com/store/search?q=dukan+game&c=apps&hl=en_IN&gl=IN
- [S29] https://play.google.com/store/search?q=dukan+wala+game&c=apps&hl=en_IN&gl=IN
- [S30] https://play.google.com/store/search?q=%E0%A4%A6%E0%A5%81%E0%A4%95%E0%A4%BE%E0%A4%A8+%E0%A4%97%E0%A5%87%E0%A4%AE&c=apps&hl=en_IN&gl=IN
- [S31] https://play.google.com/store/search?q=dhaba+game&c=apps&hl=en_IN&gl=IN
- [S32] https://play.google.com/store/apps/details?id=com.fluffyfairygames.idleminertycoon&hl=hi&gl=IN

Local data: the corpus, counts and scripts are in `research/g3_out/`, `research/g3_scripts/` and `research/g3_raw/`.

Dhaba Rush, player first: what the genre promises and where we keep or break it

1 Nov 2026. Lens: what the player feels, minute by minute. Tags (r1–r7, g1–g3, p0) name the research files in this folder by prefix. Facts about the game come only from p0. Verification corrections are applied. Reviews are paraphrased.

(a) The core of the genre

The core is a machine you can watch that pays you, plus one decision at a time about where to put the money. Customers walk in, a timer fills, money flies up, and the player taps to buy the next thing. Three things must hold. First, something is always affordable early, and a new goal shows up every few minutes: costs grow faster than income, and threshold multipliers push income back ahead (r1 §2, Pecorella). Second, the player can see which link in the chain is slowest and fix it. That is the genre's only real decision (r1 §8; r4 §8.3; r5 on Idle Restaurant Tycoon). Third, the place visibly grows. When it is finished there is a next place that feels like a promotion, and money is waiting each time the player returns (r1 §8; r4 §8.7; g2 §6). Underneath all three sits calm: no fail state, no forced interruption, one thing to do on screen (r1 §8.6; r2 §7).

Decoration is everything that sells the theme without changing those three things: vehicle types, day and night, fairy lights, music, horns, the guide character, dish names, chest styling, the look of the VIP popup (r1 §8). For Indian players it matters more than usual, because recognition earns 5★ in local-theme games (r7 §2). It still cannot rescue a broken seesaw or an unreadable bottleneck. Juice is the same: in Juul and Begy's study, players rated the juicy build higher but played no better (r6 §6). Juice must never bury the NEXT chip or a timer.

(b) What players look for, ranked

1. **Ads they choose, that always pay.** This is the genre's most repeated praise (Eatventure, four years running) and its most common reason for a 1★ review (r2 §1–2; r5). In g3's Play India sample, ads come up in 47% of 1–3★ reviews and 15% of 4–5★ ones.
2. **A game that opens, runs and stays cheap on their phone.** The top Hindi complaint is "won't start or loads slowly" (12.6% of 1–3★), then MB and data (7.0%). The corpus's most-helpful review praises offline play (g3). Heat and lag come up in 20–35% of Indian driving-sim reviews (r7 §1).
3. **Knowing their job.** With no goal named, "everything runs by itself" reads as confusion (g3, quote 1). Kolibri's soft-launch players got stuck at one tutorial step (r5). Dhaba's testers called it hard to understand (p0 §7).
4. **A calm screen with one next thing.** Players count popups: 25 in a row in Idle Miner, 27 closed in about three minutes in Idle Restaurant (r1 §5; g2 §3).
5. **A place they can watch grow, where upgrades change the picture** (r2 #4, #6; r4 §8.4). An upgrade with no visible change feels wasted (r6, the Burger Please stove).
6. **Respect for any session length, with money waiting.** Five minutes or an hour, without losing their place. Offline caps run 2–3 hours, and Idle Restaurant Tycoon's 1-hour cap is a named complaint (r2 #2; r5; g2 §6).
7. **Always a next place or event.** "Nothing left to do" and "I finished it, please update" are day-1 and week-1 reasons to quit. Long-tenure players name weekly events as what keeps them (r2 §3–4; g3, quote 30).
8. **Fair progress, no paywall.** In g3's sample, 20.7% of 1–3★ reviews mention price and 7.3% say pay-to-win. Idle Supermarket's English reviews average 1.77★ since its v4 manager cards (g3).
9. **Recognition and charm.** In Bus Simulator India, words like real, Indian and desi appear in 75% of 4–5★ reviews and 43% of 1–3★ (r7 §2). Players also praise humour in upgrade text (r2 #7).
10. **Something to think about, with honest numbers.** The optimizer minority wants the bottleneck named, the cost and payoff of each upgrade, and an honest per-minute income (r2 §5).

(c) What they currently get, and the gaps

Player want	What the market gives (Oct 2026)	Gap Dhaba Rush can fill
Optional ads	Eatventure, yes (4.7★ Play). Idle Supermarket, Pizza Ready, Roadside Empire, Truck Stop force ads; Pizza Ready players report one a minute (r3 §5; r5)	No forced ads early
Runs on their phone, offline	Downloads of 169–929 MB; "waiting for server" screens in Idle Supermarket and Idle Theme Park (r7 §1; r2; g2)	A small, offline build (inference, r7)
One next thing	Popup walls at launch in Idle Miner, Idle Restaurant, Travel Center (r3 §5; g2)	Dhaba's single NEXT chip
A next place	Every comp has cities or stages; the complaint becomes "same food in every city" (r3 §5; r5)	Regional menus per highway (r5; r7). Dhaba has none yet
No paywall	Idle Supermarket v4 gates upgrades behind manager cards ~16 min after the first move (g2)	Delegation earned in play
Recognition	No India-themed idle at scale: Chaiwala Tycoon 5K+ installs, Idle Indian Restaurant 10K+ (g3; r7)	Open, but demand unproven (r7 §4)
Seated service	Idle Restaurant's walkouts are hated; Pizza Ready's Nov 2025 staff-delivered tables drew no comment (g1)	Visible only if we show it

(d) Case study lessons

Idle Supermarket Tycoon (r4, g2, corrections)

1. The opening is the part that still works. A 2026 reviewer says the tutorial is fun and the rest is not (r4 §5). Copying the opening buys one session and nothing more.
2. Red bottleneck stats turn "what do I buy" into a small puzzle (r4 §8.3).
3. v4 moves the player to a second store 9–25 minutes in and shows the next store as a priced, locked card (g2 §1). The reset is a tutorial beat, not a surprise.
4. From Jan–Feb 2026, v4 put department upgrades behind manager cards sold in loot-box packs, and players read it as a paywall (g2; g3; verdict). Managers sold this way are a warning, not a model.
5. Dhaba's VIP ×2 popup with a free reward matches a v4 beat at about 2.5 minutes. The 2019–20 guides describe a different game (g2 §6).

Eatventure, plus Kolibri's Idle Restaurant Tycoon (r5, g1, g2)

1. The ad contract wins ratings. "No forced ads" is the top praise from 2022 to Oct 2026, and Eatventure out-rates Idle Supermarket on Play, 4.7 to 4.1 (r5 §5).
2. Little text and no big tutorial: the visuals tell the story (Lessmore's 2022 interview, r5).
3. A renovation preview appears at about 3:00, and the first renovation comes at 5:30–6:30. The first city still takes days (g2 §2). Finishing feels like a promotion, and nothing is lost.
4. A fixed weekly calendar, with a weekend headline event and a mid-week race, is a cadence a small team can run. Events feed the main game through permanent items (r5 §2).
5. Idle Restaurant Tycoon is the closest analogue to Dhaba's twist: tables, waiters, a door counter of vacant tables and an overview of where money comes from. Its walkouts with no fix and its pathing bugs drew the angriest reviews (g1 §2).

Pizza Ready! (r6, r3, g1, corrections)

1. Start at once: no main menu and no complicated tutorial. Arrows and pads do the teaching (r6; verdict).
2. Everything is physical: cash lies on the floor and the stacks are visible. An upgrade the player can't see is a wasted purchase (r6 §7–8).
3. The player feels the chore first, then a hire arrives as relief. In its sibling My Perfect Hotel, something new arrives every 1–3 minutes for the first 12 minutes (r6 §3).

4. Scale is not love. It has about 400M lifetime installs and was India's #4 game by downloads in 2025 (r3; verdict). Yet its reviews are dominated by ad density, including Hindi reviews of ads every few seconds, and by a content ceiling (r6 §5; g3).
5. Since Nov 2025, staff carry food to the tables, and no review in g1's sample mentions it (g1). That validates Dhaba's twist but makes it less new. It only matters if the player can see it.

India's local-theme hits (r7, g3)

1. Recognition earns stars: real roads, named trucks, horns (r7 §2).
2. Truck and bus sim players already ask, unprompted, for a dhaba stop (r7 §2).
3. Shallow authenticity is punished: only the vehicles feeling Indian, empty scenes, identical cities, Hindi-only boards (r7 §3).
4. Problems that break the session decide 1★ reviews: won't start, MB, data, heat. Offline play is a selling point (g3, quotes 19–23).
5. The business fantasy translates: Hindi reviewers call Pizza Ready a game for people in business, and creators' hits are titled "I opened my own..." (r7; g3). But Hindi idle-tycoon videos get tiny audiences, so theme alone won't find players (g3).

(e) Dhaba Rush

Core promise. Run a busy highway dhaba that works by itself: lorries pull in, travellers eat on charpais, and money lands in the galla. You make it busier by spotting what is holding it back (seats, waiters, cooks or the galla) and fixing it with a tap or two.

Feel targets as observable moments, each checkable in a screen recording of a tester on their own phone. The first three minutes deliver. The feel breaks where the twist hides in panels, where a forced ad lands on a purchase, and where next steps run out.

When	Observable moment (pass)	Today (p0)	Source
First 10 s	A vehicle and a traveller move on screen. No menu, and no popup apart from Munshi-ji	Delivers: lorry at 0:00, traveller from 0:10	r6 §8; r2 #3
By 0:40	First sale, notes fly to the money pill	Delivers: about 0:37	r4 §10
By 1:00	The tester's own tap levels the chai and the counter reacts	Delivers: squash, sparkle, rising knock	p0 §6
1–3 min	A problem appears in the world and the fix shows there within 2–3 s: the new waiter takes the oldest plate, /min rises	Partly: waiters are hired in a full-screen panel	g1 #6; p0 §9
By 3:00	Every player meets the seats bottleneck once	Breaks: the beat fires in 3 of 6 seeds	g1 #7; p0 §8
Minutes 3–12	At least one new thing (build, dish, hire, table) in every 3-minute window	Delivers with ads. Without ads the kadai slips to minutes 15–17	r6 §3; p0 §2
Minute 8	Asked cold, the tester can name what is slowing the dhaba, the next buy and what will change	Checked by bots only	r1 §8; p0 §7
End of session 1	The tester leaves by choice, not because of an ad, and can say what they will come back for	Not tested	r1 §2; r2 #3
Day 2	On WELCOME BACK, COLLECT is the first tap and a purchase follows within seconds. Something is new today	Partly: nothing refreshes daily	r2 #6; g2 §6
Week 1	Before the last new dish (35–50 min of play), the tester has seen a priced next step and wants it	Breaks: there is no next place	g2 §6; r1 §8
Always	No forced ad interrupts a purchase, and every rewarded ad pays	Breaks from session 4: an interstitial 0.6 s after an upgrade	r6 §8; g3

KEEP / FIX / ADD / CUT. Priority: P1 = before 15 Dec, P2 = during soft launch, P3 = after.

KEEP

- K1 (P1) **The first-3-minute beat sheet**: sale at 0:37, upgrade ~0:45, hire ~1:10, each twist opened by a visible problem and closed in two taps. Smallest version: freeze it; change only what FIX names. r4 §10; r6 §8.
- K2 (P1) **The NEXT and PROBLEM chips, honest /min, before→after on HIRE.** Smallest version: as is. g3, implication 1; r2 §5; r4 §8.3.
- K3 (P1) **Seats and waiters as the bottleneck chain, whole orders on trays.** Smallest version: sim as is; FIX handles legibility. r1 §5; g1.
- K4 (P1) **Recognition.** Keep the lorries reversing into bays, the four Indian horns, charpais, the kettle on the bhatti, fairy lights and Devanagari boards. Smallest version: if they aren't there yet, add "Horn OK Please" to the first lorry and serve chai in small glasses. r7 §2, §6.
- K5 (P1) **The ad bubble as a gift.** FREE CASH in session 1; VIP appears only when the player taps. r2 #1; r4 §8.5; g3, implication 1.

FIX

- F1 (P1) **Interstitials.** Today they start in session 4 and fire 0.6 s after an upgrade. Smallest version: none within 60 s of a purchase, hire or reward. Never on WELCOME BACK or during a build beat. At most one every 3–5 minutes. Block rummy, real-money and dating ad categories. r6 §8 guardrail; g3, implication 2.
- F2 (P1) **Force the seats beat** for every player by injecting arrivals. g1 #7; p0 §8.
- F3 (P1) **Walkouts.** Today a door line of four gives up after 8 s, shown as LOST. Smallest version: make the door line lossless, with vehicles driving past when it is full. Or stretch the wait to 20–30 s with a ring over each head, and allow losses only when the fix is affordable. Show the cost as "+₹X/min with one more table". g1 #1.
- F4 (P1) **Hire where the problem is.** Tables already sell from a 2-tap card on the ghost. Smallest version: the same 2-tap HIRE card over the plates waiting on the pass; the new waiter lands there and takes the oldest plate. A new table seats the door line at once. g1 #6; r6 §8.1; p0 §9 #2.
- F5 (P1) **Put the twist on screen.** Smallest version: a painted board at the gate reading "Seats 6/8", a visible plate stack on the pass, and one "what's slowing us" line from the start rather than HISAAB after the kadai. g1 #2; r6 §8.4; p0 §9 #4.
- F6 (P1) **Rewarded ads always pay.** Smallest version: grant the reward if the ad fails. Hide the bubble when no ad is available or the phone is offline. Run the sim fully offline. g3, implication 3; r7, implication 2.
- F7 (P2) **The lever the tutorial teaches goes flat right after it.** Smallest version: when LEVEL UP isn't the limit, show its real /min gain and promote the bottleneck banner's button above it. p0 §9 #1; r1 §3 (Pecorella: if the newest generator always wins, the choices disappear); r6 (an upgrade you can't see is wasted).
- F8 (P2) **Price ladder.** Smallest version: Remove Ads priced below VIP (₹99–199) and a ₹10–49 starter, both labelled one-time and forever. No more offers after a purchase. r7, implication 4; g3, implication 4.

ADD

- A1 (P1) **A next step the player can see.** Smallest version: one renovation, "Dhaba → Family Dhaba with an AC hall", shown from about minute 3 as a locked card with a price and a before/after picture. It unlocks where new content now runs out (35–50 min), and the player chooses when. Levels reset; unlocked dishes and a permanent income multiplier carry over. Regional highways (Punjab, Rajasthan, the south) come later. g2 §6; r5 §5; r4 §8.7; r7, implication 7; r7 §6 (dhabas adding AC family halls).
- A2 (P2) **A daily reason to open.** Smallest version: a free crate on the first open each day, with fixed contents (minutes of takings) and no random draw. g2 §6.
- A3 (P2) **Life in the scene.** Smallest version: two or three seated idle animations (sipping, napping on a charpai, on the phone) and two more traveller types (a trucker, a family). r2 §5 (cosy players notice staff who just stand there); r7 §3, §6; p0 §6.
- A4 (P2) **Munshi-ji reacts to the player's fixes**, in short Hinglish lines. A new dish appears on trays and tables for the next few orders. r7, implication 5; g3, implication 5; r2 #7; p0 §9 #3, #5.
- A5 (P3) **A weekend event in the same dhaba**, such as a night mela or a wedding order, with its own goal track and one permanent reward. r5 §2; r3 §4.2; r2 §4.
- A6 (P3) **Waiter levels that show**: a bigger tray at milestones. g1 #4.

CUT

- C1 (P1) **Interstitials in the soft-launch build**, so D1–D7 can be read cleanly. Bring them back later as a test, under F1's rules. r5 §5; g2 §6; r3 §6.
- C2 (P1) **The red LOST tally**, replaced by F3. g1 #1.
- C3 (P2) **Copy that could read as real money**, such as "Earn ₹..." or "a company pays us". Use "bonus" and "collect" instead. g3, implication 4: Hindi reviewers call payout bait a trap.
- C4 (standing) **Paid manager cards, and any boost that brings more travellers than there are free seats.** g2 §6; g3, quote 16; g1 #14–15.

(f) The three biggest risks, and how to test each

Risk 1: the twist stays unreadable. Dhaba Rush is a logistics puzzle dressed as a numbers game, the root of "hard to understand" (p0 §4). Test: 6–8 new testers on their own phones, no coaching, screen recorded. At minute 8, ask r1's three questions: what is slowing the dhaba, what will you buy next, what will it look like after? Pass: at least three in four name seats or waiters and find the fix unaided. Also log the time from the first "food waiting" to the second waiter, and whether the seats beat fired.

Risk 2: there is no day 2. New content ends after 35–50 minutes and goals after 1–1.5 hours, the cliff reviews describe (p0 §5; r2 §3). Test: the same testers play freely for seven days with analytics on. Record sessions per day, opens on days 1 and 3, minutes to the last new dish, and a daily one-liner: why did you open it today? The group is too small for benchmarks, but nobody opening on day 3 is a clear signal. For context only, Lumikai calls 30% D1 and under 10% D7 too weak to scale in India (r2). Ship A1 and A2 as soon as they exist and compare.

Risk 3: the phone breaks the session. The game has never run on a phone; haptics, audio, touch, pinch, safe areas and cold start are unmeasured (p0 §8). Indian 1★ reviews lead with won't start, data and heat (g3). The installed base is ageing, as the 2026 memory squeeze keeps people on old 3–4 GB phones (r7, corrected). Test: first install it on a 3–4 GB Vivo, Redmi or Realme on Android 10–11 (r7, implication 1). Measure download size, cold start, heat after 20 minutes, and one full session in airplane mode. Then ask testers to report heat, stutter or data warnings, and confirm every rewarded ad paid out.

Dhaba Rush: design-first synthesis

Written 1 Nov 2026 from the eleven verified research files, with the verification corrections applied. Files are cited by prefix: r1 = r1_genre_anatomy.md, r2 = r2_player_motivations.md, r3 = r3_market_2026.md, r4 = r4_case_idle_supermarket_tycoon.md, r5 = r5_case_eatventure_kolibri.md, r6 = r6_case_pizza_ready_feel.md, r7 = r7_india_players_local_theme.md, g1 = g1_seated_service..., g2 = g2_timed_teardown..., g3 = g3_indian_players..., p0 = p0_dhaba_rush_today.md. Facts about the game come from p0 only. Review text is paraphrased.

(a) The core of the genre

A hands-off idle tycoon is a machine the player watches and tunes. Agents walk in, get served on a timer and pay. The player's only verb is tap, read a price, buy. Under that sits Pecorella's seesaw: production leads early, costs catch up, and threshold multipliers push production ahead again. So there is always something affordable and a visible next goal every few minutes (r1 §2, §8). The one real decision is which link in a bottleneck chain to fix. The best games make the binding link visible: red stats in Idle Supermarket Tycoon (IST), a door counter in Idle Restaurant Tycoon (IRT) (r4 §8, r5 §3). Each purchase changes the scene, not only a number (r2 #6, r4 §8). Above the minute loop sits a day loop: capped offline earnings, a reason to return, and a reset dressed as a new place with a multiplier (r1 §2, g2 §6). All of it is calm: no fail state, ads the player chooses, one popup per launch (r1 §8, r2 §7).

Decoration is everything else: vehicle variety, day/night, fairy lights, music, horns, Munshi-ji, dish names, chest and VIP styling. It sells the theme, but it cannot rescue a seesaw that stalls or a chain the player cannot read (r1 §8). One India caveat: decoration does not carry the loop, but it carries installs and 5★ text. Words like "real", "Indian" and "desi" appear in 75% of 4-5★ Bus Simulator India reviews against 43% of 1-3★ (r7 §2). Recognition gets players in; the core keeps them.

(b) What players look for, ranked

1. **Ads they choose, that always pay.** Ads appear in 46.8% of 1-3★ reviews in the India corpus, against 14.8% of 4-5★ (g3). Optional ads are Eatventure's most repeated praise across four years (r5, g2).
2. **A game that starts, runs and plays offline on their phone.** The top Hindi 1-3★ complaint is "won't start or loads slowly" at 12.6%; MB and data complaints add 7.0% (g3). The most-helpful review in that corpus (+31,148) praises offline play (g3).
3. **A calm screen with one obvious next thing.** A Hindi 1★ says everything runs by itself and they understand nothing (g3). Pop-up counts recur in 1-2★ reviews (r1 §5, r2 #3).
4. **Respect for their time, with money waiting on return.** Players praise playing five minutes or an hour without losing position (r2 #2). Kolibri's best ad placement is the return-to-double (r5 §4).
5. **A place they watch grow, where upgrades change what they see** (r2 #4, #6; r4 §8). Burger Please's stove upgrade that showed no visible change is the anti-pattern (r6 §3).
6. **Recognition and charm.** Indian roads, horns, named trucks, "add my state" (r7 §2). Truck and bus sim players ask, unprompted, for a dhaba stop (r7).
7. **Fair progress with no paywall.** 7.3% of India-corpus 1-3★ reviews say pay-to-win (g3). IST's v4 manager gate is its most-hated 2026 beat (g2, r4).
8. **Always a next place or event.** Hindi players write that they finished the game and ask for updates (g3). Kolibri's MVP lost players as soon as content ended (r5 §4).
9. **Something to think about.** The optimizer minority wants honest per-minute income, the binding station and the offline cap stated (r2 §5).
10. **It never loses their stuff.** Lost saves and updates that reset veterans are 1★ causes (r2 #8, #10).

(c) What they currently get, and the gaps

Need	What the leaders ship in 2026	Gap	Dhaba Rush today (p0)
Optional ads	Eatventure: none forced. IST, Pizza Ready: density creep, forced ads (r3, r6)	Few keep the promise	Rewarded bubble; interstitials from session 4, 0.6 s after an upgrade
Runs on low-end, offline	Android builds of 169-929 MB among the local hits and comps (r7)	Nobody sells "small and offline" on purpose	Never run on a phone; size unmeasured
Calm first session	IST v4 VIP popup at ~2.5 min; IRT season pass at ~9 min (g2)	Offers before trust	FREE CASH in session 1; VIP once a session from session 2
Readable bottleneck	IST red stats; IRT door counter (r4, r5)	Mostly in menus	NEXT/PROBLEM chip; HISAAB only after the kadai
Seated service	IRT walkouts hated; Pizza Ready's staff-served tables (Nov 2025) drew no reaction (g1)	Losses with no lever	Door line; LOST after 8 s
Day loop	IST first move at 9-25 min; Eatventure renovation at ~5:30, cities over days (g2)	Repetition after hour one (r3)	None; new content ends at 35-50 min
Fair meta	IST v4 manager cards from packs; Eatventure vault and gear, earned (r4, r5)	Pay gates	None (hidden)
Events	Weekly in every leader (r3)	Same events on repeat	None
Indian theme	No India-themed idle at scale; Chaiwala Tycoon 5K+ installs (r7, g3)	White space, untested demand	Strong

(d) Case study lessons

Idle Supermarket Tycoon (r4, g2)

1. The opening is the part players still like. A 2026 2★ says the tutorial is fun and little after it is (r4 §5). Copying the opening buys one session.
2. Legibility wins. Red stats name the binding link (r4 §8 #3).
3. A move feels like a promotion when it is previewed, priced and carries a cumulative multiplier (r4 §3). In v4 the first move comes at 9-25 minutes (g2). Moves forced before a place feels finished are resented (r1 §5).
4. Each retrofitted paid layer cost rating: Evolve timers in 2023, then manager cards from loot-box packs in v4 (from Feb 2026). English India-corpus reviews since v4 average 1.77★ (g3).
5. Dhaba Rush's x2 popup with a free reward is a v4 beat; the 2020 guides describe v1-3 (g2 §6). Copy v4's structure, the previewed move, not its monetisation.

Eatventure, with Kolibri's IRT as the closest twin (r5, g2, g1)

1. The ad contract is the rating gap: 4.7 on Play against IST's 4.1 (r5 §5).
2. Finishable units. A Before/After renovation preview appears at 3:00, the first renovation at about 5:30, and a city takes days (g2 §2).
3. Text-light onboarding: visuals tell the story, no big tutorial (r5 §2, quoting a 2022 interview).
4. The rewarded ad is a walking Investor character, and the permanent layer (vault, gear) is earned, not bought (r5).
5. Repetition is its top complaint: the same dishes in every city (r5). IRT adds the twin's lesson. Tables, waiters and cooks as connected bottlenecks work; walkouts with no lever, bad pathing and cleaners draw 1-2★ (r5 §3, g1 §2).

Pizza Ready (r6, r3, g1)

1. Instant start: no main menu and no complicated tutorial (r6, as corrected).
2. Everything physical: stacks, bills, pads. An upgrade you cannot see is a wasted purchase (r6 §7).
3. Something new every 1-3 minutes for the first 12 minutes (the My Perfect Hotel timeline, r6 §3).

4. The loop already reaches India in a foreign skin: #4 by downloads in India in 2025 (r3, r7). Hindi reviewers read it as a way to learn business (r7).
5. Its Nov 2025 switch to staff-served tables drew neither praise nor backlash; players notice ads, not who carries the food (g1). The waiter twist is validated but not novel. Players quit over ad density and a content ceiling (r6).

India local-theme hits (r7, g3)

1. Recognition sells: horns, named trucks, real roads (r7 §2).
2. Low-end and offline friendliness earns praise; heat, lag and storage words appear in 20-35% of the local sims' reviews (r7 §1).
3. "Add my state" is the commonest request (r7 §2). Regional variety is the natural new location.
4. Wrong or shallow authenticity is mocked: medu vada in a seafood level, empty scenes, identical cities (r7 §3).
5. Ads that gate the core loop, and a Remove Ads purchase that still shows ads, draw 1★ (r7 §3).

(e) Dhaba Rush

Core promise. You own a highway dhaba that runs itself: travellers park, sit on charpais, eat and pay while you decide what to fix next. Every rupee you spend shows up in the world, until a chai counter becomes the busiest stop on the highway.

What the seats-and-waiters twist does to the core

Bottleneck chain. The reference binds on department and checkout. Dhaba Rush has five links: seats, cooks, waiters, gallas and the arrival ramp. The ramp sets arrivals to the slowest of the other four (p0 §4). That is a real chain, and the chain is the genre's one real decision (r1 §8). It is also five places to get confused, which is the root of "hard to understand" (p0 §7).

Legibility. The chip turns the chain into one sentence, and it works (p0 §9). The world does not show the chain yet. The arrival ramp is off-screen. Waiter hires happen in a full-screen panel. The "what's slowing us" rows appear only after the kadai (p0 §9 #2, #4).

Money source. Throughput is hard-capped: 3 waiters, 5 tables, 2 gallas, arrivals at 19.5/min. Measured throughput plateaus near 17/min once the kadai lands (p0 §4). So the twist is the decision for roughly minutes 3-15, then a ceiling. After that, growth comes from LEVEL UP price, the least visible lever (p0 §9 #2). The twist sets the ceiling; price sets the growth.

Verdict: keep it, change it. Without it, Dhaba Rush is a reskin, and AppMagic and IGDA warn that copiers underestimate this genre's design (r4 §6). With it, the game has IRT's connected-bottleneck shape, which players accept when every bottleneck has a lever (g1 §2). Change four things. Make waiting lossless (g1). Show capacity in the world, not in panels (g1, r6). Add no more links: no cleaners, wages or quitting (g1 §2). And reopen the puzzle at each reset with a new layout, so the twist matters across the day loop and not only in minutes 3-15 (r1 §8, p0 §4).

Feel targets, as observable moments

1. Within 30 s of launch a lorry honks into a bay and a cook is visibly working (r7 §7).
2. Hire a waiter: within 3 s he takes the oldest plate off the pass and "/min" ticks up (g1 #6).
3. Buy a table: the door line sits on it within 2 s, and a gate board flips to "Seats 7/8" (g1 #2, #6).
4. A full pass looks full: stacked plates, readable without a number (r6 #4).
5. In the first 30 minutes the next affordable thing is never more than about 5 minutes away (r1 §8).
6. A dish unlock changes the counter and brings a new kind of traveller within 30 s (r2 #6, p0 §9 #5).
7. At minute 8 a tester can say what is slowing the dhaba, what they will buy next and what it will look like after (r1 §8).
8. Returning after 30+ minutes shows one screen, COLLECT, and nothing else (r2 #3, g3).
9. In sessions 1-3 the tester sees no ad they did not choose (r2 #1, r5).

KEEP / FIX / ADD / CUT

Overall order: FIX 1-5 before any ADD. Within each group, items are in priority order.

FIX

1. **Run it on a phone.** Smallest: one 3-4 GB Redmi, Vivo or Realme on Android 10-11; a 20-minute session; record cold start, frame time, heat, APK size and an offline launch. Aim for 150 MB or less (r7 §7, g3). The RAM split is Newzoo 2021; the 2026 memory squeeze means people keep older 3-4 GB phones longer (r7, as corrected).
2. **Interstitial timing.** Today they fire 0.6 s after an upgrade from session 4 (p0 §3). Smallest: off for soft launch behind a remote flag. If on: never within 60 s of a purchase, hire, reward or return screen; 3-5 minutes apart; 30 s or less; rummy and dating categories blocked (r6 §8, g3, r5).
3. **Walkouts.** Smallest: drop the 8 s LOST. Let the door line of 4 wait, and let vehicles drive past when it is full. Show "+₹X/min with one more table" instead of a red tally (g1 #1).
4. **Force the seats beat.** It fires in 3 of 6 seeds (p0 §8). Smallest: always inject arrivals (g1 #7; r5 §3 on Kolibri's stuck tutorial step).
5. **Show capacity in the world.** Smallest: a gate board "Seats 6/8"; plates stacking on the pass; on the waiter hire card, "One waiter ≈ 9 orders/min. You need ~12." After a STAFF hire, close the panel and show him pop in at the pass (g1 #2, #3, #6; p0 §9 #2).
6. **The economy seam.** LEVEL UP goes flat right after the lesson (p0 §9 #1). Smallest: ramp the step from the tutorial curve into the free-play curve over Lv 10-25 instead of switching (r1 §2, r4 §9 #1).
7. **Purchases that earn about +0.** SPEED or a cook off the bottleneck shows +0 (p0 §4). Smallest: label it "Not the bottleneck now" beside the honest number (r2 §5).
8. **Rewarded ads always pay.** Smallest: grant the reward if the ad fails, and hide the bubble when there is no fill (g3, r2 complaint 2).

KEEP

1. The first three minutes and the NEXT/PROBLEM chip (p0 §9, r4 §10).
2. Honest "/min" and before → after on every hire (p0 §9, r2 §5).
3. Seats and waiters, changed as above (r1 §5, r5 §3, g1).
4. FREE CASH in session 1 and VIP once a session from session 2 (r2 #1, g3).
5. Offline earnings, with the 2-hour cap stated on the WELCOME BACK screen (g2 §6, r2 §5).
6. The recognition layer: horns, lorries in bays, charpais, tandoor, Munshi-ji in Hinglish (r7 §2, §7).
7. The juice, with timers and the chip kept plain and readable, since juice lifts ratings but not understanding (r6 §6).

ADD

1. **A day loop: renovate first, move later.** Smallest for 15 Dec: a locked, priced RENOVATE card in BUILD from about minute 10, with a Before/After picture (g2 §6, r5). When the content runs out (35-50 min), the player may renovate. Levels, staff and tables reset. A cumulative income multiplier and a new look (an AC family hall, a bigger board) stay. The family hall adds seats far from the pass, so waiters matter again (r4 §3; r7 §6 notes real dhabas added AC halls). Offer it, never force it (r1 §5). After launch, a second highway in a new state with its own menu (r7 §7, r5 §5).
2. **A 24-hour return hook.** Smallest: a named regular trucker who comes once a day and pays a big bill (g2 §6; p0 §9 #3 notes no regulars; r7 §6 notes owners feed regulars).
3. **A bottleneck readout from minute one.** Smallest: four rows (seats, cooks, waiters, gallas), green or red, before the kadai (r4 §8, g1 #2).
4. **A Remove Ads price below VIP.** Smallest: Remove Ads at ₹99-199, VIP x2 at ₹299, both labelled "one-time, forever", no further offers to buyers (r7 §7, g3).
5. **A weekly event, after soft-launch D1 data.** Smallest: a weekend wedding-party bus, sized to free seats, paying a bonus (r3 §4, r5; g3 on rushes that exceed capacity).
6. **Bustle.** Smallest: two more traveller types tied to unlocks (r7 §6 traps; p0 §6 thin spots).

CUT

1. The interstitial 0.6 s after an upgrade (r6, g3).
2. The red LOST tally (g1).
3. Any plan for manager card packs or paid gates (r4, g2, as corrected).
4. New chain links: cleaners, wages, staff quitting (g1).
5. Bare Lv 150-300 milestone bumps as goals, once RENOVATE exists (p0 §5, r1 §4).

(f) The three biggest risks, and how to test each with soft-launch testers

1. It fails on the phone. The game has never run on one (p0 §8). For Indian players, failing to start or load is the top Hindi complaint (g3), and heat, lag and storage fill 20-35% of local-sim reviews (r7). *Test:* do FIX 1 before any tester sees it. Then ask each tester for phone model and RAM. Log time from icon tap to first sale. After 20 minutes, ask whether the phone got hot or lagged. Run one session in airplane mode. *Pass (proposed):* every tester reaches the first sale, nobody reports heat, and the game launches offline.

2. The twist is still hard to read. The 21 Oct testers said it was hard to understand, and every fix since was verified by headless bots only (p0 §7). Kolibri found real players stuck at one early step (r5 §3). *Test:* 5-8 new testers, screen-recorded, no help. At minute 8, ask r1's three questions: what is slowing the dhaba, what will you buy next, what will it look like after. Mark every pause over 10 s and where it happened. Note whether the seats beat fired. *Pass (proposed):* most testers name the real bottleneck and the next buy. Repeat after FIX 3-5.

3. The day cliff. New content ends at 35-50 minutes and goals at about 1-1.5 hours, with no reset (p0 §5). Kolibri's MVP lost players when content ended (r5 §4), and IST now moves players at 9-25 minutes (g2). *Test:* let testers play freely for three days with analytics consent. Log sessions per day, the minute each session ends, and D1 and D3 returns. On day 3, ask why they last opened it and why they stopped. If RENOVATE ships, log who takes it and who returns afterwards. With a small pool, treat numbers as directions only. Reference points: top-10% idle D1 was 45.6% in GameAnalytics' 2020 study (r3), and Lumikai says 30% D1 with under 10% D7 is not enough to scale in India (r2).

Dhaba Rush: market-first synthesis

1 Nov 2026. Lens: what an Indian Android player can already download today. Sources are the research files in this folder, cited by prefix: r1 genre anatomy, r2 player motivations, r3 market 2026, r4 Idle Supermarket Tycoon (IST), r5 Eatventure and Kolibri, r6 Pizza Ready and feel, r7 India and local theme, g1 seated service, g2 minute-3-to-day-3 teardown, g3 Indian players' reviews, p0 Dhaba Rush today. Facts about the game come only from p0. Corrections from the verification pass are applied; for example, IST's 2026 managers are treated as a paywall, not a success.

(a) The core

The core of a hands-off idle tycoon is a loop the player watches and a choice the player makes. Customers walk in, get served on a timer and pay. Money arrives on its own. The player spends it on whichever part is slowest. Four things must hold. There is always something affordable and a visible next goal every few minutes (r1, Pecorella's seesaw). The bottleneck binds where the player can see it, and one tap relaxes it (r1, r4 §8). The place visibly grows when money is spent (r2, r4 §8). And there is a day scale: capped offline earnings, a reason to come back tomorrow, and a next place or reset that feels like a promotion (r1 §8, g2 §6). All of it stays calm: no fail state, no forced interruption, one popup at a time (r1 §8, r2). In India one more thing sits inside the core, not around it: the session has to start, run and pay out on an ordinary phone without data. "Won't start or loads slowly" is the top Hindi 1–3★ complaint, at 12.6% (g3).

Decoration is the vehicles, day/night, fairy lights, the music loop and horns, Munshi-ji, dish names, and chest and popup styling. Decoration does not rescue a weak core (r1 §8). But in this market decoration earns the install. "Real", "Indian" and "desi" appear in 75% of 4–5★ Bus Simulator India reviews against 43% of 1–3★ (r7). Inside idle-game reviews, India or Hindi themes come up in only 0.3% of reviews in either star band (g3). Read together: the theme brings people in; the core decides whether they come back.

(b) What players look for, ranked

Indian Android evidence (g3, r7) is weighted above US App Store text.

1. **A game that starts, runs and pays on my phone, offline.** Top Hindi 1–3★ codes: won't start or loads slowly 12.6%, MB/data/"needs net" 7.0% (g3). The most-helpful review in g3's corpus (+31,148) praises Pizza Ready as an offline game. Lag, heat and storage words appear in 20–35% of local-sim reviews (r7).
2. **Ads I choose, that always pay.** Ads appear in 46.8% of 1–3★ reviews against 14.8% of 4–5★ (g3). "No forced ads" is Eatventure's most repeated praise across four years (r5). Rewards that fail are a separate complaint (r2, g3 quotes 14–15).
3. **Calm time-pass with one obvious next thing.** Relaxing / time-pass / satisfying is the top positive code in 4–5★ reviews, at 10.7% (g3). "13 game pop ups in one hit" is a typical quit reason (r2).
4. **Knowing what my job is.** A Hindi 1★: "I understand nothing; everything runs by itself" (g3 quote 1). Kolibri's soft launch found players stuck at one tutorial step (r5). Dhaba Rush's own testers said "hard to understand" on 21 Oct (p0 §7).
5. **A place I watch grow, and upgrades I can see.** Reviewers praise upgrades that are "not just a stat boost" (r2); visible change on upgrade is one of IST's seven strengths (r4 §8).
6. **A next place or event.** "I finished the game; update soon" (g3 quote 30); "maxed out level 11" (r6); one-year players name weekly challenges (r2 §4).
7. **Fair progress, no paywall.** Price or real money appears in 20.7% of 1–3★ reviews, pay-to-win in 7.3% (g3). IST's English reviews since v4 average 1.77★ in g3's sample.
8. **Cheap, honest prices.** ₹930 for no ads was called "misleading", while an "x2 forever" item was praised as low-priced (g3). India IAP floors run ₹6–₹100 (r7, g3).

9. **Something to think about.** Optimizers want the bottleneck, cost against payoff and an honest per-minute number. Both cosy and optimizer players judge the sim's pathing (r2 §5, g1).
10. **Recognition.** Indian reviewers welcome the first Indian-themed restaurant idle (g3), and truck and bus sim players ask, unprompted, for a dhaba stop (r7). This drives installs more than reviews.

(c) What they currently get, and the gaps

Need	What the leaders ship (late 2026)	Gap
Runs on my phone, offline	Pizza Ready praised as offline (g3). Downloads: Indian Bikes 169 MB, Pizza Ready 221 MB, IST 241 MB, Truck Masters 598 MB (r7). "200 MB gone loading" (Lumber, g3)	Hygiene, not a moat: big builds still reach 10M+ when the game is wanted (r7). Failing it costs ratings.
Optional ads	Eatventure: optional only, 4.7★ on Play (r5). Pizza Ready: reviewers report an ad about every 60 s (r3). IST v4: x2 VIP offer at ~2.5 min (g2). IRT: one player counted 27 popups (g2)	Optional-only is rare among the titles Indians download most.
Day loop	IST v4: first move at 9–25 min, next store shown as a priced locked card (g2). Eatventure: renovation at 5:30, first city takes days (g2). Weekly events in every comp (r3)	Dhaba Rush has none. New content ends at 35–50 min (p0).
Fair meta	IST v4 managers from card packs (the age rating lists loot boxes), upgrade gate at ~26 min of recorded play (g2, corrections). Travel Center vault cap (r2)	Paywalls are the loudest veteran complaint.
Seated service	IRT: hosts, tables, waiters, cleaners; changelog is bug fixes only; pathing complaints (r5, g1). Pizza Ready: staff-served tables since 8 Nov 2025, no visible player reaction (g1)	Not novel. No one makes the chain both legible and lossless.
Indian theme	Pizza Ready #4 by installs in India in 2025 (r3). Local hits are driving sims and cooking games (r7). No India-themed idle above ~10K installs (g3)	White space. Demand for an Indian idle is unproven.
Prices	IAP ceilings on Play India ₹4,819–₹30,300 (g3). Pizza Ready No Ads ₹399 on iOS India (r6)	Western ladders converted to rupees.
Variety	"same food, same dishes, every other country" (Eatventure, r5)	A highway game has regional menus built in.

Table stakes in late 2026 (r3 §4, g2 §6). At launch: offline play, optional ads, one popup at a time, a next place shown early, offline earnings capped at 2–3 hours. In the first months: weekly events, a second location, a collection layer, a pass. Managers from card packs are common, and players hate them most (g2, g3).

(d) Case study lessons

Idle Supermarket Tycoon (Codigames), the reference

1. Dhaba Rush copied the v4 opening. The x2 VIP popup with a free reward at ~2.5 min appears in 2026 v4 videos and not in 12 minutes of a Feb 2025 v3.2.6 run (g2).
2. The opening is the part players still like. A 2★ review from Aug 2026: "the tutorial is fun but not really much fun after that" (r4). Copying the opening buys one session, not a week (r4 §10).
3. v4 shows the next store as a priced, locked card and moves the player at 9–25 min (g2). A long horizon on the HUD was one of its original strengths (r4 §8).
4. Do not copy the 2026 meta. Managers arrived with v4 in early 2026, come from card packs and gate department upgrades. US reviewers read this as a paywall, and Play sits at 4.0–4.1 against iOS 4.6 (r4, corrections, g3).
5. The red bottleneck readout turns buying into a puzzle (r4 §8). Dhaba Rush's PROBLEM chip already does this (p0).

Eatventure (Lessmore)

1. Optional-only ads, every year since 2022, are the main reason it outrates IST, 4.7 against 4.1 on Play (r5 §5).

2. Finishable units: a Before/After renovation preview at 3:00, the renovation at 5:30, a first city that takes days (g2). A sale reads as finishing, not losing (r5).
3. A text-light start: "no long texts, no big tutorial", with visuals that tell the story (r5; quote verified).
4. The cheap part of its live ops is a fixed cycle: four weekend events in rotation and a weekly race (r5). Lessmore is now a 33-person Miniclip studio, so copy the cycle, not the cadence.
5. Its top complaint is sameness across cities (r5). Do not relabel the same four dishes per location.

Pizza Ready (Supercent)

1. Indian Android players already download this loop at scale: #4 by installs in India in 2025 (r3, r7). Hindi reviewers read it as a business fantasy (r7, g3).
2. It shipped staff-delivered service tables on 8 Nov 2025 with no visible praise or backlash; players notice ads, not who carries the food (g1). The waiter twist is not a selling point on its own.
3. An instant start: no main menu and no complicated tutorial; arrows and pads teach (r6, corrected).
4. Its feel comes from physical money and purchases that happen in the world. Burger Please's stove upgrade with no visible change is the anti-pattern (r6).
5. It loses stars on ad cadence and on its content ceiling (r6). Players forgive a lot when it runs offline (g3).

India's local-theme hits (Indian Bikes Driving 3D, Truck Masters, Bus Simulator India, Masala Express, Indian Cooking Star)

1. Recognition is the hook: real roads, horns, named trucks, "add my state" (r7).
2. Shallow authenticity is punished: reviewers say nothing but the vehicles feels Indian, that every city feels the same, and mock regional mix-ups (r7). Bustle counts as much as props.
3. Low-end and offline play are praised by name: "runs smooth on low-end phones", "best offline game" (r7).
4. Ads that gate the core loop, and a Remove Ads that does not remove ads, draw the angriest reviews (r7).
5. The theme is unproven for idle: Chaiwala Tycoon has 5K+ installs and Idle Indian Restaurant 10K+ (g3). Indonesia's Warung Seblak passed 500K downloads in a month but rates ~2.6★ (r3). A local theme gets installs; quality keeps the rating.

(e) Dhaba Rush

Core promise. You own a highway dhaba that runs itself: trucks pull in, charpais fill, trays go out and the galla fills while you decide what to fix next. You can always see what is slowing the dhaba, one tap fixes it, and the dhaba visibly grows from session to session.

Feel targets, as moments a tester can be seen to reach

1. First sale by ~0:40 and a first purchase by ~0:50, with no offer before it (p0; g3 impl. 1).
2. At minute 3 the tester can point to the next big goal and its price (g2 §6).
3. Hiring a waiter: the panel closes, he drops in at the pass, takes the oldest plate, and "/min" rises within 3 s (g1 #6).
4. Buying a table: the door line sits down within 1 s and a gate board flips to "Seats 7/8" (g1 #2, #6).
5. At minute 8 the tester can say what is slowing the dhaba, what they will buy next, and what the dhaba will look like after (r1).
6. No ad of any kind starts within 60 s of a purchase (r6).
7. Back after an hour: one screen, COLLECT, an optional x2, nothing else (r2, r5).
8. After 20 minutes on a 3–4 GB phone, the phone is not hot and frames do not stutter (r7).
9. Unprompted, the tester calls it "real" or "desi", or names a detail: the horn, the tandoor, the charpai (r7).

KEEP (works and matches the market)

#	Item	Why	Source
K1	The first-3-minute tempo: sale 0:37, hire ~1:10, tandoor ~3:00	Same cadence as the leaders' openings	p0, r6, r4
K2	NEXT and PROBLEM chips, honest "/min", before → after on HIRE	IST's red readout; optimizers want honest numbers	p0, r4 §8, r2 §5
K3	Rewards paid as minutes of takings, in cash, never as crowds	An ad that brings more travellers than seats is wasted	p0, r6, g3 quote 16, g1
K4	Offline: 2 h cap, COLLECT first, x2 only after 30 min	Inside the 2–3 h market band; 1 h caps are hated	p0, g2, r5
K5	Remove Ads kills every interstitial	"Still getting ads after paying" is a classic 1★	p0, r7
K6	Horns, charpais, kettle on the bhatti, Hindi boards, fairy lights	Recognition sells installs. Check the first 3 minutes against r7's list (Horn OK Please, rotis slapped into the tandoor, chai in glasses)	p0, r7 §7

FIX (all before soft launch)

#	Problem	Smallest version	Source
F1	Never run on a phone	One release build on one 3–4 GB Vivo, Redmi or Realme on Android 10–11: record download size, cold start, frame time, heat over 20 minutes, and one session in airplane mode	p0 §8, r7 §7, g3
F2	Interstitials fire 0.6 s after an upgrade from session 4	Off for the soft launch. If they return: never within 60 s of a purchase, never on return, build or tutorial, 30 s or less, rummy, real-money and dating ad categories blocked	p0 §3, r6, g2 §6, g3 impl. 2
F3	The seats beat fires in 3 of 6 seeds	Inject arrivals until the door line forms, every time	p0 §8, g1 #7, r5
F4	Travellers give up after 8 s ("LOST")	A lossless door line; or give-up at 20–30 s with a ring over the head, only when a table is affordable	p0 §3, g1 #1
F5	LEVEL UP goes flat right after the tutorial	One price and cost curve across the tutorial boundary	p0 §9, r1 §8, r4 §9
F6	Rewarded-ad failure handling is not described in p0	Grant the reward if the ad fails or times out; hide the bubble when offline or unfilled	g3 impl. 3, r2
F7	Money words	Check that "FREE CASH" and "Earn ₹..." cannot read as real money; reviewers resent rummy ads and "payout" lures [inference]	g3 impl. 2, 4 and 7

ADD

#	Item	Smallest version	When	Source
A1	Seat count at the gate	A board reading "Seats 6/8", visible from the home camera	Before	g1 #2, r5 (IRT door counter), p0 §9
A2	Purchases that land in the world	After HIRE, close STAFF and pan to the pass for the pop-in and first plate	Before	g1 #6, r6, p0 §9
A3	A day-scale promise	A priced, locked RENOVATE card visible from minute 3. At the end of current content (35–50 min) it resets counter levels for a shown multiplier and a new look, e.g. an AC "Family Hall"	Before (this version)	g2 §6, r5, r4 §8, r7 §6
A4	An honest store listing	English-first with Hinglish, "apna dhaba" framing, screenshots of real play, Hindi keywords such as "बिज़नेस गेम" and "dhaba game"	Before	g3 impl. 5 and 7, r2
A5	A cheap first offer	A one-time ₹10–99 starter; Remove Ads at ₹99–199, below VIP ₹299; label both "one-time, forever"; stop offers to VIP buyers	First update, or before if store setup allows	r7 §7, r2 §6, g3 impl. 4
A6	A second dhaba on a new highway	Same four counters, a regional menu and palette (e.g. Rajasthan), carry-over shown before the move	After	r5, r7 §7, g2

#	Item	Smallest version	When	Source
A7	One weekend event	Wedding catering or a mela on the existing map, with a keep-forever reward	After	r5, r3 §4, g2
A8	Waiter milestones that change carry	A bigger tray at milestones, not only +5% speed	After	g1 #4
A9	A walking ad character	Replace the wall bubble only if soft-launch bubble taps are low	After	r5, r6

CUT, and do not copy

#	Item	Source
C1	IST v4 managers from card packs, loot boxes, research tokens. Keep managers hidden; if delegation comes later, make it earnable with visible progress	corrections, g2, r5 (Super Manager 2.0)
C2	Ad boosts that bring a traveller surge (IST's bus, IRT's taxi)	g1, g3 quote 16
C3	Timers on instant actions, vault caps, salaries, staff who quit	r4 §9, r2, r5
C4	More than one popup per launch; offer stacks on return	r1 §8, r2, g2
C5	Western price ceilings converted to rupees	r3 §5, g3
C6	Real brand logos or gameplay that is not in the game in ads; data-indexing SDKs	r6, g3
C7	Hindi-only text, caricatured dirt, regional mix-ups, child waiters	r7

(f) Three biggest risks and how to test them

1. The content cliff. New content ends at 35–50 min and goals at ~1–1.5 h (p0). Kolibri's early Idle Miner MVP lost players as soon as they finished the content (r5; c. 2019 data). Every comparable title ships a move or renovation plus events (r3, g2). *Test.* In soft-launch analytics, log the minute each player reaches the kadai, the last dish, and the end of the chip ladder, and split day-1 return by whether they got there. On day 2, ask five testers why they did or did not open the game. Pass: players who reached the end return at least as often as those who did not. Benchmarks: GameAnalytics 2026 D1 median ~22%, top 10% ~40% (r3); Lumikai calls 30% D1 with sub-10% D7 not enough to scale in India (r2).

2. Real Indian phones and networks. The game has never run on a phone. Haptics, audio, touch, safe areas and the cold start are unmeasured (p0). Load and data failures lead Hindi 1–3★ reviews (g3). The newest public RAM split is from 2021, and 2026 memory prices are making people keep older 3–4 GB phones longer (r7, corrections). *Test.* Give the build to five testers with 3–4 GB phones on Android 10–12, plus one 2 GB phone if one exists. Record download MB, time from icon tap to first sale, crashes, heat after 20 minutes, and one session in airplane mode including the offline payout. Pass: no crash, first sale within about a minute of the tap, full play offline.

3. The twist reads as confusion, not as the game. Testers said "hard to understand" (p0 §7), and every fix since was checked only by headless bots (p0). Indian players read "it runs by itself" as confusion when they do not know their job (g3). The waiter twist has no novelty value of its own (g1), so it earns its place only if it is legible. *Test.* Five fresh testers, no coaching, screen-recorded. At minute 8 ask r1's three questions. Note whether they found the waiter hire unaided, whether the seats beat fired, and whether they tapped the ad bubble. Pass: four of five name the bottleneck (seats, waiters, cooks or galla) and their next buy.

Recruit testers who look like the market: Android, mostly outside the metros, mixed gender. India's gamers are 44–45% women and 60–66% non-metro (r2 §6).